

Fiat CR.32 Aces of the Spanish Civil War



Alfredo Logoluso

OSPREY AIRCRAFT OF THE ACES • 94

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Front Cover

During the afternoon of 23 May 1938, Maggiore Pilota Armando François led 28 CR.32s from his XVI Gruppo Caccia of the 'Aviazione Legionaria' on an interdiction patrol over the Balaguer bridgehead in Catalonia in support of the Spanish Nationalist Army's offensive. The Italian formation consisted of 12 fighters from 24^a Squadriglia, led by Capitano Luigi Bianchi, nine machines from 25^a Squadriglia, led by Capitano Roberto Fassi, and seven CR.32s from 26^a Squadriglia, led by Capitano Vincenzo La Carubba.

An aerial clash had already taken place over the frontline earlier that day between CR.32s escorting S.79 and BR.20 bombers and Nationalist Polikarpov I-15s and I-16s that had attempted to attack the latter aircraft. As the Fiat fighters of XVI Gruppo Caccia approached the bridgehead to escort the last of the S.79s home, the bombers were set upon by 27 I-16s of Republican Grupo 21. Diving on the Italian aircraft from 19,000 ft, the Republican machines enjoyed a height advantage over the CR.32s. Nevertheless, Maggiore Pilota Armando François successfully led his fighters against the enemy machines. Indeed, the XVI Gruppo Caccia pilots claimed five 'Ratas' (I-16s) destroyed and three more probably destroyed. Soviet patrol leaders Lt N I Marthishchenko from 2a Escuadrilla and Lt I I Turchin from 5a Escuadrilla, both of whom were flying newly delivered Tip 10 versions of the I-16 fighter, perished in this clash.

In return, XVI Gruppo Caccia lost two CR.32s in a mid-air collision while chasing an I-16 (their pilots were captured). Three biplane fighters were also damaged by enemy fire. One of the confirmed victories was credited to Maggiore François himself, taking his final tally in Spain to six. His aircraft was also shot up during the engagement (Cover artwork by Mark Postlethwaite)

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BLUE ARENA

During the week of 16-22 July 1936, the military coup in Spain organised by a group of right-wing generals and supported by monarchist and conservative nationalist sympathisers against a Republic born in 1931 and its recently elected government of *Frente Popular* escalated into a full-scale civil war. Spanish army officers had long been critical of the socialist politicians running what they felt was a corrupt and ineffective administration that had only just scraped into power. To this day, historians view the Spanish Civil War as the prelude to the wider conflict of World War 2.

The initial success that the coup registered in the Canary Islands, occupied by the leader of the Nationalist movement, Gen Francisco Franco, and in the Moroccan Spanish Protectorate, where the latter could count on the support of the *Tercio Extranjero* (Spanish Foreign Legion), was not reflected over the vastly populated territories of the Iberian Peninsula. In fact the Republican *Frente Popular* Government found that it could rely on the support of much of the armed forces and the police, which in turn allowed it to retain control of the capital, Madrid. The port of Barcelona and major cities and ports as far away as Valencia in the east also remained loyal to the *Frente Popular*. Support for the Republican cause was also forthcoming from trade unions and socialist political organisations, including contemporary 'revolutionary' ones, across Spain, thus preventing the Nationalists from assuming military control.

Although the coup had failed to topple the *Frente Popular*, by late July large parts of continental Spain were under Nationalist control thanks in the main to support from significant sections of the civilian population. Southern cities such as Seville, Córdoba, Granada and Cadiz, in Andalusia, as well as in the traditionally nationalist north-central regions and provinces of Galizia, León, Navarra, Burgos, Salamanca and Valladolid all backed the rebels. Conversely, vast areas rich in economic and industrial resources remained faithful to the Republic, where the existing armed forces, supported by communist, anarchic and socialist militiamen, maintained control of the territories and cities after having quelled the rebels' attempts to unseat the government.

In the very early stages of the coup, the opposing sides had sent out urgent requests to sympathetic foreign countries for military aid, with the supply of aircraft featuring most prominently. For example, on 20 July the newly appointed Prime Minister of the Spanish Republic, José Giral, approached the French 'Popular Front' government for aeroplanes to help it eradicate the threat posed by the Nationalists. The Spanish *Aviación Militar* was already primarily equipped with French-designed machines such as the Nieuport-Hispano Ni-H.52 sesquiplane fighter, numerous examples of which had been built under licence in Spain from 1929, and the Breguet 19 reconnaissance bomber. France quickly prepared to send more modern aircraft to its neighbour, these being primarily surplus Potez 540 twin-engined bombers and Dewoitine D.372 monoplane (parasol) fighters.

Soviet and international communist organisations such as the *Komintern* and *Profintern* were also mobilised in Moscow and Prague in order to plan and provide substantial aid (including hundreds of modern Polikarpov fighters and Tupolev bombers) against forces that were menacing the Spanish Republic. In addition to the creation of funds and recruitment of military volunteers from several countries, a nucleus of airmen was organised to leave for Spain.

Once rebel leaders, and Gen Franco in particular, realised that they could not rely on the support of the *Aviación Militar*, they too requested both pilots and aircraft from the Fascist governments of Italy and Germany, with whom they had had contact whilst conspiring against the Republic. On 25 July Italian dictator Benito Mussolini ordered the transfer of 12 SIAI S.81 tri-motor bombers by air and the shipping of 24 CR.32 fighters to Spanish Morocco to aid the Nationalists. In order to disguise the supply of these aircraft, the deal between Italy and the Nationalists was listed as a 'private sale'. As part of this ruse, Italian pilots and ground personnel were enrolled on a voluntary basis into the *Tercio Extranjero* with false identities. That same evening, German Chancellor Adolf Hitler authorised the transfer of 20 Ju 52/3m bomber-transport, and their crews, to a commercial company expressly formed to carry Gen Franco's African troops from Morocco to Spain. These aircraft were to be escorted by six He 51 fighters, with support personnel for both German types being despatched by sea.

While the supply of weaponry from other European countries was being organised, the Nationalists and Republicans busied themselves consolidating their respective positions in Spain as the nation's military forces were divided between them. The most formidable of those were the Moroccan troops and *Tercio* legionnaires loyal to the Nationalists. Most of the army and navy in Spain itself remained loyal to the Republic following a thorough purge of right-wing officers, many of whom were removed from their commands or executed.

In Madrid, the Republican Government was forced into reorganising the army so that its ranks could be bolstered through the integration of a popular emergency militia. The latter saw the arming of both civilians and the militant elements of political parties that had mobilised themselves against the revolt.

The same thing happened in Barcelona and in the region of Catalonia, where anarchic militants had prevailed. Militias loyal to the government were also armed in the northern provinces on the Basque and Cantabrian coast when the Republican strongholds of Bilbao, Santander and Gijón became detached from the rest of Republican Spain after rebel Nationalist forces took control of the north-central territories. These northern provinces were cut off by substantial numbers of Nationalist troops in western Aragon, as well as within the region's three major cities, Saragossa, Huesca and Teruel. The major Balearic island of Majorca was also Nationalist territory, while neighbouring Minorca remained under Republican control.

Much of the Spanish navy had also stayed loyal to the government, and this included the main naval base of Cartagena, on the Mediterranean coast. The merchant fleet duly followed suit, and it was because of this that the Nationalists' 'African Army' had to be flown from

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Spanish Morocco to Andalusia by the Ju 52/3ms hastily transferred to North Africa from Germany.

At the start of hostilities in July 1936, the Republican-controlled *Aviación Militar* could field around 500 aeroplanes of various types, nearly all of which were of foreign design dating from 1921 to 1928. The majority of these aircraft hailed from France, England, Germany and Italy, and they had been built in Spain under licence. As previously mentioned in this chapter, the most abundant machines in Spanish service at this time were the 160 Breguet 19 single-engined, two-seat sesquiplane reconnaissance-bombers and around 70 Ni-H.52 single-seat sesquiplane fighters.

Following the coup, the Nationalists had taken possession of 110 military aircraft, including 60 Breguet 19s and 12 Ni-H.52s. The Republican Government retained control of the remaining 80 percent of the existing aeroplanes. There were close to 600 military pilots in Spain in July 1936, 400 of which served with Republican units. Half of these men, however, did not see action as pilots during the Civil War due to their questionable loyalty. Some were dismissed, others were relegated to secondary duties and several ended up in front of a firing squad. A significant number simply deserted or defected to the Nationalist cause. Of the 200 who initially pledged their allegiance to the rebel cause, around 50 were kept from flying again due to their dubious political beliefs. As a result of this situation, both sides were forced to immediately mobilise civilian aviators and hastily recruit foreigners.

FIRST *TERCIO* FIGHTERS

At dawn on 14 August 1936, the Italian freighter *Nereide* entered the port of Melilla, on the Mediterranean coast of Spanish Morocco. This important town had been occupied four weeks earlier by Nationalist forces led by Gen Franco himself. The vessel's precious cargo consisted of 12 CR.32s, which had been embarked in the Italian port of La Spezia a week earlier.

As well as spare parts for the Fiat fighters, the ship had also transported 18 volunteers from the *Regia Aeronautica* to North Africa, their passports bearing false details. Amongst them were the first 12 Italian fighter pilots to arrive on Spanish territory. They were led by Capitano Vincenzo Dequal (alias Paride Limonesi) of 1° *Stormo Caccia Terrestre* (CT), *Squadriglia*, and his flight leaders were Tenente Vittor Ugo Ceccherelli (alias Vaccarese), also of 1° *Stormo* CT, Tenente Ernesto Monico (alias Preti) of 4° *Stormo* CT and Sottotenente Giuseppe Cenni (alias Stella) of 1° *Stormo* CT. The remaining enlisted pilots were Sergente Maggiore Giuseppe Avvico (alias Nannini) of 4° *Stormo* CT, Sergente Maggiore Bruno

This photograph, taken aboard the steamer *Nereide* in the Italian port of La Spezia on 7 August 1936, shows all the personnel from the first CR.32 *squadriglia* to be sent to Spain. The three men in the top row are, from left to right, pilots Presel, Magistrini and Castellani. Standing, from left to right, are two groundcrew and pilots Monico, Dequal, Giuglietti and Avvico. In the middle row, from left to right, is another groundcrewman, pilot Cenni, yet another groundcrewman and pilots Ceccherelli and Boetti. Finally, in the foreground, from left to right, are two more groundcrewmen and pilots Salvadori and Patriarca (*Dequal Family archive, via Associazione 4° Stormo*)



One of first 12 CR.32s delivered to Spanish Morocco aboard the Italian steamer *Nereide* is carefully unloaded in Melilla harbour during the morning of 14 August 1936. Despite the Fiat fighter's questionable modernity by the second half of the 1930s, the CR.32 turned out to be particularly suited to combat in Spain. Flying from semi-prepared airfields in an ever-changing environment, the CR.32's robust construction served it well, while more modern fighters such as the I-16 that it opposed and the Bf 109 that fought alongside it often struggled. Apart from being able to withstand great punishment either in combat or in flying accidents, the CR.32 could also be easily repaired thanks to its numerous interchangeable structures and simple construction. Again, the wooden structure of the I-16 and metal stressed-skinning of the Bf 109 proved more time consuming to repair in the field. Proving this point, some 50 CR.32s were rebuilt using scrapped aircraft components during the course of the war. These aircraft helped to considerably reduce the overall losses suffered by CR.32 units during the war, increasing by 30 percent the number of operational machines (225 in total) available to Nationalist units at the end of the conflict. Rebuilding on this scale simply did not happen with the all-metal Bf 109 or wooden I-16 (Author archive)



Castellani (alias Ribaudi) of 6° *Stormo* CT, Sergente Maggiore Sirio Salvadori (alias Salvo) of 4° *Stormo* CT, Sergente Angelo Boetti (alias Ilacqua) of 1° *Stormo* CT, Sergente Adamo Giuglietti (alias Guglielmotti) of 1° *Stormo* CT, Sergente Giovanbattista Magistrini (alias Marietti) of 1° *Stormo* CT, Sergente Joseph Vincent Patriarca (alias Boccolari) of 4° *Stormo* CT and Sergente Guido Presel (alias Sammartano) of 6° *Stormo* CT. The groundcrew consisted of just three aircraft riggers and three mechanics.

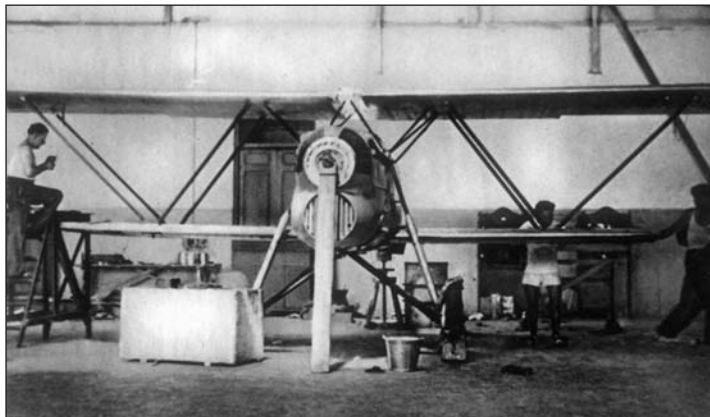
After being welcomed by Spanish officers and the local Italian Consul, the pilots and groundcrew were immediately enrolled into the *Tercio Extranjero* with their equivalent ranks. The S.81 crews that had flown to Melilla directly from Sardinia two weeks earlier had followed the same routine. The secrecy surrounding the bombers' flight had been exposed, however, when two of the tri-motors were forced to perform emergency landings in neighbouring French Morocco due to bad weather.

The CR.32s were assembled over the course of several days and eventually transferred by air to an airfield at Seville-Tablada, in southern Spain.

Towards the end of July nine of the S.81s, and their crews, formed the *Aviación del Tercio*, and they commenced combat operations from Spanish Morocco under the command of *Regia Aeronautica* Colonello Ruggero Bonomi (alias Francesco Federigi). The bombers were in turn subordinated to the head of the Nationalist air forces, Gen Alfredo Kindelán Duany, who took his orders from the commander of the African Army, Gen Franco. The 12 CR.32s were also integrated into this foreign legion air arm, the first fighter unit being led by Capitano Dequal,

The new squadron's initial operations consisted of patrols and single sortie missions as dictated by the particular operational requirements and limited efficiency of its aircraft. The CR.32 pilots struggled at first to have an impact on their Republican counterparts because only two of the dozen Fiat fighters in-theatre boasted compasses following a supply oversight in Italy! Unfamiliarity with Spanish terrain and inadequately detailed maps further compounded the unit's navigational problems when in the air, and the end result was pilot disorientation culminating in emergency landings and damaged aircraft.

From these less than auspicious beginnings, few could predict that the first 12 CR.32s that arrived on Spanish territory in August 1936 would be followed by more than 400 examples over the next two-and-a-half years. Moreover, the initial cadre of 12 Italian aviators that had arrived in Spanish Morocco on the *Nereide* would be joined by a further 600 fully trained fighter pilots from the *Regia Aeronautica* who saw combat for almost 30 months during the *Operazioni Militari Spagna* (military operations in Spain).



Once off-loaded from *Nereide*, the aircraft were taken to Melilla-Nador airfield and reassembled (Author archive)

The fighters had black Nationalist roundels painted onto their fuselage sides after being rebuilt. Black stripes were also applied to the undersides of the lower wingtips, as per Gen Franco's orders issued on 8 August 1936. However, Republican colours (red/yellow/purple) were also initially present in roundel form on both the upper and undersides of the top wing! These were replaced with black roundels a few days later when the aircraft transferred to continental Spain (Dequal Family archive via Associazione 4° Stormo)



Initially, the CR.32s were assigned defensive duties, patrolling overhead Nationalist forces in Andalusia and protecting them from aerial attack, as well as escorting S.81 bombers. The Italian biplanes also provided air cover for the infantry columns of the African Army that had been transported to Spain in the Ju 52/3ms. These troops were particularly vulnerable to attack from the numerically superior Republican air force in the early weeks of the war as they

advanced north, occupying western Extremadura. The African Army's next target was the Spanish capital, Madrid, which it intended to occupy so as to claim international recognition in favour of a new Nationalist administration.

At that time the Republican air force relied principally on its Breguet 19s and Ni-H.52s whilst other Spanish and 'international' units were being organised. The latter included the *Komintern's Escuadra Internacional* and the *Escuadra España*, which was organised by the French president of the International Anti-Fascist Committee, André Malraux. It was equipped with the first military aircraft to be sent from France, namely Potez and Bloch twin-engined bombers and Dewoitine, Loire and SPAD fighters. As these aircraft arrived in Spain, so too did pilots from France, Great Britain, the USA and the USSR, as well as countries in central and eastern Europe. All keen to fly for the Republic, they were joined by a handful of aviators who had previously fled the right-wing regimes in Italy and Germany.

French aircraft (either built in Spain or supplied directly) were to be the first adversaries faced by the CR.32 pilots, and units equipped with these machines were based principally around the capital (the Republicans also had a handful of Furies and a solitary Boeing 281). They were both well organised and well supplied with consumables such as fuel, ammunition and spare parts thanks to the fact that the bulk of Spain's arms and the aviation industries remained under Republican control.

The first aerial encounter between CR.32s and Republican aircraft came on 21 August 1936 over the city of Córdoba, in southern Spain, which had fallen into Nationalist hands the previous month. The rebel troops had subsequently come under repeated attack from the air by Republican aircraft, so a flight of three Fiat fighters was sent on detachment from Seville with orders to defend

the city. The CR.32s were led by Tenente Ceccherelli, and during the fifth scramble of the day on the 21st, he single-handedly engaged two Republican Ni-H.52s. The Italian pilot duly succeeded in shooting down one of the fighters, expending 172 7.7 mm rounds. A second CR.32 victory came on 27 August after Tenente Ceccherelli and Sergente Magistrini had been sent to the southern city of Granada to defend it from attack too.

Scrambling on his own, Magistrini shot down an Ni-H.52 that had been escorting Breguet 19 bombers heading for the city.

By then a further 12 CR.32s, and their pilots, had reached Melilla, three more had been sent to Majorca and nine were offloaded in the port of Vigo de Galicia, on Spain's Atlantic coast, from the Spanish ship *Ebro*. The latter had been renamed *Aniene* in Italy so that it could run contraband under a flag of convenience. Subterfuge such as this had become necessary in late August when an international agreement of 'non-intervention' was drawn up and subscribed to by 27 nations, including France, Great Britain, Germany, Italy and the Soviet Union. Signatories were legally prevented from supporting either side in the Spanish conflict through the provision of military equipment. Apart from Great Britain, whose special economic and strategic interests in Spain and the Mediterranean forced it to observe strict neutrality in its dealings with the Nationalist and Republican regimes, the agreement was duly ignored by the remaining four signatories.

The nine CR.32s delivered to Vigo de Galicia were unloaded on the night of 27 August, although the presence of a British naval vessel in the port at the same time meant that this operation could not be completed in secrecy. Nine pilots under the command of Tenente Dante Olivero (from 6° *Stormo* CT) were also on board *Aniene*, and each of them had a false identity. Amongst the aviators were Sottotenente Adriano Mantelli and Sergenti Bruno Montegnacco, Gianlino Baschiroto and Raffaele Chianese, while five groundcrew provided technical support. The men and their machines then travelled by train southwards along the Vigo-Orense-Salamanca-Caceres-Seville route, which was controlled by Nationalist forces that had recently occupied the eastern Extremadura to unite the occupied zones of southern and northeastern Spain. The reassembly of the nine aeroplanes, which were destined for the *Segunda Escuadrilla de Caza del Tercio* (second fighter *Squadriglia*), commenced after the three-day journey had ended in Tablada on 30 August.

Future ace Sergente Guido Presel flew his first combat sortie that same day. Born on 3 December 1913 in Trieste, Presel was studying industrial engineering when he was called up for military service with the *Regia Aeronautica* in April 1934. He received a Bronze Medal for Aeronautical Valour when he risked his life to save an aircraft from being destroyed



An early CR.32 assembled in Spanish Morocco and flown to Seville-Tablada airfield for the *Primera Escuadrilla de Caza de la Aviación del Tercio* serves as a backdrop for *escuadrilla* leader Capitano Vincenzo Dequal, Sergente Maggiore Angelo Boetti, Tenente Ernesto Monico and Sergente Bruno Castellani on 25 August 1936. A groundcrewman is sitting in front of the pilots. Most of the Italian airmen sent to Spain in the summer of 1936 already had about two years of flying experience with the CR.32 by the time they entered combat, these individuals being highly proficient at disciplined aerobatics and formation flying rather than navigation and aerial gunnery. This knowledge was duly passed on to their newfound Nationalist allies, and the latter quickly got to grips with the Fiat fighter. Spanish pilots were particularly enthusiastic about their new mounts in light of the problems that they had faced flying the less forgiving Heinkel He 51 biplane fighter. Indeed, future ranking ace Joaquín García Morato began leading formations of CR.32s on combat patrols after just 85 minutes of flight instruction, while fellow ace Capitán Ángel Salas felt so confident at the controls of the Italian fighter that he performed an outside loop during his first flight! It has also been reported that when Soviet Polikarpov fighters first appeared over Madrid in the autumn of 1936, German pilots requested (but were refused) that their He 51s be replaced by CR.32s (A *Emiliani archive*)



Sergente pilota Guido Carestiatto and his CR.32, which was one of three Fiat fighters unloaded at Palma de Mallorca by the Italian steamer *Emilio Morandi* and assembled during the night of 27-28 August 1936. The aircraft were then used to defend the Nationalist-controlled island from Republican air attacks. Indeed, Carestiatto shot down a Savoia-Marchetti S.62 flying boat of the *Aeronáutica Naval* at midday on 28 August near Punta Amer, on the east coast of Mallorca. This victory was denoted on the fin of Carestiatto's fighter through the addition of a small 'V'. This was one of the very few examples of victory markings being applied to Italian fighters during the Spanish Civil War. Code numbers and markings applied to the CR.32s based at Mallorca differed from those used in continental Spain, especially during 1936. For example, the bat worn by CR.32s and S.81 and S.79 bombers based on the island was a traditional symbol of Palma de Mallorca. The most successful CR.32 pilot to serve in the Balearic Islands during the Spanish Civil War was future World War 2 ace Leonardo Ferrulli, who claimed three SB bombers shot down between 7 October and 7 December 1937 whilst serving with 101ª *Squadriglia* of *X Gruppo Caccia Baleari* (A Emiliani archive)

by fire at the Grottaglie Flying School in Puglia in August 1934. He subsequently completed his flying course at the same school two months later. Having mastered the CR.20 fighter, Presel was sent on an advanced flying course at the Aviano Fighter School in Venezia Giulia, close to the base of Campoformido. The latter was home to 6° *Stormo Caccia*, which was equipped with the CR.32. Presel duly joined this unit in early

1936, and in the summer of that year he was one of the first, and most enthusiastic, volunteer pilots to be chosen for service in Spain.

On 30 August, Presel had taken off from Tablada as the lone escort for a Ju 52/3m that was heading for Nationalist northern Spain. As the pair neared Badajoz, on Spain's border with Portugal, a Republican Fury flown by Sargente Felix Urtubi Ercilla suddenly attacked the Junkers tri-motor. Presel immediately engaged the British fighter, whose pilot broke off his pursuit of the Ju 52/3m and concentrated on the Italian aircraft instead. What followed was a closely fought engagement between two evenly matched biplane fighters flown by determined and well-trained pilots.

Concentrating on each other, both men neglected to keep an eye on their fuel, or their location. The engine in Ercilla's aircraft fell silent first, and he was forced to land near Alburquerque, which was controlled by the Nationalists. Disguising himself as a farmer, he then had to walk for a week to reach Republican territory, keeping away from main roads and populated areas as much as he could. His Fury was recovered by Nationalist forces and pressed into service.

Presel, meanwhile, had lost sight of the Ju 52/3m during the fight, and lacking a compass in his CR.32, he found himself alone over unfamiliar territory. With the engine of his aircraft running on vapours, Presel had little choice but to make an emergency landing on Portuguese soil, damaging the undercarriage of the CR.32 in the process. Fortunately for him, the Portuguese government supported the Nationalist cause, so the aircraft was quickly recovered and Presel returned to Tablada.

With the Fury in Nationalist hands, this engagement could have been deemed a victory for Presel. His opponent, Ercilla, had gained notoriety five days prior to this action when he had shot and killed a Nationalist officer whilst flying a Breguet 19 from Spanish Morocco to Spain. Ercilla proceeded to land at Madrid-Getafe, where he promptly joined the Republican air force.

During the latter half of August 1936, Nationalist troops continued with their advance through Extremadura and New Castile in the direction of Madrid. Accompanying them was a flight of CR.32s from 1ª *Escuadrilla* under the command of Tenente Monico, these aircraft being sent to Cáceres for the defence of the local airfield and Gen Franco's General Headquarters, which had recently been established in the city.



This photograph, taken at Portalegre on 3 September 1936, shows the recovery of one of three CR.32s that accidentally landed in Portuguese territory 72 hours earlier. Incidents such as this were relatively commonplace during the early weeks of CR.32 operations in Spain primarily because the Italian pilots were unfamiliar with the local landscape. The fact that most of the Fiat fighters lacked compasses further exacerbated the navigational problems initially encountered by the Italian pilots (Author archive via US SM Aeronautica Militare)

Early ace Sergente pilota Guido Presel poses with his CR.32 at Seville-Tablada airfield in September 1936 (Dequal Family archive, via Associazione 4° Stormo)



On the same day (30 August) that Presel fought the Republican Fury, Cuatro Vientos, Monico and Castellani were bounced by a flight of three D.372 fighters between Talavera de la Reina and Oropesa whilst returning from a reconnaissance flight over the enemy airfields at Getafe and Cuatro Vientos. Monico's CR.32 quickly caught fire and the pilot took to his parachute (his aircraft crashed near Las Herencias), while Castellani force-landed near Villanueva de la Serena and returned to friendly territory on foot. Monico was not so fortunate, being taken prisoner by militants retreating towards Talavera. Declaring his proper nationality shortly after his capture, he requested to see the Italian ambassador in Madrid. This was refused, however, and Monico was executed shortly thereafter. He was the first Italian pilot to lose his life in action during the Spanish Civil War. When his fate became known some days later, the inscription *MONICO! PRESENTE* ('Monico is Present') was applied to all the CR.32s flown by both *Tercio* fighter units.

On 4 September Nationalist forces occupied Talavera and its local airfield some 60 miles to the southwest of Madrid just as a new Republican Government was being formed in the capital city. Socialist Largo Caballero duly became prime minister, heading a cabinet that included communist ministers for the very first time.

Two days later, future ranking Spanish Civil War ace Capitán Joaquín García Morato became flight leader of the *Tercio's* 1^a *Escuadrilla*. Born on 4 May 1904 in Melilla, Spanish Morocco, to parents that hailed from Malaga, he entered the Military Academy at Toledo at a young age and eventually returned to Spanish Morocco to serve as a lieutenant in the infantry in 1923. European colonisers and Muslim locals were in conflict at this time, so García Morato found no shortage of action during his first operational posting.

Although of modest stature, he was blessed with an outgoing character that quickly earned him the respect of those he served with. He also displayed an innate sense of authority, leading his men by example rather than through the authoritarian imposition or military rank.

In 1925 García Morato obtained his civil and military flying licences, and that same year he undertook his first operational missions in Morocco in DH 9A light bombers against guerrillas loyal to the Muslim leader Abd-El-Krim. Subsequently switching to the Bristol F 2B Fighter, he flew 57 missions totalling more than 100 flying hours. During this



On 30 August 1936, Tenente Ernesto Monico was shot down in his CR.32 by French pilots flying D.372 fighters of the Republican *Escuadra España*. Captured, he was executed that same day by Spanish militiamen at Las Herencias, near Talavera de la Reina. His Italian comrades were informed of his fate on 4 September, after which they honoured his memory by adorning the fuselages of all the CR.32s assigned to both 1^a and 2^a *Escuadrillas de Caza de el Tercio* with the slogan **MONICO ! PRESENTE**. Monico was the first Italian airman to be killed in action during the Spanish Civil War (Author archive)

Henares in 1929. In the summer of 1932 García Morato qualified for the first course in blind flying and aerobatic flight to be held in Spain. Successfully completing them, he became an instructor in both disciplines. That same year García Morato also obtained the title of aviation mechanic. Continuing his self-taught aerobatic training, the Spaniard was certified as a combat pilot instructor and frequently won aerobatic flying competitions both at home and abroad.

In 1934 García Morato took part in the aerial intervention against the miners' rebellion in Asturias, the latter being suppressed on the ground by African troops led by Gen Franco. He was promoted to capitane shortly after this and tasked with organising the air arm of the *Dirección General* of the *Cuerpo de Seguridad* (Security Corps). With the advent of the *Frente Popular* in Spain in February 1936, García Morato's exemplary military service record as an officer loyal to the Crown, his membership of the *Falange Española Tradicionalista* (Spanish Traditionalist Falange) and his strong Catholic faith were all viewed with distrust by the new regime. He was duly removed from service in the *Aviación Militar* and given command of a machine gun section within the 18th Infantry Regiment in Gerona, Catalonia.

When the military revolt started in mid July 1936, García Morato was actually in London. Upon returning to Spain in a light civil aircraft on 1 August, he immediately joined the Nationalist air force and was transferred to Tablada 24 hours later. Given a Ni-H.52 fighter, García Morato flew to Córdoba on 3 August with orders to defend the city. That same day he engaged a pair of Breguet 19s escorted by a solitary Ni-H.52, forcing them to turn away. By the time García Morato performed his first flight in a CR.32 on 6 September following brief instruction on the ground from Sottotenente Mantelli, the Spanish pilot already had four kills to his credit. He had obtained the first of these on 12 August when he downed a Vickers Vildebeest reconnaissance bomber near Antequera while flying the Ni-H.52. Six days later, having swapped his Nieuport-Hispano fighter for a He 51, he claimed a Republican Ni-H.52 and a Potez 540, followed by another Ni-H.52 on 2 September.

On the morning of 9 September García Morato led Italian pilots Chianese and Buffali from Tablada to the airfield at Cáceres, in

time the future ace's aircraft was frequently hit by ground fire. Indeed, he had to force land on two occasions, suffering serious wounds. In 1928 he was transferred to the seaplane base at Melilla Atalayon, but again he sustained terrible injuries when his aircraft crashed into the sea during a mission. Suffering various fractures, García Morato was hospitalised for almost a year.

Upon his recovery, he was assigned as instructor to the *Escuela de Transformación de Pilotos* (Pilot Conversion School) at Alcalá de

Extremadura, from where they could support the Nationalist advance towards Madrid. By the end of the month García Morato had claimed four victories with the CR.32. The first of these was yet another Ni-H.52, which fell near Talavera on the 11th. Five days later he and future ace Sergente Gianlino Baschiroto inflicted so much damage on a Potez 540 bomber near Navalcarnero that the aircraft crash-landed in Republican territory – only its wounded pilot survived. On 20 September García Morato claimed to have downed a Fury near Santa Olalla. Finally, on 26 September he was credited with destroying a Breguet 19 near Bargas.



AIR SUPERIORITY

Operating from Cáceres airfield in the province of Talavera, the CR.32s rapidly gained air superiority over the area following a series of successful engagements against pre-civil war Republican aircraft and newly imported French machines. The latter were, in the main, flown by foreign pilots formed into 'international' combat units.

During the course of September 1936, CR.32 pilots were credited with the destruction of 35 enemy aircraft and three probables. A similar number of victories were recorded in October too. One of the pilots to enjoy success during this period was Sergente Bruno Montegnacco, who would become the ranking Italian ace in Spain.

Born on 30 July 1910 in Tricesimo, in the province of Udine, into a noble Friuli family, Bruno Montegnacco displayed an exuberant and impudent character from a very young age. His desire to become a flyer was fulfilled when he voluntarily enrolled into the *Regia Aeronautica*, and he displayed a great aptitude for flying by finishing as one the top students in his course. This success was rewarded with an assignment to 1° *Stormo Caccia*, based at Campofornido – a mere nine miles from his birthplace. 1° *Stormo*'s flying training syllabus at this time concentrated mainly on aerobatics, and the unit became so good at it that the Minister for Aviation Italo Balbo acknowledged it as the best prepared within the *Regia Aeronautica*. 1° *Stormo* was therefore chosen to be the first unit to re-equip with Fiat's new CR.32 biplane fighter.

In early August 1936 Italian fighter unit commanders issued a request for pilots to volunteer to be secretly sent to aid the Spanish Nationalist forces. Montegnacco was one of the first to offer his services, and to be selected, and he duly received a false passport in the name of 'Antonio Romualdi' prior to travelling to Spain.

Spanish and Italian CR.32 pilots fought near daily combats in the skies over Talavera, Toledo and Madrid during September-October 1936, and they quickly managed to gain superiority over their adversaries who were flying aeroplanes of French design and construction. Indeed,

Also bearing the **MONICO ! PRESENTE** titling, this aircraft of 1ª *Escuadrilla de Caza del Tercio* features the early camouflage scheme applied to CR.32s shortly after they arrived in Spain. It consisted of reddish-brown patches on sand yellow uppersurfaces. One of the Fiat fighter's most highly valued attributes in combat was its unmatched manoeuvrability. The latter went a long way to offsetting its modest top speed, particularly when compared to the I-16 (273 mph). The CR.32's rate of climb was also slower than either of the Polikarpov fighter types in Spain, although conversely it could dive faster and better withstand the considerable stresses associated with a high-speed pullout after a long dive. Such attributes were routinely relied upon by Nationalist pilots who sought to shake off opponents from their tails, a fast evasive diving manoeuvre usually doing the trick. If this proved unsuccessful, however, the Fiat pilot could easily enter a controlled spin that was quickly halted after a few turns once the Republican fighter had been shaken off – the I-16, in particular, was difficult to recover from a high-speed spin (*Dequal Family archive via Associazione 4° Stormo*)



Built in Turin in February 1936, CR.32 NC 275 was amongst the first batch of 12 Fiat fighters sent to Spain to form the 1ª *Escuadrilla de Caza del Tercio*. The aircraft was damaged in a landing accident at Cáceres in September 1936. It too was camouflaged in the early reddish-brown scheme that was chosen to match the colour of the earth present at its airfield in the summer months. Note the fighter's black stripes on each wingtip – a key Nationalist identification marking (Dequal Family archive via *Associazione 4° Stormo*)

The first Republican Breguet 19 to be shot down by CR.32s in Spain was credited to Capitano Dequal on the morning of 11 September 1936 near Talavera de la Reina. The pilot escaped back to Republican lines but the observer was killed. Standing in the centre of this photograph near wreckage of the Breguet 19 is the commander of the *Aviación del Tercio*, Colonnello Ruggero Bonomi (Author archive)



obsolescent Ni-H.52s suffered particularly harsh losses at the hands of the clearly superior CR.32.

For example, on 11 September no fewer than five Nieuport-Hispano sesquiplane fighters were destroyed during three aerial combats that were fought close to Talavera. British pilots Brian Griffin and Claude Warsow of the *Escuadra Internacional* were both killed after being shot down by

Patriarca in the morning and Magistrini in the afternoon, respectively. That same morning French pilots Capt Jean Labitte and Sgt Abel Guidez, who had enrolled in the *Escuadra España* from the reserve corps of the *Armée de l'Air*, were shot down by Chianese and García Morato. Both pilots survived to return to their unit. Finally, Spaniard Sgt Jesús García Herguido was shot down by Buffali. Although wounded in the engagement, he also managed to return to Republican territory.

Two days later two more Ni-H.52s fell to the guns of CR.32s over Talavera. Spaniards Ercilla and Colóm lost their lives duelling with Italians Baschiroto and Patriarca (who had dual Italian/American citizenship), although the latter was forced to take to his parachute after he collided with Ercilla's fighter. Patriarca was captured and later released following the intervention of the US State Department. His fighter was the only CR.32 lost in combat in September-October 1936 – a period during which dozens of victories were attributed to the 20 Italian and three Spanish Fiat fighter pilots. A second CR.32 was lost following an action on 16 September, although it was not shot down. Sottotenente Franceschi became disorientated whilst fighting Republican aircraft and landed in enemy territory close to Don Benito, in Extremadura. He was killed a short while later in a shoot out with a militia patrol. Franceschi's CR.32 was captured intact, and after being thoroughly evaluated by the Republicans, it was lost in a landing incident at Los Alcázares airport, near Cartagena, in November.

Aside from those aircraft shot down, a handful of Ni-H.52s were also destroyed on the ground as well during strafing attacks by CR.32s in Andalusia.

As the number of Nieuport-Hispanos dwindled, more modern French fighters such as the parasol monoplane Dewoitine D.372 and gull-winged Loire 46 C1 appeared over Spain. Yet despite being fitted with powerful air-cooled radial engines that gave them a higher rate of climb than the CR.32, they too were shot down in significant numbers by the Fiat fighters. On 16 September, for example, Chianese downed a D.372 near



Sergente pilota Raffaele Chianese from 4° Stormo Caccia was assigned to 2ª Escuadrilla de Caza del Tercio, and he shot down three enemy aircraft in September 1936. The first of these fell on the 11th when the Ni-D.52 flown by French pilot Jean Labitte from *Escuadra España* crash-landed near Talavera de la Reina. Five days later a D.372 flown by British pilot Keith Lindsay from the *Escuadra Internacional* crash-landed after being wounded by Chianese. A short while later during the same sortie the Italian pilot downed a militarised, red-painted, Miles M 2 two-seat single-engined monoplane that was being used as a makeshift reconnaissance aircraft – both crewmembers were killed. On 30 November Chianese's CR.32 burst into flames during a strafing attack and he was forced to take to his parachute over Republican territory. He was soon captured, and remained a PoW until being freed in a prisoner exchange in July 1937. After long service during World War 2 and post-war as a flying instructor, Chianese, who turned 100 in 2010, is one of the last surviving Italian fighter pilots from the war in Spain (*Chianese Family archive via Associazione 4° Stormo*)

The wreckage of a Breguet 19 shot down on 16 September 1936 near Talavera de la Reina by Sottotenente Adriano Mantelli – seen here in the white flying overalls (*Author archive via US SM Aeronautica Militare*)

three French-built parasol monoplane fighters. After an aerial duel that lasted 15 minutes, Montegnacco managed to get on the tail of an enemy fighter, which he identified as a Loire 46 C1, and shot it down. The pilot of the latter machine, 27-year-old British engineer Edward Downes Martin from the *Escuadra Internacional*, lost his life.

Two days later, Montegnacco and the rest of his unit were transferred to Talavera airfield, which was closer to the operational zone of Toledo and Madrid. Montegnacco scored his second victory during a morning patrol the following day when Dequal's flight of four CR.32s intercepted six enemy fighters that were attacking a pair of Ju 52/3ms. Thanks to the Italian pilots' intervention, the opposing fighters were dispersed. Following a short duel Montegnacco shot down his second Loire 46 C1 near Villamiel de Toledo, the enemy fighter crashing to the ground with a Frenchman by the name of Hantz (from Alsace) still strapped into the cockpit. A 40-year-old veteran of World War 1 – he had served in the German Imperial Air Force – Hantz had joined the Republican *Escuadra España* as a mercenary.

During that same combat Presel was credited with the destruction of two Dewoitine fighters. One of the pilots to be shot down was Frenchman René Issard, who was also a member of the *Escuadra España*.





CR.32s of 2ª *Escuadrilla de Caza del Tercio* undergo routine maintenance at Cáceres in September 1936. The aircraft in the foreground is CR.32 factory number NC 183, which was usually flown by *Sergente Maggiore* Montegnacco. Indeed, he used it on both 22 and 25 September to claim his first aerial victories in Spain when he downed two Loire 46 fighters from the *Escuadra Internacional*. The pilots of these aircraft were killed, Britain Edward Downes Martin crashing near Talavera de la Reina and a German-Alsatian by the name of Hantz coming down near Toledo (A Emiliani archive)

He suffered injuries as he crash-landed his fighter in friendly territory between Talavera and Madrid. Presel downed a D.372 during an evening patrol on 26 September, the fighter being abandoned by its pilot, Rafael Peña Dugo, over Bargas. Although the latter landed in Republican territory, he would subsequently lose a leg to his wounds.

Future ace *Sottotenente* Giuseppe Cenni added to his score during the afternoon of 18 October when he shot down a light aircraft that was performing a reconnaissance mission for the Republicans over Santa Cruz. The vast majority of the enemy aircraft being encountered by CR.32 pilots during the offensive on Madrid were French-built. This fact is clearly evident in the following diary entry by Montegnacco;

‘Talavera de la Reina, 21 October 1936. Defensive patrol over the Illescas front – myself, Capitán Morato and *Sergente Maggiore* Presel. We attacked three Loires, a SPAD, a Dewoitine 500 and a Fury that were escorting a Potez and five Breguets. Morato was overwhelmed due to his inferior altitude by a Loire, which Presel managed to shake off the Spaniard’s tail and shoot down. I followed the SPAD down over Jetafe airfield and fired my guns at it. The fighter crashed there.

‘Returning to our lines, I encountered a Potez and fired my guns at it until one of its engines burst into flames. I could not follow it down, as I went to my colleague’s aid. Presel followed the Dewoitine all the way to Madrid but then had to break off contact due to engine trouble. Capitán Morato attacked a Breguet, although he failed to shoot it down despite firing a considerable amount of ammunition in its direction. The Potez I had previously hit managed to drop its bombs over enemy territory and was later declared destroyed after falling east of Madrid.’

Colonello Bonomi’s diary entry for the same day commented on the ‘SPAD’ claimed by Montegnacco;

‘During the night we were informed that the cannon-armed SPAD was in fact an experimental machine that was actually being flown by a test pilot during a demonstration flight.’

This aircraft was probably the second of two Blériot SPAD 510 C1s sent by the manufacturer to Spain late the previous month. It was fitted with an experimental ‘motor-cannon’ Hispano-Suiza 12Xcrs inline engine that housed a 20 mm cannon between its twin cylinder banks, the weapon firing through the propeller hub. Its French ferry pilot, Guilloux,



Italian CR.32 pilots are seen at Cáceres airfield in September 1936. German fighter pilots were also based here at the time, and one of their He 51s is visible in the background. Sottotenente Mantelli can be seen to the left in his white overall, while in the centre of the photograph in his bathing costume is Sergente Presel (*Dequal Family archive via Associazione 4° Stormo*)

had enrolled in the *Escuadra España* and flown the fighter to Madrid. He was probably flying the Blériot SPAD when it was shot down by Montegnacco over Getafe, the Frenchman surviving the incident.

The D.500 that Montegnacco chased towards Madrid was probably the sole example of its type sent to Spain during October, this aircraft probably being the company's demonstration prototype of the export version of the monoplane fighter.

FIRST CR.32 ACE

Between August and October 1936, CR.32 pilots destroyed 45 Republican aircraft (as later verified by historical research) for the loss of only three Fiat fighters in aerial combat. The leading Italian pilot during this period in terms of individual victories was 23-year-old Sottotenente Adriano Mantelli. Amongst the first members of the *Regia Aeronautica* to volunteer for service in Spain, he was also the first Italian to be credited with the destruction of five aircraft during the civil war.

Mantelli was born on 13 February 1913 in Cortile San Marino di Parma, his father being a regular soldier. He became interested in aviation at a young age, and from 1929 he avidly participated in model flying competitions with aircraft that he had built himself. From 1931 Mantelli dedicated himself to glider design, and the following year he obtained his glider flying licence. Concurrently, he graduated from the Parma *Regio Istituto d'Arte* (Royal Art Institute).

Joining the *Regia Aeronautica* in 1934, Mantelli gained his military 'wings' and became a fighter pilot. Initially flying the CR.20 with 1° *Stormo Caccia*, in 1935 he transferred to a *Squadriglia* equipped with CR.32s that had been formed at the *Reparto Sperimentale Volo* (Experimental Flight Establishment) at Guidonia expressly to defend Rome. Finally, Mantelli joined the newly formed 6° *Stormo Caccia* at Ravenna, in Emilia, which was led by Colonello Vincenzo Velardi. The latter officer subsequently commanded Italian airmen in Spain.

By the end of October 1936 Mantelli had been credited with nine individual and several shared victories whilst operating in the New Castile and Andalusia regions. His first success came on 26 September when he and Sottotenente Cenni shared in the destruction of a twin-engined Potez 540 from the *Escuadra Internacional* over Bargas, the bomber

Sottotenente Mantelli (left) and Capitano Dequal examine the wreckage of a Loire 46 C1 fighter that was shot down by CR.32s in the autumn of 1936. This aircraft is probably the fighter credited to Sergente Montegnacco on 22 September as his first victory, the machine crashing near Maqueda. Only the fourth Loire 46 built, it was flown across the Spanish border from Toulouse-Montaudran to Barcelona on 6 September, along with a handful of other examples. Some of their French pilots duly joined the *Escuadra España* (*A Mantelli archive*)



Pilots of 1ª and 2ª *Escuadrillas de Caza del Tercio* chat with their comrades flying S.81 bombers at Talavera de la Reina airfield in late September 1936. They are, second from left, Sottotenente Giuseppe Cenni, third from left, Sottotenente Adriano Mantelli and, fifth from left, Capitano Vincenzo Dequal. The latter was in overall command of *Tercio* fighter units at that time (A Mantelli archive)



Wreckage of a French Dewoitine D.372 fighter that was shot down by CR.32s. About a dozen of these machines were destroyed by Italian pilots in September-October 1936 in the Talavera-Madrid area. This particular example is probably the D.372 downed by Sergente Galli (seen in this photograph) on 27 September near Toledo. This aircraft was one of 14 examples originally built for the Lithuanian government but delivered instead to the Spanish Republic from early August 1936. It was flown from Toulouse to Barcelona by French pilot Bois on 9 August (Dequal Family archive via Associazione 4° Stormo)



coming down in Republican territory with five of its six crew members wounded. Mantelli was then temporarily transferred to Granada to command a section of CR.32s. On 8 and 9 October he was credited with shooting down two Ni-H.52s, the first of these falling near Granada and the other not far from Andujar. On the morning of 16 October Mantelli destroyed two Breguet 19s directly over Andujar, killing pilot José Serrano Sánchez.

Upon his return to the Madrid front, Mantelli was transferred with his flight to Avila, where he continued to claim victories through to the end of October. The first of these came late in the afternoon of the 27th between Peguerinos and El Escorial when he and his wingmen attacked a formation of five unescorted Breguet 19s. Mantelli shot one down himself and shared in the destruction of three others with Sergente Maggiore Serafini and Sergente Galli. The latter's CR.32 was hit by return fire, however, severing its aileron control lines. Nevertheless, Galli managed to nurse his damaged fighter back to Avila and perform an uneventful landing, in spite of the aeroplane's poor handling.

All four of the aircraft destroyed belonged to the last Republican unit to be equipped with the Breguet 19 on the Madrid front, *Escuadrilla González*, as the rest had been decimated by the all-conquering CR.32. The commander of this unit, Capitán González Martín, had in fact been flying the first aircraft to be shot down on 27 October. He and another pilot, and their respective rear gunners, all lost their lives, while the remaining two crews survived emergency landings in Republican territory. The one surviving Breguet 19 returned home to Alcalá de Henares with only the pilot on board, as the gunner, Ramos, had taken to his parachute over the Republican zone near El Escorial in the belief that his aircraft was falling out of the sky following the apparent death of his pilot! It was Ramos who had hit Galli's fighter, forcing the Italians to finally break off their attack.

Mantelli's flight, consisting of Ligabò and Giuglietti, intercepted a formation of three Potez 542s over Navalcarnero on the morning of 30 October. Leading the Republican bomber formation was the second-in-command of the *Escuadra Internacional*, Spaniard Comandante Sampil, while the remaining two aircraft were flown by Bulgarian Zakharev and Russian Proskurov. The CR.32s initially targeted Zakharev's Potez, setting one of its engines on fire. Proskurov attempted

The fuselage of the Potez 542 twin-engined bomber shot down by Sottotenente Mantelli and his wingmen, Ligabò and Giuglietti, on 30 October 1936 between Navalcarnero and Madrid. This aircraft had been flown from Toulouse to Barcelona on 15 September, before heading on to Madrid to be assigned to the *Escuadra Internacional*, or *Escuadra N 4*. It was flown by Bulgarian pilot Zakharij Zakharev (alias Volkan Goranov), who was wounded along with two other crewmen by gunfire from the Italian fighters. All six crew aboard the bomber were saved, however, by the fact that its pilot could force-land on flat ground. During the same action two other Potez bombers were credited as individually downed by Mantelli, although only the aircraft flown by Soviet pilot Ivan Proskurov was destroyed. He too managed to save his crew by crash-landing near Getafe. Of the three French twin-engined bombers in the formation, only the aircraft flown by patrol leader Sampil (a Spaniard) returned alone to base (Author archive via US SM Aeronautica Militare)

CR.32s of 2ª *Escuadrilla de Caza del Tercio* are prepared for their next mission in October 1936. Each fighter has a different style of identification number, with the CR.32 in the centre of the line-up having a locally adopted code system (2-2 for *Escuadrilla 2*, with the latter 2 being the fighter's individual number) just aft of the exhaust stubs. The aircraft to the left bears the code 3-20 beneath the cockpit, with the '3' being the type number assigned by the Nationalists to the CR.32. These numbers were issued in chronological order, being issued when the aircraft entered service in Spain – the Fiat fighter was the third fighter type to be flown by the Nationalists after the Ni-H.52 and He 51. The number '20' was the fighter's individual identifier. Finally, the aircraft furthest from the camera bears the Fiat factory number only (*Dequal Family archive via Associazione 4° Stormo*)



to assist his comrade by slowing down and positioning his aircraft between Zakharev and the opposing fighters. This courageous action won him the admiration of the Italian pilots, but it was ultimately performed in vain as the damaged bomber was doomed.

Although wounded in the leg by a bullet, Zakharev managed to nurse his stricken aircraft to the safety of Republican territory, where he and his Spanish co-pilot Pérez Sancho force-landed the aircraft in a clearing near the frontline. All five crew managed to escape the wreckage and reach friendly troops. A short while later Mantelli shot down Proskurov's Potez over Republican territory. Like Zakharev, the skilful Russian pilot also managed to save the lives of his crew by carrying out a successful emergency landing in a vineyard near Getafe. Although Mantelli was also credited with the destruction of flight leader Sampil's Potez, the latter had in fact made it back to base at Albacete. Mantelli, like his wingmen, returned to Talavera to find that his CR.32 had been holed in several places by fire from Proskurov's gunner, Vladimirov, who had continued to fire at the Italian fighter in spite of a serious wound to one of his hands.

EARLY SPANISH CR.32 PILOTS

Four Spanish pilots joined the first CR.32 units of the *Tercio Extranjero* during September and October 1936. The first of these was of course García Morato, and he claimed three more victories with the Fiat fighter



in October while flying from Talavera. Initially, García Morato flew defensive patrols around Illescas, and on 16 October he shot down a Loire 46 C1 near Madrid. Two Breguet 19s followed two days later, and on 23 October he shared in the destruction of two airships moored at Casa de Campo (Madrid's race course), where Cenni had noticed them the day before. Both caught fire, the first being an old unbraced design, while the second was of semi-rigid construction with an internal metal structure.

When García Morato had transferred to the CR.32 in early September 1936, he had done so only days before fellow Spaniards, and future aces, Julio Salvador and Ángel Salas.

Salvador was born on 20 May 1910 in Cadiz, and he entered the military academy at the age of 15. In 1930 Salvador attained the rank of tenente after graduating top of his class in the 4a *Promoción* (4th promotion) course for the *Aviación Militar*. In 1931 he was assigned as a fighter pilot to 2a *Escuadra Aérea*, based at Seville-Tablada – he also received the title of air mechanic. Salvador had logged 550 flying hours by the time he and most of his fellow officers at the base backed the Nationalist cause on the night of 18 July 1936 and occupied Seville-Tablada airfield.

Salvador's first aerial combat occurred over Sierra de Guadarrama ten days later when, during a defensive patrol from Cáceres in a Ni-H.52, he encountered an identical machine on a similar mission from Madrid-Getafe. The action ended inconclusively, however. Upon his return to Seville in August, Salvador found the first six He 51s issued to the Nationalists being prepared for combat – these aircraft had been unloaded in Cadiz. He quickly converted onto the German fighter, and during one of his first flights in it, on 18 August, he shot down a Ni-H.52 near Mérida, in Extremadura, followed by a pair of Breguet 19s. By month-end, however, the Spanish He 51 *Escuadrilla* had been disbanded and its aircraft handed over to German pilots who were more familiar with the type. Unhappy with this turn of events, Salvador, García Morato and Ángel Salas duly requested a transfer to the *Tercio Extranjero*. Colonel Bonomi certified that Salvador's first flight in the CR.32 had gone very well, and during the second week of September he joined the foreign legion air component along with García Morato and Salas.

The latter was born on 10 October 1906 in the Biscayan enclave of Orduña. He enrolled in the artillery military academy at the age of 15, and on attaining the rank of teniente, Salas joined the *Aviación Militar*. He initially qualified as an aero observer in 1928, after which he then gained both his civilian and military flying licences, topping the graduation list of the 2a *Promoción*. This in turn meant that Salas was chosen to fly fighters, and he was assigned to the *Escuadrilla Martinskyde* based at Madrid-Getafe. He was subsequently posted to Tetuán, in Spanish Morocco, where he met Gen Franco. In February 1936 Salas was promoted to the rank of captain, and by mid July he had a total of 1625 flying hours in his logbook.

Salas was staying with his parents and his brothers at their summer residence in Madrid when the military revolt occurred. Together with two other pilot officers, he managed to fly to rebel territory in one of three Breguet 19s that fled from Getafe to Pamplona – the latter city had been captured by the rebels on 19 July. Salas' first operational flights were



The wreckage of a Loire 46 C1 shot down by Capitán García Morato on 16 October 1936 near Illescas. The aircraft had been transferred by lorry to Seville, where this photograph was taken. Standing furthest from the camera is Sergente Raffaele Chianese, who was wingman for García Morato during the Spaniard's first CR.32 patrol (*Chianese Family archive via Associazione 4° Stormo*)

performed in the Breguet 19, and he also flew Ni-H.52s and twin-engined de Havilland DH 89s that had been fitted with a fixed forward-firing machine gun.

It was whilst flying these aircraft that Salas participated in the first three aerial combats fought on the Madrid-Guadarrama front, although he failed to achieve any success. Indeed, it was not until 23 August that he recorded his first kill whilst flying a Ni-H.52 from Saragossa, Salas shooting down a light aircraft that was being used as a reconnaissance platform near Teruel. However, the very next day he was hospitalised due to exhaustion, having flown 50 operational sorties totalling 116 hours in just 27 days. On leaving hospital on 11 September, Salas was sent to Seville-Tablada, where, following García Morato's recommendation, he was accepted into 2ª *Escuadrilla de Caza de el Tercio*. The latter unit, together with 1ª *Escuadrilla de Caza de el Tercio*, was under the command of Capitano Dequal.

Salas headed to Talavera, on the Toledo front, a short while later, and it was whilst flying from here that he shared in the destruction of a Potez 540 with his Italian wingman Baschiroto on 25 September. The bomber was being flown by the commander of *Grupo Potez*, Capitán Joaquín Mellado Pascual, who perished along with all six of his crew.

The fourth Spaniard to fly the CR.32 in the autumn of 1936 was future ace Miguel García Pardo, who was born in La Coruña on 20 November 1907. Joining the military academy at the age of 16, he was promoted to alférez (second lieutenant) in 1928 and sent to an infantry regiment. From here he was selected for pilot training, qualifying as an observer and being transferred to Melilla, in Spanish Morocco. Promoted to teniente in 1930, García Pardo earned his 'wings' as a military pilot a short time later and went on to serve with 3a *Escuadra Aérea* at Prat de Llobregat, near Barcelona. He immediately displayed excellent leadership qualities, which he combined with good aerial navigation skills to finish first three times in annually organised patrol competitions.

At the start of the civil war García Pardo was serving in Barcelona. With the Republicans fearing an imminent attack, he took advantage of the confusion reigning at Prat and escaped to Pamplona on 19 July in a Breguet 19 with Capitán Calderón, whereupon they both joined the Nationalist cause. García Pardo flew his first combat missions in the Breguet 19, before hastily converting onto the Ni-H.52 after a handful of examples were transferred from Andalusia to Burgos. On 9 August he scored his first victory against a Breguet 19 over Sierra de Guadarrama, and during September he flew missions over Aragon in Ni-H.52s, He 51s and Breguet 19s from Saragossa.

In October García Pardo moved to Seville, where he began flying the CR.32 within the fighter group of the *Aviación del Tercio*, which was in the process of being formed under the command of recently arrived Maggiore Tarcisio Fagnani (alias Faroni). García Pardo's operational sorties on the Madrid front began on 21 October. By the end of that month, the majority of the French-built Republican aircraft defending the Spanish capital had either been destroyed, were unserviceable or undergoing repair.



Capitano Dequal and Capitán García Morato are seen here in the CO's office at Seville-Tablada airfield in early September 1936 (*Dequal Family archive via Associazione 4º Stormo*)

The wreckage of Potez 540 4219, which was flown from Toulouse-Montaudran to Barcelona on 8 August 1936. In service with the *Grupo Potez* of the Republican air force, it was shot down by Capitán Salas and Sergente Baschiroto from 2ª *Escuadrilla de Caza del Tercio* between Toledo and Rielves on 25 September 1936. The pilot of the bomber, group commander Joaquín Mellado Pascual, perished along with the remaining six members of his crew (*Author archive*)



FIGHTER ESCALATION

More aircraft and pilots had reached the Nationalists in Spain from Italy and Germany during September and October 1936. Included in their number were three new CR.32s delivered to Palma de Majorca on 7 September, thus doubling the number of Fiat fighters on the island – they formed the *Squadriglia Mussolini*, led by Capitano D’Agostinis. On 29 September 12 CR.32s arrived at Cadiz, accompanied by 11 pilots that were destined to form 3^a *Squadriglia da Caccia del Tercio*. The unit was headed by Capitano Carlo Albergo Maccagno (alias Alfredo Percori), who was transferred to Spain in early October from 4^o *Stormo CT*. On 13 October a further dozen CR.32s, and their pilots, reached Cadiz, these new arrivals being led by Capitano Guido Nobili (alias Notabili). The latter had previously served with the *Scuola Caccia Terrestre* (Fighter School) of the *Regia Aeronautica*. Nine more CR.32s, and pilots, were disembarked at Seville under the command of Capitano Mosca (alias Massa) from 6^o *Stormo CT*.

By 3 November, a total of 60 CR.32s had arrived in Spain, as had 57 He 51s. Germany and Italy also sent 150 other military aircraft types between them too, including 34 transport and bomber Ju 52/3ms and 18 S.81 bombers. These numbers were countered on the Republican side through the provision of Soviet fighters and bombers from late October. With the arrival of these aircraft, the Republicans finally began to match the Nationalists in the air. This became more and more evident in the late autumn as Gen Franco’s African Army advanced to the southwest outskirts of Madrid. Not only were the Nationalists being engaged more effectively in the air, on the ground, the Republican defence of the capital had been reinforced through the deployment of thousands of foreign volunteers who had rallied to the cause. These troops also benefited from mechanised support, as well as a massive influx of small arms and ammunition from the USSR. The supply of weaponry to both sides openly violated the ‘Non-Intervention’ pact prescribed by the International Committee.

During the last week of October and the third week of November, ships from the Soviet Union unloaded aeroplanes, personnel, arms and ammunition in Republican ports such as Cartegna, on the Spanish Mediterranean coast. Once at various airfields in eastern Spain, these machines allowed the immediate formation of a bomber group numbering 30 modern Tupolev SB twin-engined aircraft, two units equipped with 42 Polikarpov I-15 biplane and 31 I-16 monoplane fighters and an attack group flying 31 Polikarpov R-5 SSS biplanes. A third fighter unit equipped with 30 I-15s were disembarked on the Atlantic coast, thus bringing the total number of Soviet combat aircraft in Spain to 164. Soon, yet more aid would be forthcoming.

The appearance of Soviet aircraft flown by well-trained and disciplined crews reopened the battle for aerial supremacy that had been so convincingly won by the CR.32s when pitted against fighters and bombers of French design in the summer and autumn of 1936. This new confrontation was to continue for the rest of the civil war. For the Nationalists, the CR.32 was its most important fighter from a numerical perspective, equipping up to seven Italian and Spanish groups. The technologically superior Bf 109 was flown by only one German *gruppe* of the *Legion Condor* from 1937, while the He 51 was quickly relegated to ground attack duties following the arrival of superior Polikarpov fighters in Spain. For the Republicans, the I-15 and I-16 were the only fighters in widespread use from November 1936 until war's end, these aircraft being ably flown by Soviet and Spanish pilots (the latter trained in the USSR), as well as a small number of foreign pilots.

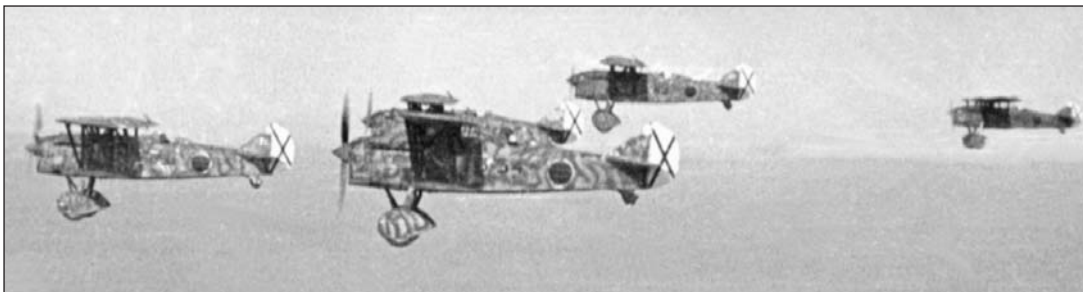
Although CR.32s and Polikarpov fighters would fight each other innumerable times over the next 29 months in Spanish skies, the first Soviet aircraft engaged by the Italian machines were fast SB bombers. A thoroughly modern all-metal aircraft designed in 1933, the Tupolev bomber was not only highly aerodynamic, it also boasted a retractable undercarriage. Carrying a crew of three (pilot, bomb-aimer/gunner and rear gunner), the SB's speed proved to be higher than that of contemporary opposing fighters such as the He 51 and CR.32. Indeed, the aircraft was capable of 236 mph at an altitude of 13,000 ft when carrying up to 1500 lbs of bombs.

SBs carried out their first missions on 29 October when they dropped 220-lb bombs on the airfields in Caceres and Seville. CR.32s scrambled from the latter base in an attempt to intercept the Tupolevs but they were unable to catch the fast twin-engined raiders. The first real combat between the new bombers and the Fiat fighters took place the following day south of Madrid when three SB-2s were attacked by six CR.32s. The latter fired all their ammunition before giving up the chase. Spaniard Salas claimed to have hit one of the bombers, which was seen by those on the ground to crash within Republican territory.

During the afternoon of 2 November flight leader Sottotenente Mantelli and his wingman Maresciallo Sozzi managed to bring down an SB between them, this being the first time that the actual destruction of a Tupolev bomber could be proven. Mantelli later recounted;

'The combat experience that I remember best, and the one I'm most proud of, was when I faced one of the newly-arrived Red Air Force aircraft that were causing us great concern. Dubbed the "Martin bomber", its appearance came as a rather nasty surprise to us. Thanks to its twin engines and retractable undercarriage, the bomber's level speed was some 30 mph faster than that of our fighters, which meant that interceptions were impossible. Needless to say, scrambling once these bombers had appeared was useless. A series of surprise raids by the aircraft, where no opposition could be offered, threw all of us into a feeling of helplessness. Our commanders encouraged us, but it appeared that the facts were too clear to be dismissed – top speed, in particular, was definitely against us.

'However, an interception did happen a few days later. I scrambled, accompanied by Sozzi, into the sky above Talavera de la Reina. We already knew that one of these famous monoplanes had been sighted over



Avila, some 60 miles away, but I decided not to wander too far from Talavera. Below me were two airfields, and by circling over the town I could keep an eye on both of them. It was well known that these airfields were targeted by the raiders as they attempted to “ground us” (and we had already suffered quite a lot of damage). I thought to myself that if it comes this way I could intercept it, but if it heads for a different target I could just about forget it!

‘We continued to climb, knowing that the higher we went the faster we could dive down on the enemy bomber. I continued to scan the sky by sector out of habit. First sector, empty. Second sector, empty. Third sector, there, a thin line in the distance against the horizon in a yellowish sky – I will never forget that. It was “him”. I wouldn’t let him out of my sight, and I continued to gain height. It was not coming towards Talavera, however. According to my reckoning, it would pass us some six miles away. There would be no chance of getting at him if I didn’t change course.

‘Then suddenly the “Martin bomber” turned almost 90 degrees and set course for Talavera. The monoplane was well below us, and hadn’t seen us. I waited, checked my speed and distance and then at the right moment I pushed the nose of my fighter down and dove at the bomber. The slipstream whistled past and the engine roared, but I heard nothing. My eyes were fixed on the aeroplane that rapidly grew larger as we closed in at a tremendous speed. Range seemed just right so I fired – the machine guns hummed.

‘With the first burst I could clearly see the incendiary rounds hitting the wing, sending white sparks flying. The right wing caught fire almost immediately, then a tail of flames from the left wing engulfed both the fuselage and the right wing. The “Martin bomber” began to fall, but my frenetic dive continued. One wing broke off, at which point three men took to their parachutes. I saw three envelopes open, but the speed was too high and they were torn away – the three men fell like dead bodies. My CR.32 was faster and I flew past them. I was terribly excited by the victory and nearly forgot my controls, only to suddenly remember that I had to stop the aeroplane from diving. The sound of the slipstream became calmer as I pulled out, and down below me the monoplane exploded as it hit the ground.’

Wingman Sozzi also contributed to the destruction of the SB, having positioned himself behind and below the bomber after the fighters’ fast dive. He duly fired at the aircraft from below while Mantelli shot at it from above. The SB’s crew, engaged in a reconnaissance sortie, came from the 2^a *Escuadrilla* ‘SB’ of *Grupo* 12, which was based at San Clemente,

A formation of CR.32s patrols over the Madrid front in November 1936. No emblems or unit numbers are present on these aircraft, just individual numerical codes – 3-34 is the closest machine. In an effort to help CR.32 pilots quickly identify their comrades during dogfights over Madrid, the rudders of most Fiat fighters were painted white at this time so that the Nationalist black cross stood out more clearly. Large white crosses were also applied to the upper surface of the top wing as well (*Dequal Family archive, via Associazione 4° Stormo*)

Capitán García Morato (centre) and the pilots that he routinely led whilst serving with 2ª Escuadrilla de Caza del Tercio between September and December 1936. To the left is Sergente Buffali and to the right Sergente Chianese. CR.32 NC 232 was part of the first production series of Fiat fighters completed in Turin in December 1935 (*Chianese Family archive via Associazione 4º Stormo*)



in Murcia, under the command of Capt Kholzunov. Pilot Petrov, observer Vlasov and gunner Tsigulev became the first Soviet airmen to fall in action in Spain. Following this action, Mantelli concluded;

‘The excitement that spread throughout both the flying units and the Nationalist troops following this victory was enormous. A *bandera* (infantry unit of the *Tercio*) ventured into enemy territory so that the “dragon’s” demise could be confirmed. They brought back ailerons, which we shipped off to Italy. The “Martin bomber’s” myth of invincibility came to an end that day.’

Two days after the SB-2 had been shot down, the Nationalist pilots got another nasty surprise in the skies over Madrid when they encountered Polikarpov fighters for the first time. Their appearance coincided with the arrival of the first International Brigades in the frontline around the capital, the latter having been abandoned for Valencia by the Republican government due to the closeness of the Nationalist army.

On 4 November, CR.32 pilots Dequal and his wingman Magistrini were on a reconnaissance mission over Madrid when they saw a Nationalist Romeo Ro.37 light bomber coming under attack by seven biplane fighters the likes of which they had not seen before over Spain. These aircraft were, of course, the first I-15s to attain operational status with the Republicans. The Italian fighter pilots managed to distract their Soviet opponents long enough for the Ro.37 to escape, albeit with a wounded Spanish observer on board and some damage to the airframe.

Overwhelmed by the well-flown Republican machines, both CR.32 pilots were eventually shot down. Dequal lost consciousness after suffering wounds from a bullet that hit him in the forehead. He woke up next to his parachute in enemy territory, at which point he realised that he had fallen out of his stricken aircraft and the ‘chute had opened automatically. Despite suffering further injuries to his legs and chest

when he was yanked out of this fighter, Dequal somehow managed to limp back to friendly territory, where he was rescued by Nationalist soldiers and hospitalised in Talavera. Magistrini, meanwhile, had landed his badly shot up CR.32 behind the Nationalist frontline, but he subsequently succumbed to serious wounds a short time later in a local field hospital. Although seriously damaged, Magistrini’s aircraft was recovered.

That same day the new Soviet fighters downed two Ju 52/3ms. Air superiority over Madrid had been well and truly wrestled away from the Nationalists.

Nine CR.32s clashed with a considerably larger force of I-15s over Madrid on 5 November, and *Squadriglia* commander Capitano Carlo Albero Maccagno was shot down. On his first operational mission, the badly wounded Maccagno was captured and hospitalised. Despite receiving medical treatment, he had to have his right leg amputated. Maccagno eventually returned to Italy following a prisoner exchange.

Avenging Maccagno's loss, the remaining Italian and Spanish CR.32 pilots were credited with the destruction of seven Soviet fighters, as well as two SBs that were intercepted as the Nationalist aircraft headed for home. Two of the I-15s were claimed by García Morato and Salas, who had sortied with Salvador and six Italian pilots. Salas duly noted in his logbook;

'Fiat number 278, 1 hour 40 minutes, Torrijos-Madrid (surveillance). Our nine Fiats met about 15 "Curtiss" fighters. I took one by surprise and shot him down, the aircraft falling some five kilometres south-southeast of Barajas and bursting into flames on impact. I then fired at one head on and later fired at another, before being attacked by two. I managed to shake them off by diving vertically.'

In reality, only two I-15s had been destroyed. Lt Mitrofanov, who was flying one of the aircraft that was shot down, became the first Soviet fighter pilot to lose his life in Spain. Although the other I-15 was a write-off, its pilot survived his forced landing on the tree-lined avenue of *Paseo de la Castellana*. Several other I-15s returned to their base at Campo Soto, near Algete, with varying degrees of battle damage.

Shortly after his encounter with the Soviet fighters, García Morato shot down a Potez twin-engined bomber that force-landed in Republican territory with a dead engine.

Weather conditions deteriorated over the next few days, but aerial battles continued over Madrid as Nationalist forces prepared for a massive attack in the hope of a decisive victory that would allow them to occupy the city. This would ultimately prove impossible, however, for rebel forces were insufficient in number to seize a well-defended conurbation the size of Madrid (with a population then in excess of one million inhabitants).

Nevertheless, during the morning and evening of 6 November, CR.32s were involved in two more engagements in the vicinity of Madrid against the new Soviet fighters. The results were indecisive, and many of the Italian fighters required repair or suffered battle damage – one was holed no fewer than 70 times. During the first combat over Getafe four victories were attributed to five CR.32s led by Salas, although only two kills could be confirmed by ground observers. Three individual victories were attributed to Tenente Ceccherelli, future ace Sottotenente Cenni and Sottotenente Serafini. One of the aircraft destroyed was the I-15 flown by Lt Voronov, who died two days later in hospital from injuries suffered when he crash-landed upon his return to base.

With repairs to the damaged fighters complete, 18 CR.32s were fully serviceable at Torrijos on 8 November – the day the major assault on Madrid began. Forty-eight hours later García Morato attacked five I-15s and eight SB-2s, noting in his logbook;

'Fiat *Escuadrilla*. Bomber escort. "Junker" (Ju 52/3m) and "Romeo" (Ro.37) engaged by five "Curtiss fighters" (I-15s). I shot one down and then machine gunned eight "Sophias" (SBs), preventing them from dropping their bombs. Anti-aircraft fire also seen. Total flying time 1 hour 50 minutes.'

Monoplane I-16 fighters made their first appearance over the Madrid front on 10 November when they joined I-15s in the strafing of Moroccan troops and cavalry that had occupied the *Casa de Campo* on the



Pilots of the first CR.32 group to be based at Torrijos and see combat over the Madrid front in November 1936 pose for the camera. In the top row, from left to right, are Sergente Raul Galli (3^a Squadriglia), Tenente Antonio Larsimont Pergameni (3^a Squadriglia) and Sergente Eugenio Salvi (3^a Squadriglia). In the front row, from left to right, are Sergenti Guido Presel (3^a Squadriglia), Virginio Pongiluppi (3^a Squadriglia) and Adamo Giuglietti (2^a Squadriglia), Capitano Guido Nobili (then leader of 2^a Squadriglia Caccia del Tercio), Spanish pilot Teniente Miguel García Pardo (then attached to 2^a Squadriglia), Tenente Elio Fiacchino (2^a Squadriglia) and two unidentified Italian sottufficiali piloti (Author archive)

outskirts of western Madrid. For the Nationalist troops on the receiving end of these ultra low-level strafing incursions (three attacks that afternoon alone), the Soviet fighters appeared without warning literally from within the abandoned buildings of Madrid's frontline, hugging the ground like rats. The I-16s were duly nicknamed *Ratas* (Rats), and this name stuck with the type throughout its frontline career.

In response to the appearance of the new Soviet aircraft over Madrid, the Nationalist air force officially formed the first Fiat fighter group

on 11 November. Designated *Gruppo Caccia di Torrijos* or *Primo Gruppo Caccia Fiat* (First Fiat Fighter Group), its CO was Maggiore Tarcisio Fagnani. The group included 2^a and 3^a *Squadriglie* on the Madrid front, these units being led by Capitani Nobili and Mosca, respectively, while Capitano Dequal's 1^a *Squadriglia* remained at Seville, in Andalusia.

Two days later, the fiercest fighting yet seen in the skies over Madrid took place that morning when a formation of Ju 52/3ms and Ro.37s, escorted by 15 CR.32s, was surprised by I-15s that dived on the Nationalist aircraft from above out of the sun. Despite immediately being on the defensive, the Fiat pilots managed to protect the bombers as the air battle broke up into a series of individual combats. A Soviet fighter, whose pilot escaped by parachute, was shot down by Capitano Mosca. The latter was in turn badly wounded in his right thigh and forced to limp back to Talavera. Command of 3^a *Squadriglia* was subsequently given to Tenente Larsimont, although Mosca eventually recovered, only to perish in a flying accident at Seville on 19 December.

CR.32 pilots were credited with ten aerial victories following the huge clash on 13 November, although only two I-15s and an SB were actually lost over Madrid that morning – the Soviet pilots in turn claimed six victories. Baschiroto was among the Italians to be awarded a kill, while Nobili was credited with a probable. García Morato and Salvador were also credited with one I-15 kill apiece, while Salas accounted for the SB from a formation of three that was intercepted shortly after the main engagement. These successes gave Salvador ace status and Salas his fourth individual victory. García Morato, whose tally now stood at 15 victories, recounted;

'Fiat *Squadriglia*. Bomber escort. "Junkers" and "Romeos" bombing Rosales (Madrid) clashed with 13 "Curtiss fighters". I shot down one that caught fire in the air, and then machine gunned three "Sophias" till my ammunition ran out. Saw Anti-aircraft fire. Total flying time 1 hour 30 minutes.'

Salas recalled;

'Fiat number 128. 1 hour 30 minutes. Torrijos to Madrid, escorting five Junkers. Fourteen Fiats attacked 13 "Curtiss fighters" – three

combats, one frontal, fired on the second while banking, and on the third from behind. Noticed several hits on the fuselage of one aircraft, but could not follow him due to the presence of others. Remained alone throughout, and eventually saw five “Martin bombers” attacking Getafe and Cuatro Vientos from 5000 metres. I fired at them twice until my guns stopped. On landing, Noreña, Celier and Betancour told me that one of the bombers I had attacked lost a wing and fell to the ground, its crew escaping by parachute.’

That afternoon, it was the *Legion Condor*’s turn to ‘mix it’ with the Soviet fighters when I-15s and I-16s attacked a formation of 12 He 51s and three Heinkel He 46 light bombers. This was the first time that the Heinkel biplane fighter had encountered the Polikarpovs, and the end result was two Soviet and two German pilots killed.

The aerial battle of Madrid continued for the next few days as Nationalist troops advanced to the city’s western outskirts until they were finally halted by the newly formed *Ejército Popular* of the Republican militia, supported by the International Brigades.

On the morning of 15 November, 15 CR.32s again provided the fighter escort for bombers attacking targets in Madrid. As they neared the city, four I-16s led by Lt Chernhikh attacked the Italian section consisting of Sottotenenti Serafini and Cenni and Sergente Berretta. All three pilots ably defended themselves and collectively shot down an I-16 piloted by Vladimir N Vzorov (alias José Zoro), who destroyed his fighter when he crash-landed into an olive grove.

The following afternoon future ace 1Lt Rychagov, who was also the commander of the I-15 group, was shot down over Madrid. His fighter was initially hit by return fire from a Ju 52/3m, before being finished off by Sottotenente Montegnacco as his fifth individual victory. Although wounded, Rychagov escaped by parachute and landed on Paseo de la Castellana. During the same engagement future ace Sergente Maggiore Vittorino Daffara recorded his very first individual kill when he shot down an SB.

Two I-16s attempted to attack bombers over the northern Madrid suburb of Fuencarral on the morning of 17 November, but they were both shot down. The fighters’ demise was credited to Montegnacco, who claimed one by himself, and Presel, Baccara and Salvi, who shared the second success between them. Soviet I-16 pilot Lt Pavlov was killed.

A major Nationalist aerial attack was mounted during the afternoon of 19 November involving the largest number of aircraft employed simultaneously against the defences of Madrid – 18 Ju 52/3ms, four S.81s and 12 Ro.37s, escorted by 16 CR.32s and nine He 51s. Soviet fighters succeeded in destroying one Junkers tri-motor, although its Spanish crew survived. Seven Soviet fighters were claimed as destroyed

Sergente Presel (right) was almost an ace when this photograph was taken in November 1936, having by then claimed four individual and one shared victories and one unconfirmed. The aircraft is CR.32 NC 105 from the first production series completed in Turin in July 1935 and shipped to Spain just over a year later (Dequal Family archive via Associazione 4° Stormo)



by Italian Fiat pilots, including two 'Curtiss fighters' each to future aces Nobili and Daffara. During the clash Soviet I-16 pilot Capt Dmitriy I Jhedanov lost his life, as did Spanish I-15 pilot Sargento Fernando Roig Vilalta. Jhedanov, who was leading a section of I-16s, was probably shot down between Madrid and Barajas by Tenente Corrado Ricci of 3^a *Squadriglia*.

By the third week of November the Nationalist offensive on Madrid had stalled in the face of stiff resistance both on the ground and in the air. The fighting had taken a toll on the Soviet fighters, however, and by 20 November there were only 15 operational I-15s in Spain.

On 2 December the action picked up again when 18 Soviet R-5 SSSs from 1a *Escuadrilla* attacked the Nationalist airfield at Talavera-Velada, destroying an S.81 and badly damaging two others. One of the Polikarpov biplanes suffered damage from exploding bombs dropped by those ahead of it, causing the R-5 SSS to crash near the airfield. Three others were also similarly damaged, after which they were attacked by Sottotenente Cenni as they fled the scene. The latter pilot just happened to be airborne after he had been scrambled following earlier reports of Republican aircraft in the area.

Cenni chased the R-5 SSSs down as they attempted to reach Republican territory, and he succeeded in shooting all three aircraft down. The two crewmen from the first biplane that he destroyed were taken prisoner, while the others managed to crash-land in the Republican zone. With these victories Cenni's tally rose to six.

Giuseppe Cenni was born in Emilia, Casola Valsenio, in the province of Ravenna, on 17 February 1915. He displayed an enthusiasm for flying at an early age and enjoyed building gliders while studying at the Parma Institute of Fine Arts – a school attended by fellow would-be ace Adriano Mantelli. Indeed, both men would also commence their flying careers together. Cenni joined the *Regia Aeronautica* on 19 June 1935 as an Allievo Ufficiale di Complemento (auxiliary officer cadet), gaining his 'wings' flying the CR.20 five months later. He entered permanent service as a sottotenente on 2 June 1936, and just two weeks later he embarked with the first volunteer group for Spain, having been given the alias Vittorio Stella.

Two more R-5 SSSs were shot down by CR.32s over Torrijos during the afternoon of 4 December, one of which was credited to Sergente Baschiroto as his third individual victory.

During December the first battle for Madrid finally petered out as both sides reinforced their defensive positions along the frontline – positions that would change very little until the final stages of the Spanish Civil War.



Standing in front of a captured Soviet SB bomber and the tail of a German Bucker trainer is Maresciallo Vittorino Daffara (left), who served in Spain as a fighter pilot from October 1936 through to 1940. Initially a sergente with 2^a *Escuadrilla de Caza del Tercio*, he later flew with XXIII *Gruppo Caccia* of the *Aviazione Legionaria* in 1937-38 and finally as a highly valued instructor with various Spanish military flying schools. Between 16 November 1936 and 4 January 1938 Daffara was credited with six individual and four shared victories. Promoted to tenente for his distinguished service in Spain, Daffara also saw action leading a *squadriglia* during World War 2. He survived the conflict with an additional seven individual victories to his name. Joining the post-war Italian *Aeronautica Militare* in 1949, Daffara was transferred to the military reserve in 1987 with the rank of general (A Emiliani archive)

FORMING OF THE AVIAZIONE LEGIONARIA

Following the Soviet military intervention in support of the Spanish Republicans, which had gone a long way to preventing the Nationalists from seizing Madrid, Gen Franco and his Italian and German allies realised that the civil war was not going to be won any time soon as they had confidently predicted. A further injection of military supplies, and especially aircraft, would now be necessary. Germany reacted quickly, organising and sending an expeditionary force known as the *Legion Condor* to Spain in November 1936. This consisted of arms, personnel and a command structure, together with logistic and technical support. The cutting edge of this force were the bomber and fighter units, which were in turn supported by artillery, armoured vehicles, land- and sea-based transportation, a detachment from the *Kriegsmarine* and an international air transport service.

Italy organised the *Corpo Truppe Volontarie* (Volunteer Troop Corps) made up of infantry divisions, arms and vehicles, and it also mobilised the merchant fleet and provided escorts from the *Regia Marina*. The supply of aircraft to Spain was also renewed, with fighters featuring most prominently since existing German types such as the He 51 had quickly proven inferior to their more modern Soviet equivalents, as well as to the CR.32. It was also understood that the Germans would concentrate on supplying bombers to the Nationalists.

Reflecting the escalation in the conflict, the *Aviación del Tercio Extranjero* was dissolved on 28 December 1936 and replaced by the Italian *Aviazione Legionaria*. The latter combined the majority of the aircraft that had been sent to Spain from Italy together with all Italian airmen participating in the mission, as well as some Spanish aviators and soldiers. A minor air component was formed as an autonomous entity, the *Aviazione Legionaria delle Baleari* being equipped with bombers intended for anti-maritime or coastal operations, as well as a few CR.32s for local defence. Some of the new aircraft supplied by Italy, including S.81s, Ro.37s, CR.32s and CANT Z.501 flying boats, were handed over to the *Aviación Nacional* for operation by Spanish crews and, occasionally, foreign volunteers.

By the end of 1936, CR.32 pilots of the *Aviazione del Tercio* had been credited with 131 aerial

CR.32 NC 262 from the first production series was completed in Turin in January 1936 and shipped to Spain later that same year. The aircraft received the code 3-17 shortly after being assigned to the *Aviación del Tercio*. It then joined 4^a *Squadriglia Caccia* of the newly formed *Aviazione Legionaria* in January 1937. Passed on to the Spanish Nationalist air force a short while later, the CR.32 received the new code 3-51 when the identification system for Fiat fighters assigned to Spanish units changed. From early 1937 3-51 became the favoured aircraft of ranking Spanish Civil War ace Capitán García Morato. He would fly it for the rest of the conflict, scoring the bulk of his victories in the fighter. Parked to the right of the CR.32 in this photograph is a Nationalist Breguet 19 (*Dequal Family archive via Associazione 4^o Stormo*)



victories (plus 14 probables). Some 110 of these (and the 14 probables) had been claimed by Italian pilots, while 16 were credited to Spanish pilots. The destruction of two Potez twin-engined bombers, two airships and a balloon had been shared between pilots from Spain and Italy. A Spaniard and three Italians had scored five or more individual victories flying the CR.32, namely García Morato (11), Mantelli (nine), Montegnacco (seven) and Cenni (six). Of the 145 aerial successes claimed by CR.32 pilots, around 80 have been verified by historical research as representing actual losses suffered by the Republican air force.

As previously noted, 60 CR.32s had been sent to Spain by October 1936, and a similar number arrived from Italy between November and January. The bulk of these aircraft departed La Spezia aboard the *Aniene* in late December and arrived in Seville on 1 January 1937. Among the fighters supplied were 20 examples of the CR.32bis *quadriarmi* (four-gun). These machines boasted two 12.7 mm guns fitted above the forward fuselage and synchronised to fire through the propeller arc, as well as a pair of 7.7 mm guns housed within the lower wings. The CR.32bis was also fitted with the improved Fiat A 30 RAbis engine.

Accompanying the aircraft aboard the *Aniene* were eight engine mechanics, six riggers, eight armourers, three airmen of other categories and 33 fighter pilots. Leading the expedition was Tenente Colonello Alberto Canaveri (alias Franco Signorelli), who had orders to command the *Reggimento* or *Stormo da Caccia* of the *Aviazione Legionaria*. Other pilots included the *squadriglia* commanders, Capitani Armando François (alias Martori) and Luigi Lodi (alias Marcelli), Tenenti Enrico Degli Incerti (alias Tocci) and Alfiero Mezzetti (alias Mariani) and ten sottotenenti and 18 sottufficiali.

During a subsequent voyage from La Spezia that ended on 4 February 1937, *Aniene* delivered 12 more CR.32s, *squadriglia* commander Capitano Mario Viola (alias Viotti) and an additional 11 pilots – five sottotenenti and six sottufficiali.

With the arrival of these new fighters there were now sufficient aircraft in-theatre to organise the CR.32 *stormo* into two *gruppi* of three *squadriglie* each. These took the form of the already established I *Gruppo* (formerly *Gruppo Caccia di Torrijos*, which controlled the reorganised 1^a, 2^a and 3^a *Squadriglie*) under the leadership of Maggiore Fagnani, and II *Gruppo* (with the new *Squadriglie* 4^a, 5^a and 6^a) that was initially led by Tenente Colonello Canaveri.

At *Squadriglia* level, 1^a *Squadriglia* was led by Tenente Degli Incerti, 2^a *Squadriglia* by Capitano Nobili, 3^a *Squadriglia* by Tenente Ricci (followed by Capitani Lodi and Viola), 4^a *Squadriglia* by Capitano Dequal and 5^a *Squadriglia* by Capitano François. 6^a *Squadriglia* initially remained in reserve, although it was later commanded by Tenente Larsimont.

During the final weeks of 1936, following the appearance of

CR.32 NC 136 was serving with 2^a *Squadriglia*, I *Gruppo Caccia* of the newly formed *Aviazione Legionaria*, at Torrijos-Barcienne advanced airfield when this photograph was taken in January 1937. The 2^a *Squadriglia* had been led by Capitano Guido Nobili since 11 November 1936. Then still a future ace, he was held in great esteem by Spanish pilots and commanders alike (Dequal Family archive via Associazione 4^o Stormo)



increasing numbers of Soviet fighters on the Madrid front, Capitán García Morato and Salas complained to their superiors that their Italian commander, Maggiore Fagnani, was not being sufficiently aggressive in his pursuit of the enemy. This criticism grew more and more vociferous until Salas, who was leading a patrol, directly disobeyed an order from his CO not to cross the frontline into enemy territory. Fagnani attempted to have him arrested when he returned to base but García Morato intervened, protesting that in Spain nobody was arrested for displaying courage. The outcome of the ensuing discussions between García Morato and Salas was a decision to try to form their own independent squadron.

In early January the disgruntled pilots got their wish when five CR.32s were handed over to the Nationalist air force so that it could form the first all-Spanish unit equipped with the Fiat fighter. Christened the *Patrulla Azul* (Blue Patrol), it was commanded by Capitán García Morato, who had Capitán Bermúdez and Teniente Salvador as his wingmen. Morato recorded his first major success of the period on 3 January while defending Córdoba against two SB bombers;

‘After several days of studying the attacks on Córdoba, I had worked out when the bombers usually appeared, what altitude they were at and the direction from which they typically approached. Making full use of this information, I started flying standing patrols at a height of 16,500 ft over the city. One morning while circling over Córdoba I noticed two aircraft at a slightly lower altitude heading for the city at high speed. Heading towards them as fast as I could, I quickly identified the contacts as the two twin-engined bombers that had been regularly attacking Córdoba. I opened fire and hit one of the aircraft’s engines. This soon caught alight, leaving a trail of black smoke in its wake.

‘The stricken bomber turned around and headed back from whence it came, and I followed, hoping to see it crash. I also saw the second bomber turn back in the direction of home too. The damaged bomber did indeed crash some 40 miles from Córdoba near to the communist-held airport of Andujar, the aircraft being engulfed in flames.

‘As I turned for home, my fighter came under attack from the second “Martin bomber”. The latter had somehow got to within 1200 ft of me and it was firing at me with its two machine guns. This was a dangerous moment for me, as I was more than 20 miles from Nationalist territory. It had never dawned on me that the bomber crew would dare attack me! However, I remained cool, banked away sharply and then fired at the enemy. Luck was with me, as one of my bullets hit the aeroplane in a vital spot and within seconds it had spun away and hit the ground, exploding in flames barely a mile away from my first victim. I then flew back to Córdoba, where I was showered with hearty congratulations from the city’s civilian population.’

Maintenance work on CR.32s of Italian 2^a Squadriglia Caccia at Torrijos-Barcience at the end of February 1937. This advanced fighter base was designated Torrijos 37, while another small field near Torrijos that had been used from 1936 was called ‘Campo Baracca’ in honour of Italy’s leading World War 1 ace, Francesco Baracca (*Dequal Family archive via Associazione 4^o Stormo*)



Tenente Adriano Mantelli at Granada in February 1937 following his promotion for outstanding service in Spain. At this time, Mantelli was credited with ten individual and six shared victories. He remained the leading Italian ace in Spain until 20 March 1937 when his score was bettered by Montegnacco (Dequal Family archive via Associazione 4° Stormo)



The two SBs belonged to the 3a *Escuadrilla* of *Grupo* 12, with the first one being piloted by Spaniard Ananías Sanjuan Alonso. He was the sole survivor from the crash-landing, as observer Capitán Álvarez Rueda and gunner González Martos were both killed. In the second aircraft, pilot Nikolay Batov (alias Ivanov) of Bulgarian origin perished, as did observer 1Lt Vladimir Zotov and gunner Muñoz Hernández.

Tragedy struck 5a *Squadriglia* on 29 January when six CR.32s were lost, together with their pilots, in bad weather during an escort flight over enemy territory in the vicinity of the *Santuario de la Virgen de la Cabeza*, in Andalusia. Two pilots were killed and four taken prisoner. Among those captured was ace Sottotenente Cenni, who had taken to his parachute and landed at Pantano de Guadalmellato, from where he was driven to Valencia. He returned to Italy in July, along with four other CR.32 pilots, following a prisoner exchange organised by the Spanish branch of the International Red Cross.

— SUPPORTING THE *CORPO TRUPPE* — *VOLONTARIE*

The conquest of the Andalusian capital of Malaga, which was also an important Mediterranean port on Spain's south coast, in early February by Nationalist forces marked the successful combat debut of the *Corpo Truppe Volontarie*. Following an advance that was only sporadically opposed both in the air and on the ground by the Republicans, the *Corpo Truppe Volontarie*, supported by *Aviazione Legionaria*, units occupied Malaga on 8 February 1937. The aerial defence of the area then became the responsibility of CR.32s from 4a and 5a *Squadriglie*, based further inland at Granada. These units saw plenty of action as SB and Potez 540 bombers were being employed by the Republicans to attack advancing columns of Nationalist troops in a bid to halt their march eastwards beyond Malaga.

During the morning of 11 February a patrol from 4a *Squadriglia* consisting of the recently promoted Tenente Mantelli and his two wingmen intercepted a pair of Potez twin-engined bombers from the *Escadrille André Malraux*, based at Tabernas, near Almeria. Having already bombed Motril, the aircraft were heading east along the coast towards home, their progress being overseen by an escort of five I-15s led by high-scoring ace Lt Georgiy Zakharov (and including American pilots Baumler and Koch). The escort fighters were quite some distance away from the bombers, and at a height in excess of 16,000 ft, when the three CR.32s appeared unexpectedly from the south over the sea and intercepted the Potez bombers as they flew below the I-15s.

Mantelli quickly set a Potez 540 alight with his opening burst, although the French upper gunner, Lt René Deverts, returned fire. Two bullets hit the CR.32 in the oil tank, causing the engine to overheat. As Mantelli turned towards Nationalist territory, he was set upon by the I-15s and force-landed in enemy territory close to the frontline east of Motril – the latter had been occupied the night before by Italian troops. The pilot of Mantelli's Potez, Frenchman Guy Sentés, ditched his bomber just offshore near the village of Castell de Ferro despite being wounded in his right arm. His Indonesian co-pilot (of Dutch nationality), Jan Frederik Stolk, suffered serious chest wounds and died in a coma



One of the last Potez 540s still serving with the *Escadrille André Malraux* sits forlornly in the shallows east of Malaga and Motril, in Andalusia, near the village of Castell de Ferro. It was shot down by Adriano Mantelli on the morning of 11 February 1937, the bomber being his tenth, and last, individual victory in Spain (*Dequal Family archive via Associazione 4° Stormo*)

Motril. Having escaped unhurt, Mantelli managed to evade enemy militia that were roaming the area and reach Nationalist territory thanks to guidance from a local farmer. The pilot rewarded the latter with 100 pesetas for his assistance and soon met up with the vanguard of the *Corpo Truppe Volontarie*, returning to his unit five hours later. Once the front east of Motril had been secured, his fighter was also recovered.

Further north near Madrid, the CR.32 *Squadriglie* based at Torrijos were ordered to support a Nationalist offensive on the River Jarama front from mid February. It was hoped that success in this campaign would allow the encirclement of Madrid from the south. On the 13th, during a patrol in support of the offensive, three *Ratas* were shot down near Arganda. Maggiore Fagnani and Sergenti Montegnacco and Ruzzin were credited with a victory apiece. During the same aerial battle, an I-16 shot down the commander of 3^a *Squadriglia*, Capitano Lodi.

Flying his first operational mission, Lodi was at the controls of a CR.32bis four-gun fighter. As this loss clearly proved, the performance of the new variant was clearly not up to that achieved by the earlier twin-gun version. The main problem was that the weight associated with the two extra guns, and their ammunition, in the lower wings adversely affected the flight characteristics of the CR.32. They also weakened the overall wing structure. Such drawbacks had already been noticed during combat in Andalusia the previous month. Yet despite negative reports from other more seasoned Italian pilots on the Madrid front, Capitano Lodi had unwisely opted for a four-gun CR.32. Following his loss all CR.32bis in Spain had their wing armament removed.

During the afternoon of 14 February, the appearance of 40 Soviet fighters on the Jarama front was enough to deter the Spanish crews of six Ju 52/3ms from completing their bombing mission in spite of the tri-motors being escorted by 15 CR.32s and 18 He 51s of the *Legion Condor*. Capitano Nobili and his squadronmates fired at I-15s and I-16s as they attempted to attack the bombers, and crewmen from the latter reported seeing one of the Republican fighters falling to the ground.

Soviet fighters brought down a Ju 52/3m bomber flown by a Spanish crew over the Jarama front on the afternoon of 16 February.

some hours later, although the remaining four crewmen survived, three with injuries.

Mantelli's wingmen attacked the other bomber before the distant fighter escort could intervene, forcing it down into Republican territory near Dalías. The Potez 540 was damaged beyond repair and five of its seven-man crew were wounded.

The Republicans credited Zakharov with the destruction of Mantelli's CR.32, which had overturned along the banks of the River Guadalpece not far from

On this occasion the distant CR.32 fighter escorts could not intervene in time, although future ace Tenente Degli Incerti scored his first victory when he downed an I-15 whose destruction was confirmed by observers from the tri-motor formation.

That same day García Morato led his *Patrulla Azul* from Andalusia to Talavera-Veladas so that the Spanish fighter pilots could lend their support to the escalating campaign on the Jarama front.

On 17 February he was summoned to Salamanca by chief of the air force, Gen Alfredo Kindelán, who ordered him to intercept enemy aircraft even when outnumbered. He explained that the Republicans were close to securing air superiority over the frontline because fighter units of the *Aviazione Legionaria* were employing cautious tactics when outnumbered by Soviet fighters. Having clearly been swayed by Capitán Salas' vociferous complaints of late 1936, Kindelán believed that Italian CR.32 pilots had been ordered to avoid unnecessary losses by senior officers in the *Regia Aeronautica*.

Although more than a little perturbed by this instruction, García Morato duly took off on the morning of 18 February with two pilots (Bermudez and Salvador) from his section and intercepted a formation some 13 times their number near Arganda after completing a bomber escort mission. Disregarding recent orders restricting them from engaging superior numbers of enemy aircraft, Italian pilots Ricci, Degli Incerti, Nobili and Fiacchino went to the assistance of their Spanish comrades by leading their respective flights against the large Republican formation of Polikarpov fighters.

The air battle that ensued was considered to be the most demanding yet experienced by Nationalist forces according to those that participated in it. A total of 25 CR.32s (including the three fighters flown by the Spanish pilots) fought 21 I-15s and 18 I-16s, and the Italians emerged with claims for four 'Curtiss fighters' destroyed and five probables, as well as six *Ratas* destroyed and two probables. Of these, two I-15s and a probable were credited to Presel to make him an ace, two I-16s were claimed by Montegnacco and Degli Incerti also destroyed an I-16 and probably downed a pair of I-15s. The latter pilot described the action as follows;

'We were on the return leg of an escort mission, and having made sure that our bombers were safe, we had the airfield in sight and prepared to land. It was at that very moment that the three Spanish CR.32 pilots following us, but still flying over enemy territory, decided to take on a large Soviet formation. Although the enemy aircraft were still some distance away, we performed a hasty 180-degree turn at full throttle and joined the fray. All the Italian fighter flights following suit, despite us having orders only to intervene following provocation – our duty was to fight as courageously as possible to the end.



This CR.32 was part of the bis production series, examples of which began reaching *Regia Aeronautica* from April 1936. The aircraft was shipped to Spain at the end of that same year, where it was coded 3-1 and assigned to Capitano Armando François. The future ace was leader of the newly formed 5ª *Squadriglia Caccia di Aviazione Legionaria* from 19 January 1937. The CR.32 was the 'quadriarmi' (four weapons) version of the Fiat fighter, being equipped with two 12.7 mm weapons in the fuselage and two 7.7 mm machine guns in the lower wings. It was soon found that four machine guns adversely affected the fighter's handling in combat conditions, as the CR.32's engine had not been uprated to offset the weight associated with the two extra weapons, their ammunition and the structural reinforcements made to house them. All 'quadriarmi' were soon converted into 'biarmi' (two weapons) fighters, both in Spain and in Italy, through the replacement of their lower wings. The calibre of the fuselage weapons varied according to pilots' preferences (C Carlesi archive)

‘Once we had engaged the enemy, both sides formed a long line of aircraft, and this was turning, banking and circling. The fighters alternated in this single file trail, with two or three “Reds” for every Nationalist. It was as if this formation had been planned. Many tracer rounds flashed through the sky from the aircraft, turning the dogfight into an infernal ballet. Smoke trails of death suddenly appeared, and the long line broke into smaller rows.

‘The battle threw up numerous small skirmishes that ended inconclusively. Despite being outnumbered, we legionnaires stood together, compact, protecting each other. All of a sudden in the centre of the mêlée an aircraft caught fire and a parachute opened. The former fell away and crashed to the ground, while the latter floated away to safety. A “Red” had been shot down. Four of his comrades, fearing that we’d shoot at the pilot, circled him for his protection. Two CR.32s engaged them. This turn of events split the battle into two groups, within which fierce fighting continued.

‘The “Curtiss fighter” section then broke off their attack, unable to defeat our concentrated gunfire. They tried to escape, but this move failed and two of the stubby fighters fell in flames.

‘Thirty minutes into the battle, thousands of bullets had crossed the sky over Villaconejos. By now the revolving aircraft and chatter of the guns had diminished. The fighting faded slowly away, and within a short time we remained as the sole masters of the sky over the Jarama front.’

The Italians suffered no losses during this action, and only a solitary pilot was forced to make an emergency landing after he was wounded – the damage to his CR.32 was quickly repaired. Lt Ugrovatov (the alias of Soviet pilot Ivan Kopets), leading the I-15-equipped *Escuadrilla José*, and American pilot Harold Evans Dahl from *Escuadrilla Lacalle* parachuted to safety over friendly territory from their stricken I-15s. The former had been wounded when his aircraft was probably hit by Presel, while the latter fell victim to either Presel or Ruzzin. Another I-15 from *Escuadrilla Lacalle* was downed by Degli Incerti or Fiacchino, American pilot Benjamin David Leider perishing when he attempted a forced landing. Lt Zamashanskiy, patrol leader of the I-16-equipped *Eskadril'ya Kolesnikov*, was also killed trying to crash-land his fighter after it had been shot up by either Montegnacco or Degli Incerti.

The Spanish CR.32 pilots tasted success too, García Morato, who returned with damage to his fighter, being credited with shooting down an I-15 for his 18th victory. He also claimed a probable. Salvador was credited with downing an I-16, and he too claimed a second fighter as probably destroyed.

After the battle, García Morato thanked Tenente Ricci for coming to his aid, as he knew that he owed him his life following the Italian pilots’ timely intervention. Gen Kindelán recommended that García Morato be awarded the *Cruz Laureada de San Fernando* – Spain’s highest military honour for bravery. The Nationalist Government also exploited the success of this fight against the odds to lobby Italy for additional CR.32s.

There was more fighting over the Jarama front that evening when two I-16s were shot down. Nobili and Daffara shared one between them and Salvador was credited with the second *Rata*. During the morning of 20 February Nobili shot down an I-15 near Morata del Tajuna,

Capitán Joaquín García Morato poses with his faithful CR.32, 3-51, in 1937 (A Emiliani archive)





Italy's Spanish Civil War 'ace of aces' was Bruno Montegnacco, seen here in his *Aviazione Legionaria* uniform (A *Emiliani* archive)

his victim almost certainly being Teniente Bercial, who was a patrol leader from *Escuadrilla Lacalle*.

Despite these successes in the air, on the ground, the Nationalist offensive eventually ground to a halt southeast of Madrid during the last week of February. The Battle of Jarama had been yet another defensive success for the Republicans, although their victory had been achieved at a high price.

In March the *Corpo Truppe Volontarie* was transferred to central Spain following its success in the Malaga campaign. A new offensive was to be launched shortly after its arrival as the Nationalists focused on advancing north towards the principal city of Castilla Nueva province, Guadalajara. Its capture would be part of an encircling manoeuvre aimed at surrounding Madrid, Nationalist forces moving north from their positions to the west of the capital, as well as from newly won territory at Jarama. This pincer movement was also intended to cut off the capital from reinforcements brought in from northeast Spain. This audacious plan did not succeed, however, with Italian forces being defeated mainly because of an erroneous estimate of the size of the opposing Republican force at the start of the offensive. The *Corpo Truppe Volontarie's* position was further undermined by the increasingly uneasy relationship between the Nationalist allies.

In the air, support for the *Corpo Truppe Volontarie* advance by *Aviazione Legionaria* units based at Soria, Almazán and El Burgo de Osma was hampered by bad weather that often blighted operations from Nationalist airfields in the north-central region of the country. The latter were all located north of a mountain range that was often blanketed in cloud cover, thus rendering their crossing difficult – if not impossible – especially for fighters flying in formations. Indeed, the Italians well remembered the loss of six CR.32s, and their pilots, in adverse weather conditions in Andalusia on 29 January.

Conversely, Republican fighter and bomber units had at their disposal the best airfields in central Spain, namely Madrid-Barajas, Alcalá de Henares and Guadalajara, among others. All were within easy reach of the frontline, being devoid of physical barriers such as those facing the Nationalist units. Taking full advantage of this, the Republican squadrons conducted frequent ground attack missions against the *Corpo Truppe Volontarie*, safe in the knowledge that the CR.32s that were meant to be opposing them were more than likely weathered in back at their bases. With no effective air support, the Italian advance on Guadalajara ground to a halt within a fortnight.

Some CR.32 pilots enjoyed modest success during the campaign, however, with Montegnacco claiming the last aerial victory of the battle during the afternoon of 20 March. A patrol of four Fiat fighters under the command of Capitano Viola had taken off from El Burgo de Osma and subsequently bounced two I-15s flying at low altitude in the vicinity of Almadrones. Montegnacco shot one of the aircraft down in flames in spite of his opponent's violent evasive action, the pilot taking to his parachute and being captured. Montegnacco's victim, who suffered burns to his face and one hand, was 40-year-old Mexican Miguel García Granados. He had previously commanded the Guatemalan air force, with the rank of colonel, between 1930 and 1933!

UNIT REORGANISATION

In April 1937 *Aviazione Legionaria* CR.32 units were reorganised and increased in size. I and II *Gruppi* were disbanded, re-designated and replaced by two *Gruppi* that each controlled three *Squadriglie* as before. A third new *gruppo* was also formed, however. The latter, XVI *Grupprobotta Caccia* under the command of Maggiore Giuseppe Casero (alias Casetti), reunited 24^a *Squadriglia* (formerly 4^a *Squadriglia*, led by Capitano Brambilla), 25^a *Squadriglia* (formerly 5^a *Squadriglia*, led by Capitano François) and 26^a *Squadriglia* (formerly 3^a *Squadriglia*, led by Capitano Viola). The unit adopted the name *Gruppo Cucaracha*, which it inherited from the first *Tercio* CR.32 *squadriglia* in Spain. Its insignia was a winged Moroccan cockroach (synonymous with a popular song of the period), which was applied to the fuselage sides of the *gruppo*'s aircraft.

Future ace Maggiore Andrea Zotti (alias Biondi) assumed command of XXIII *Gruppo Caccia*, which grouped together 18^a *Squadriglia* (formerly 2^a *Squadriglia*, led by Capitano Nobili), 19^a *Squadriglia* (formerly 1^a *Squadriglia*, led by Capitano Degli Incerti) and 20^a *Squadriglia* (formerly 6^a *Squadriglia*, led by Capitano Larsimont). The *gruppo* was named *Asso di Bastoni* (ace of clubs) and its CR.32s were adorned with a marking adapted from Neapolitan playing cards showing a weapon used by the *squadre d'azione fasciste* (fascist action squads).

The unit's CO, Andrea Zotti, had been born in Asiago, in the Venetian region in October 1905. He had joined the *Regia Aeronautica*'s academy at the age of 20 and graduated in 1929 with the rank of tenente, having been placed third overall in the *Centauro* course class of 36. Following his training at the Ghedi Fighter Training School, Zotti was assigned to 1° *Stormo* at Campoformido. Here, he distinguished himself both as a capable *squadriglia* commander and accomplished aerobatics pilot. Zotti then moved to 5° *Stormo d'Assalto* at Ciampino, near Rome, before joining the Italian Military Mission in China in July 1934.

Whilst in Asia Zotti served as a flight instructor for Chinese pilots, and also as a test pilot for aircraft that had been imported from Italy by the Nationalist Government of Chiang Kai-shek. Amongst the types he flew were a handful of CR.32s. On returning to Italy in 1936 he went to the Florence Aerial Warfare School, and after being promoted to the rank of maggiore in April 1937 he volunteered for service in Spain.

VI *Gruppo Caccia*, led by Maggiore Eugenio Leotta (alias Leonello), consisted of two new *squadriglia* formed on 3 May 1937 – 31^a (led by Capitano Luigi Borgogno, alias Benigni) and 32^a *Squadriglie* (led by Capitano Ernesto Botto, alias Cantini). This unit was originally named *Gruppo Leonello*, but it later became known as *Diavoli Neri* (Black Devils). The *gruppo* was brought to its full strength of three *squadriglie* with the addition of the 33^a *Squadriglia* on 1 October of that same year.

Maggiore Andrea Zotti was commander of XXIII Gruppo Caccia of the Aviazione Legionaria from 22 April 1937 through to 23 July 1938, when he was promoted to the rank of tenente colonnello following his outstanding service in Spain. During his 15 months in action he was credited with nine individual and six shared victories, as well as two probables (A Emiliani archive)



The three Italian CR.32 *gruppi* in Spain were brought together under the control of 3° *Stormo Caccia dell'Aviazione Legionaria*, which was led by Tenente Colonnello Canaveri. The unit's designation was derived from the code number '3' which had been assigned as the aircraft identifier for the CR.32 in Nationalist service, for it was the third type of fighter to have been used by the air force following the Ni-H.52 and He 51.

Other CR.32s assigned to the *Aviazione Legionaria* were placed into three *Sezioni Allarme* (Alarm Sections) that were assigned point defence duty for key airfields, these aircraft operating independently from the *gruppi*. Finally, a unit of CR.32s continued to operate within the *Aviazione Legionaria delle Baleari*, providing local defence for the island of Majorca. It was subsequently reorganised on 10 July 1937 into autonomous unit X *Gruppo Autonomo Caccia*, commanded by Capitano Rolando Pratelli (alias Piccione), incorporating 101^a *Squadriglia* (led by Capitano Di Bernardo, alias Di Benedetto) and 102^a *Squadriglia* (led by Capitano Scapinelli, alias Salvini).

A further consignment of eight CR.32s was passed on to the Nationalist air force in April 1937, and they joined the five previously handed over four months earlier to form the basis of the first Spanish *grupo* equipped with Fiat fighters. *Grupo 2-G-3*, led by García Morato, consisted of 13 aircraft and 15 pilots, which were divided into two *escuadrillas* of six fighters each. The final CR.32 was García Morato's.

On 4 May the Spanish CR.32 *grupo* was officially formed at Córdoba. Of the pilots assigned to its *escuadrillas*, two of them had previously served as wingmen in the *Patrulla Azul*, while the remaining 12 were chosen according to their experience in fighters. The commander of *Escuadrilla* 1-E-3 was ace Teniente Julio Salvador Díaz, and his pilots were Teniente Miguel Guerrero García, Alféreces Manuel Vázquez Sagastizábal, Aristides García Lopez, Rafael Mazarredo Trenor and Jesús Rubio Paz and Brigada Ramón Senra Alvarez. *Escuadrilla* 2-E-3 was also led by an ace in the form of Capitán Ángel Salas Larrazabal, and his pilots were Capitán Narciso Bermudez de Castro and Javier Murcia Rubio,

Pilots of *Grupo 2-G-3* at Avila airfield in June 1937. They are, from left to right, Jorge Muntadas Claramunt (2-E-3), Javier Allende Isasi (2-E-3), Ángel Salas Larrazabal (leader of 2-E-3), Joaquín García Morato (group commander), Aristides García Lopez (1-E-3), Julio Salvador Díaz (leader of 1-E-3), Narciso Bermudez de Castro (2-E-3), Ramón Senra Alvarez (1-E-3), Miguel García Pardo (2-E-3), Joaquín Ansaldo Vejarano (2-E-3), Jesús Rubio Paz (1-E-3), Miguel Guerrero García (1-E-3), Rafael Mazarredo Trenor (1-E-3), Manuel Vázquez and Sagastizábal (1-E-3). Absent from this photograph is the 15th pilot of the group, Javier Murcia Rubio (2-E-3), who may have been the one taking this shot. Half of these pilots – García Morato, Salvador, Vázquez, García Lopez, Salas, Guerrero, García Pardo and Allende – became CR.32 aces with at least five individual victories to their credit during the Spanish Civil War (A Emiliani archive)



Teniente Miguel García Pardo and Alféreces Javier Allende Isasi, Joaquín Ansaldo Vejarano and Jorge Muntadas Claramunt.

Ace Teniente Guerrero had distinguished himself at the very beginning of the conflict flying the Ni-H.52 when he shot down four Republican aeroplanes over Andalusia between 25 July and 1 August 1936. Born in Figueras, Catalonia, on 5 January 1909, Guerrero entered the Infantry Academy in 1925 and subsequently graduated as a pilot in 1932. Assigned to fighter *Grupo* 12 in Granada, he was on leave in Jaén at the start of the revolt. Receiving an order from the Madrid government to assume control of Granada-Armilla airport, Guerrero instead joined the Nationalist rebels. Following missions in the Ro.37 and He 51, he joined the first Spanish CR.32 *grupo*. Guerrero displayed great skill as a pilot, although his large size made it awkward for him to fit comfortably in the cockpit of a CR.32. Fortunately for him he was never forced to bail out!

Fellow *Escuadrilla* 1-E-3 pilot, and future ace, Manuel Vázquez Sagastizábal was born on 17 October 1910 in Seville. A recreational pilot with the Andalusian Aero Club prior to the civil war, he had more than 100 flying hours in his logbook when the conflict commenced – Vázquez Sagastizábal was one of only a handful of pilots to have flown a Cierva autogyro, predecessor of the helicopter. When military rebels occupied the base of Tablada on 18 July, Vázquez Sagastizábal was one of a number of local Aero Club pilots to offer his services. These men were formed into a special unit flying formerly civilian light aircraft. Enrolled as a corporal, Vázquez Sagastizábal performed a number of reconnaissance flight over Andalusia, landing several times in Republican territory to garner information. In October 1936 he was promoted to alférez provisional.

Vázquez Sagastizábal's small stature earned him the nickname of *Patiño* (duckling) – a name that stuck even after he had become an ace and been made CO of an *escuadrilla*.

In early March 1937 Vázquez Sagastizábal was transferred to a He 51-equipped unit serving on the Asturian front, but at the end of the month he was recalled to Seville to join the first Spanish CR.32 *escuadrilla*, led by García Morato. He became the first auxiliary pilot to join the unit, as all of his squadronmates had been in the military prior to the civil war.

Another future high-scoring ace of *Escuadrilla* 1-E-3 was Arístides García López, who had been an auxiliary sergeant pilot trained to fly fighters and light bomber aircraft pre-war. Mobilising in support of the military rebels in Andalusia and sent to Tablada, he flew Breguet 19s that still bore Republican tricolour markings on the Granada front until he was shot down in error by a Ni-H.52 on 7 August. Fortunately, García López and his observer/rear gunner escaped unhurt.

On 1 January 1937 the future ace was shot down for a second time when his Breguet was hit by Republican anti-aircraft fire near

CR.32bis NC 597, shipped to Spain and assigned to *Escuadrilla* 1-E-3 at Seville-Tablada air base in April 1937, was initially coded 3-5 – this was subsequently changed to 3-54, however. The fighter was assigned to ace Capitán Miguel Guerrero García, who had claimed five individual victories in 1936 flying the Ni-H.52 (A *Emiliani* archive)





Two commanders, and aces, of the Spanish National Air Force, Ángel Salas Larrazabal and Joaquín García Morato. The former was the first CO of *Escuadrilla 2-E-3* and the latter led *Grupo 2-G-3* from May 1937. Aircraft assigned to the group had the 'Yoke and Arrows' symbol of *Falange Española Tradicionalista* painted within the black roundels on both fuselage sides. The *Patrulla Azul* emblem was applied to the port side only, this emblem consisting of a hawk, a bustard and a blackbird, all in blue. They referred to the first three pilots who served with the so-called 'Blue Patrol' from early 1937, namely its leader, García Morato, and wingmen Bermúdez de Castro and Salvador Díaz. In 1938 this marking became the emblem of all Spanish nationalist fighter units within the *Escuadra de Caza*, which was led by García Morato until war's end (*A Emiliani archive*)

these fighters over the Teruel front that he scored his first aerial victory on 16 April when he downed an SB bomber from *Grupo 12* near the Nationalist airfield of Calamocha. This was the one and only time that a pilot flying an He 51 managed to bring down a Tuploev bomber, as the latter was considerably faster than the German biplane fighter.

Grupo 2-G-3 inherited the emblem that had been used previously by the *Patrulla Azul*, namely three blue stylised birds (in honour of the first three pilots that formed the flight) diving from right to left. The central bird, a Hawk, was ahead of the others as it represented unit CO García Morato. Above it was Bermúdez, in the form of a Great Bustard, while below the Hawk was a Blackbird for Salvador. They were enclosed in a circular badge carried on the port side of the fin only, with the birds facing the aircraft's line of flight. Following the formation of the *grupo*, the motto '*VISTA, SUERTE Y AL TORO*' was added, comparing aerial combat to a traditional *corrida de toros* ('race of bulls', or bullfight).

BILBAO FRONT

Having held the line around Madrid in late 1936, the Republicans set about creating an effective ring of defences around the Spanish capital. Realising that there was no way of seizing the city in the immediate future, the Nationalists turned their attention to occupying the vulnerable provinces in the far north of the country that had become progressively isolated along the Atlantic coast from the Basque front in the east to the Asturian front in the west.

Nationalist troops, supported by air force units, duly launched an offensive against the Basque capital of Bilbao on 31 March 1937. Slow but steady progress was made over the next two months, with aerial cover being provided by the newly formed XVI *Gruppo Caccia*.

The unit's Sottufficiali Montegnacco and Presel of 26^a *Squadriglia*, then based at Vitoria, were the ranking CR.32 aces of the Spanish Civil War, and they both enjoyed some success in the air during this campaign. The only modern Republican aircraft opposing the Fiat fighters in the Basque region were a handful of I-15s flown by Spanish pilots of a single *escuadrilla*. As a result, the only aeroplane shot down by CR.32s on the Bilbao front in April was an I-15 that became Montegnacco's 12th victory on the 15th of that month. He noted in his diary;

'Defensive patrol over the Ochandiano front. Flight made up of Capitano Viola, Costantini, Comelli and myself. Above Villareal, a "Curtiss fighter" managed to escape the commander's attack, despite the

The wreckage of CR.32 NC 208, coded 3-2, of XVI Gruppo Caccia's 26^a Squadriglia. This aircraft was being flown by ace Guido Presel when he was shot down and killed on 5 June 1937 near San Juan de Somorrostro, west of Bilbao, in northern Spain. Prior to his demise, Presel and his comrades from 26^a Squadriglia had attacked the Republican airfield at Somorrostro, destroying five I-15s on the ground in a series of strafing passes – one of them had been credited to the ace, and he had sent a second I-15 crashing in flames as it attempted to take off. Some minutes later, short of ammunition following the strafing runs, Presel's CR.32 was attacked by an I-15 flown by Spanish pilot Rafael Magriña Vidal and shot down into the sea near a local beach. During 302 days of service in Spain, Presel had been credited with 12 individual and ten shared aerial victories, two probables and two strafing victories (A Emiliani archive)



latter getting very close to him. My attack took him by surprise as he came out of cloud, setting him on fire. The pilot, who was hit in the head and various other parts of his body, could not escape by parachute and he fell with his aircraft close to Villareal.'

The I-15 pilot who perished was Sargente José Rodríguez Cueva.

Towards the end of May additional I-15s were flown up to the Bilbao front in an effort to reinforce the North Air Zone, these machines re-equipping the local *escuadrilla* that was led by Teniente Baquedano. The unit was based at San Juan de Somorrostro, which was located on the coast west of Bilbao. It also had fighters detached at Sondica.

During the afternoon of 4 June, ten CR.32s from 26^a Squadriglia, led by Capitano Viola, clashed with 16 I-15s between the Republican *escuadrilla*'s two bases. Italian pilots claimed to have shot down seven 'Curtiss fighters' without loss, Viola being credited with two individual victories and Presel one. Although both sides drastically overestimated their claims, Spanish I-15 pilot Marcelino Alonso Romero did indeed lose his life during this encounter. The following morning, Presel wrote in a letter addressed to his family in Italy, 'After a lull of many days we performed a magnificent flight that has once again permitted us to defeat our adversaries. I have increased my tally of destroyed aircraft, which now stands at 14 on my own, plus ten together with the *squadriglia*, placing me at the top of the list of aces. And to think that it's not over yet.'

Several hours after completing his letter, Presel participated in a patrol generated by 26^a Squadriglia that culminated in the CR.32 pilots strafing Somorrostro airfield. They destroyed six I-15s of *Escuadrilla Baquedano* on the ground, two of which were hit by Presel and one by Montegnacco. The latter also shot down another I-15 in the vicinity of Castro Urdiales.

Twenty minutes after the attack on the airfield had commenced, Teniente Rafael Magriña Vidal appeared over the base after returning from Santander in a repaired I-15. Diving on the CR.32s out of the sun, Magriña immediately latched onto the tail of the patrol leader Tenente Ricci, taking him by surprise. The latter pilot, who had been concentrating on strafing Republican fighters at low level and low speed, now found himself in grave danger. Presel quickly came to his aid, but without opening fire, as he had either used up all his ammunition or his guns had jammed after his long strafing attacks.

The ace's timely intervention allowed Ricci to shake off his opponent, who made a sharp turn to the left and went after Presel's CR.32 instead. The Italian, flying at 1500 ft, was in a banking turn to the right at the time. Making the most of the I-15's manoeuvrability, and the Fiat fighter's limited speed following Presel's low-level strafing attack, Magriña succeeded in getting in behind the CR.32 and shooting it down into the sea just offshore. Presel was killed before the aircraft hit the water, having been

shot through his right side and his neck. The ace's body and his wrecked aeroplane were retrieved a short while later and briefly displayed on the sandy beach. Magriña himself arranged for Presel's burial in a cemetery near to the town of San Juan.

During his brief military career Sergente Maggiore Guido Presel had been decorated with two Silver and two Bronze Medals for Military Valour, and he posthumously received Italy's highest military honour, the Gold Medal for Valour. The ace's final tally stood at 12 individual and ten shared aerial victories, two probables and two I-15s destroyed on the ground during his last flight (one of which, according to Ricci's testimony, caught fire on the runway just after take-off and could therefore be considered as his 13th kill). Magriña fell in combat to a Bf 109 whilst flying an I-16 near Santander a few weeks later. Around his neck when he died was the scarf originally worn by Guido Presel.

On 9 June, just four days after the Italian ace's demise, Bilbao finally fell to the Nationalists.

BRUNETE AIR BATTLE

Following reinforcement with military supplies and aircraft from the Soviet Union, which permitted the reorganisation of its *Ejército Popular*, the Republicans launched a massive offensive on the central front during the night of 6 July 1937. The town of Brunete, just 15 miles to the west of Madrid, was quickly occupied, but a stout Nationalist rearguard action prevented more ground being lost. A high price was paid both in men and materiel, and the Republicans also suffered terrible casualties during the battles that were fought throughout the Castilian summer of 1937.

Initially, the defence of the central front was supported by just the two CR.32 *squadriglie* present in this area at Torrijos-Barcience – 19^a and 20^a from XXIII *Gruppo*, commanded by Maggiore Zotti, with *squadriglia* commanders Capitani Degli Incerti and Larsimont. Nobili's 18^a *Squadriglia* was transferred in from Soria to reinforce these units, thus completing the makeup of the *gruppo*. The latter now had 29 CR.32s available, but only 17 of these remained serviceable following a series of actions on 6–7 July. Maggiore Casero's XVI *Gruppo* (24^a, 25^a and 26^a *Squadriglie*, led by Brambilla, François and Viola, respectively, although the latter was recalled to Italy and replaced by Tenente Ricci on 11 July) arrived at Torrijos-Barcience from Avila three days later, as did six CR.32s from García Morato's *Grupo* 2-G-3.

On 6 July, 19^a and 20^a *Squadriglie* participated in four separate aerial battles near Brunete, engaging Republican formations twice in the morning and twice in the afternoon. Three 'light bombers', one 'Martin bomber', seven 'Curtiss fighters' and five *Ratas* were claimed, but Sottotenente Vercellio from 19^a *Squadriglia* was killed during the third encounter. One of the I-16s destroyed was credited to future ace Maggiore Zotti as his first victory, its pilot taking to his parachute over the battlefield at Villanueva de la Cañada. Another *Rata* downed minutes later was credited to Capitano Degli Incerti, who subsequently recalled;

'Each one of us chose his quarry and the *mêlée* began. Our guns splendidly spat out a barrage, and our adversaries replied in kind. It was a matter of life or death. I pounced on a *Rata* and shot at it. It appeared that I had scored a direct hit. I kept following him until I thought that he



CR.32bis NC 601, coded 3-57, was assigned to *Gruppo 2-G-3* and flown by group commander García Morato during the battle of Brunete in July 1937. His usual mount, NC 262 3-51, was unserviceable at this time (A *Emiliani archive*)

Capitano Enrico Degli Incerti, alias Valentino Tocci, led 1^a *Squadriglia* within I *Gruppo Caccia* followed by XXIII *Gruppo Caccia*'s 19^a *Squadriglia* from 15 January to 15 November 1937. Note the *gruppo* emblem *Asso di Bastoni* (Ace of Clubs) sewn onto Degli Incerti's flying jacket, this marking also being applied to the fuselages of the unit's CR.32s. During ten months of service in Spain Degli Incerti was credited with eight individual and five shared victories, plus three probables. He was killed in a flying accident in Italy on 22 July 1938. A short while after his death a book detailing Degli Incerti's experiences in Spain was published, the author being named as Valentino Tocci (Author archive)



was clearly falling away. However, as I broke off my chase he zigzagged, dropped a little further and then climbed. He attempted to turn onto my tail, so I quickly hit him again. He pulled up abruptly after diving down a few hundred feet, so I fired at him once more. It looked to me as if the bullets had found their mark – the tracers clearly indicated that I was aiming correctly – but the *Rata* pilot continued to defend himself.

'I persevered with my foe, despite now feeling that I was possibly coming under attack. I looked over my shoulder and spotted three enemy aeroplanes, still at a distance, heading in my direction with their guns blazing. Moments later my prey finally fell headlong into a thickly wooded area. Staying with him had made me lose precious height, and as I looked up I could see that the fighting was still continuing above me.

'I climbed back up into the battle at full throttle, and saw a "Red" aeroplane chasing a Fiat. Turning tightly, I managed to get in behind the pursuing fighter. He then tried to disengage, but I made the most of my superior position and fired several long bursts at him. I succeeded in forcing him to take flight. Other enemy survivors duly abandoned the fight, and we reformed on our leader after he wagged his wings. We all landed with visible scars of battle on our aircraft.'

The pilot that had been shot down by Degli Incerti was almost certainly Lt Trusov, who had been in Spain for just a matter of weeks. A damaged I-16 force-landed in Nationalist territory and its pilot, Lt Khozjainov, was taken prisoner.

Another air battle was fought between Madrid and Brunete during the morning of 7 July when 14 CR.32s of 19^a and 20^a *Squadriglie*, led by Maggiore Zotti, encountered nine I-15s and eight I-16s that were escorting nine R-Zs (improved R-5 SSSs). The Republican aircraft were joined by other flights from a formation of 20 I-16s as they flew over Madrid. Italian pilots were credited with shooting down seven 'Curtiss fighters' during the clash, one of which was claimed by Zotti. Three *Ratas* were also destroyed, one of which was credited to Degli Incerti, while Sergente Maggiore Mattei downed an R-Z but was then forced to take to his parachute after his CR.32 was hit by return fire from the Polikarpov light bomber. He landed in Nationalist territory near Pozuelo de Alarcón.

After claiming his I-15, Zotti shared the destruction of a second biplane fighter with his two wingmen. Ten minutes later, however, his CR.32 was shot up by an I-16, the Italian being wounded in the thigh. His engine was also hit, and as it began to overheat Zotti was forced to land at nearby Griñón airfield. Sergente Maggiore Passeri from 19^a *Squadriglia* protected his CO until he was safely down, only to then be bounced by another I-16 upon rejoining the battle and killed. Three I-15s from 1^a *Escuadrilla* were lost, with Karpov killed, Shalhiganov wounded and Austrian Walter Koraus surviving unscathed. Flight leader Serov and his wingman Yakushin managed to nurse their badly damaged biplanes back to base. Dhyakonov, who was leading an I-16 flight,

suffered serious wounds in combat possibly from Degli Incerti's gunfire, and he died later that day after landing in Republican territory.

Grupo 2-G-3 lost its first CR.32 in combat near Brunete on 10 July when Rubio Paz's aircraft was attacked by an I-16, although the pilot survived by parachuting into Nationalist territory. Capitán Bermúdez was not so lucky two days later, however, when he became the first Spaniard to be killed flying a CR.32 – the veteran pilot fell victim to an I-15.

Aerial battles involving CR.32s continued for the rest of the month, with García Morato claiming five individual kills, Aurili four, François three and Montegnacco and Baschirotto two each by the end of July.

Most of these engagements took place whilst the CR.32 units supported the Nationalist counteroffensive on the Brunete front, which had commenced during the evening of 18 July. That day, 23 CR.32s from XVI *Gruppo* and four from 2-G-3 intercepted a formation of 12 light bombers, escorted by 32 I-15s and I-16s, between Valdemorillo and Navalcarnero. Italian pilots were credited with 14 victories – eight light bombers (R-Zs from *Grupo 30*), five *Ratas* and a 'Curtiss fighter' – for the loss of Tenente Mollo from 26^a *Squadriglia*. One of the R-Zs was claimed by García Morato, whose tally now stood at 26 victories (he had claimed four in 48 hours on 14-15 June).

Six R-Zs and at least three of the fighters claimed by the CR.32 pilots were actually lost, both François and Aurili downing light bombers to give them their fifth individual victories. Two of the *Ratas* were credited to Montegnacco, whose tally now stood at 15 individual victories. Of this action he wrote;

'Fighter escort for bombing raid over the Brunete-Valdemorillo front. *Gruppo* formation. Collective attack on enemy "Praga" (Aero A-101 light bomber) aircraft. I spotted three *Ratas* diving down at us from above, and I tried to disrupt their attack by throwing myself straight at them. I shot one down and forced another to break away from us. The third fighter, rolling onto its back, caught up with Tenente Ricci and hit him with a round that, fortunately, only perforated his parachute. Seeing more *Ratas*, I quickly despatched a second Republican fighter but couldn't follow it all the way to the ground as I was attacked by two "Curtiss fighters". My first *Rata* fell east of Valdemorillo and the second crashed a short distance away from it.'

Operations on the Brunete front came to an end on 27 July when both sides consolidated their defensive positions. Despite the ferocity of the fighting both on the ground and in the air, little had changed territorily to the west of Madrid. XXIII *Gruppo Caccia* was awarded the *Medalla Militar Colectiva* (Collective Military Medal) by Gen Franco following its performance during the first few days of the Republican offensive. Two pilots from the unit had lost their lives in combat and three had been wounded, yet the *gruppo* continued to engage a numerically superior enemy until reinforcements were brought in.



CR.32bis production series fighters NC 596 and NC 589, coded 3-60 and 3-62, respectively, served with the Spanish *Escuadrilla 2-E-3*, led by Capitán Salas. Both were involved in the battle of Brunete, with 3-60 being flown by ace Teniente García Pardo and 3-62 falling victim to a Soviet fighter on 12 July 1937. Its pilot, Capitán Bermúdez de Castro was killed. The latter was in fact the first Spaniard to lose his life in action flying a CR.32. Prior to his demise, Bermúdez was credited with one aerial victory in the Ni-H.52 and three more with the CR.32 (A Emiliani archive)

Sergente Maggiore Gianlino Baschirotto poses with his CR.32 3-5 in the summer of 1937. Serving with 24^a *Squadriglia* of XVI *Gruppo Caccia*, Baschirotto was one of only two Italian pilots to be officially credited with five or more individual victories both in Spain and in World War 2. The other ace to achieve this feat was Vittorino Daffara (A Emiliani archive)



And despite the Republicans' Brunete offensive, the Nationalist advance through northern Spain continued. Its primary aim was to capture the region's principal town and port, Santander, and both the *Corpo Truppe Volontarie* and the *Aviazione Legionaria* played a key part in achieving this.

Fighter units initially assigned to this operation were 31^a and 32^a *Squadriglie* of VI *Gruppo*, as neither was involved in operations on the Madrid front. By early July they had been transferred to the advanced base of Villarcayo. Commanding 32^a *Squadriglia* was future ace Capitano Ernesto Botto (alias Cantini), who would subsequently claim more victories than any other CR.32 pilot involved in the Santander campaign.

Botto was born on 8 November 1907 in the industrial city of Turin, home of the Fiat establishment where the CR.32 was designed and produced. Upon graduating from Turin's Technical Institute of Physics and Mathematics, he joined the *Regia Aeronautica's* Aeronautical Academy in October 1929. He was promoted to the rank of tenente in July 1933 and assigned to the *Scuola Caccia Terrestre*, before joining the *Reparto Alta Velocità* (High Speed Unit) at Desenzano. Promoted to capitano in October 1936, Botto moved to 4^o *Stormo Caccia* as CO of the CR.32-equipped 84^a *Squadriglia*, in Gorizia, in January 1937. He volunteered for duty in Spain in April 1937, where he assumed command of 32^a *Squadriglia* within the newly formed VI *Gruppo Caccia*.

Botto's first encounter with Republican fighters came on 16 July northwest of Monte Maza, on the Santander front, when his patrol of five CR.32s was bounced from above by 13 I-16s. Seeing the diving enemy aircraft just in time to climb up at them, the Italian pilots duly fought a series of individual clashes that lasted for more than 20 minutes. Despite facing two or three opponents at a time, the CR.32 pilots managed to down two I-16s without loss – both kills were confirmed by Nationalist observers at Monte Maza. They were collectively credited to all five pilots, as none of them had had the time to notice that enemy fighters had in fact been downed during the course of this exhausting engagement!

Botto's first individual victories came on 6 August when he was credited with destroying two I-16s that attempted to intercept a pair of Ro.37 reconnaissance aircraft that he was escorting between Selaya and Torrelavega. He claimed two more kills 16 days later near Ontaneda when 11 CR.32s from 32^a *Squadriglia* clashed with 12 I-15s from *Escuadrilla Galindo*. Italian pilots claimed four destroyed and five probables. Teniente Miguel Galindo Saura, CO of the Republican unit, was injured when he bailed out near Puerto del Escudo and was captured, while squadronmate Ángel Martín González died when he crashed trying to force-land his battle-damaged I-15 near Suances.

On 23 August ten CR.32s from 32^a *Squadriglia* (one of which was flown by VI *Gruppo* CO Maggiore Leotta) fought yet more I-15s as the



Capitano Ernesto Botto, third from left, is seen here with other pilots from his 32^a *Squadriglia*, VI *Gruppo Caccia* of the *Aviazione Legionaria* at Villarcayo airfield west of Vitoria, in northern Spain. These pilots saw considerable action over the Santander front in July-August 1937. During his service in Spain Botto was credited with five individual and 15 shared victories in total, four individual and ten shared being claimed on the Santander front in August 1937 (A Emiliani archive)

latter tried to defend Santander from being attacked. Italian pilots claimed three 'Curtiss fighters' destroyed and three probables, and their demise was again collectively attributed to all participants from 32^a *Squadriglia*. The only loss admitted by the Republicans, however, was Francisco De Antonio Sanz, who was shot down near Ontaneda.

Three days later the last defenders of Santander surrendered and the port was occupied by Nationalist and Italian troops. During the course of operations on the northern front in July and August 1937, Italian pilots had claimed 15 verified kills without suffering a single loss in return.

ARAGON AIR BATTLES

In an attempt to slow down Nationalist advances in the north and seize the military initiative in this area, the Republicans launched an offensive in Aragon (between Zuera and Belchite) during the night of 24 August. The Nationalists immediately bolstered the aerial defence of the Aragon front by sending XXIII *Gruppo Caccia* to Saragossa-Sanjurjo. Led by Tenente Colonello Zotti, the *gruppo* was comprised of 18^a, 19^a and 20^a *Squadriglie*, led by Nobili, Degli Incerti and Larsimont, respectively. On 25 August these units were joined by the CR.32s of Capitán García Morato's *Grupo 2-G-3* and Maggiore Casero's XVI *Gruppo*, consisting of 24^a, 25^a and 26^a *Squadriglie*, led by Capitani Brambilla and François and Tenente Alfiero Mezzetti, respectively. Finally, Maggiore Leotta's VI *Gruppo* was also transferred in with its 31^a and 32^a *Squadriglie*, led by Borgogno and Botto.

Between 25 and 29 August XXIII *Gruppo* clashed with enemy aircraft on six occasions over the Aragon front, claiming seven light bombers (R-Zs), ten 'Martin bombers' (SBs), seven *Ratas* and eight 'Curtiss fighters' (I-15s) destroyed and two probables for the loss of three CR.32s and two pilots killed. Ace Degli Incerti was also wounded in action and hospitalised for two weeks. At least ten of the 32 aerial victories that were claimed as confirmed can be matched to Republican losses. The most successful CR.32 pilot during the offensive was Zotti, who claimed four victories, followed by Degli Incerti with three and Nobili with two.

During that same period XVI *Gruppo* encountered the enemy just once, on 28 August near Fuentes de Ebro. Its pilots claimed two *Ratas* and five 'Curtiss fighters' destroyed and three as probables, for the loss of three CR.32s and three pilots taken prisoner. The Republicans appear to have lost only one I-15, however.

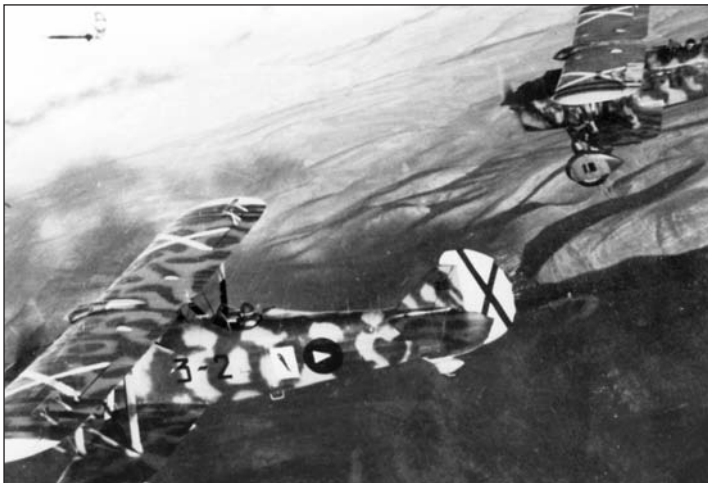
Although unable to add to their tally during the defence of the Aragon front in late August, the pilots of García Morato's *Grupo 2-G-3* enjoyed

success in the Belchite area on 1 September. The Spaniards claimed five I-15s and two I-16s destroyed, with Ángel Salas and Julio Salvador being credited with two victories apiece and García Morato, Allende and Careaga one each.

Having taken his burgeoning tally to 27 kills with this success, García Morato was sent on an eight-week-long technical mission

Capitano Guido Nobili (alias Notabili), leader of 18^a *Squadriglia* within XXIII *Gruppo Caccia* of the *Aviazione Legionaria* from 23 April to 3 December 1937, flies a patrol over the Aragon front in his CR.32 NC 29, coded 3-2, in the autumn of that year. Nobili was already an ace by the time this photograph was taken, having claimed eight individual and 12 shared victories and two probable since November 1936 (Author's archive)





to Italy at the end of September. Command of *Grupo 2-G-3* duly passed to Capitán Salas, while fellow ace García Pardo headed up 2-E-3.

The Republicans launched another new offensive in October, this time aimed at seizing Saragossa, but it again failed. That same month, fighter clashes in Aragon were limited to two clashes on the 12th. In the first encounter of the day, over Mediana, 13 I-15s from 1^a *Escuadrilla* of *Grupo 26* (commanded by Capt Antonov) and 19 I-16s from 2^a and 6^a *Escuadrillas* of *Grupo 21* (led by 1Lts Pleshchenko and Gusev) exploited their numerical advantage against 18 CR.32s – nine each from 31^a and 32^a *Squadriglie*, led by Borgogno and Botto, respectively. Five Italian fighters were lost, two of them colliding in mid-air. One pilot was killed and four were taken prisoner, although one of the latter was subsequently executed after a shoot out with his captors. Three more CR.32s returned to base badly damaged.

On a more positive note, Botto was credited with his fifth individual victory when he shot down an I-16, only to be badly wounded minutes later. Despite his right foot being all but severed by a bullet, he somehow

Nobili's CR.32, seen over the Aragon front during the of autumn 1937, bears the white triangular badges within its black roundels indicating that it was assigned to a *squadriglia* leader. A white triangle was also painted onto the skinning of the auxiliary fuel tank fitted to the uppersurface of the top wing (A Emiliani archive)

Pilots and groundcrew of VI *Gruppo Caccia* come together for a group photograph in September 1937 at Alfamen airfield in Aragon. The group had been transferred here from Villarcayo to operate over the Belchite front. Standing fifth from the left is the group commander, Maggiore Eugenio Leotta, while seventh from the left, again standing, is ace, and 32^a *Squadriglia* leader Capitano Ernesto Botto. Between them is Sottotenente Vittorio Barberis (alias Vittorio Fantini) of 32^a *Squadriglia*, who was killed in action on 10 December 1937 near Alcubierre when his CR.32 collided with I-15 CC-022, flown by Soviet pilot Mikhail Vasilhevich Kothikhov from 1^a *Escuadrilla* of *Grupo 26*. The latter pilot also perished. Barberis had been credited with two shared victories against I-16s on 16 July 1937 whilst on a patrol with Botto and three other pilots from 32^a *Squadriglia* between Puerto del Escudo and Monte Maza. He was serving on the Santander front at the time (Author archive)





CR.32 NC 262 3-51, flown by Joaquín García Morato on the Aragon front, is seen here in the late summer of 1937. Between 1936 and 1939, this aircraft received at least two numerical codes (3-17 and 3-51) and six different two- and three-colour camouflage schemes (A *Emiliani archive via E Santandrea*)

Spanish ace Capitán Ángel Salas Larrazábal and his CR.32bis NC 331, coded 3-63. He flew this aircraft while leading *Escuadrilla 2-E-3*, and he took it with him when he was given command of *Grupo 2-G-3* in mid-September 1937. The titling **BERMUDEZ PRESENTE** on the fuselage honoured the memory of the first Spanish CR.32 pilot to be killed in action, Capitán Narciso Bermúdez de Castro (A *Emiliani archive*)



managed to return to base at Saragossa-Sanjurjo – saving his aircraft in the process. Botto's right leg was subsequently amputated, and he had to undergo further extensive surgery that involved ten blood transfusions. The ace was hospitalised in Saragossa for nearly six months before returning home to Italy in May 1938. There, Botto was publicly decorated with the Gold Medal for Military Honour

in Rome by Mussolini himself. Meanwhile, back in Spain, VI *Gruppo Caccia* had both adopted his name and created the now famous *Gamba di Ferro* (Iron Leg) unit emblem in his honour.

Other pilots who returned from the grim 12 October clash were credited with downing four 'Curtiss fighters' and nine *Ratas*. This tally was hugely optimistic, as Republican documentation shows the loss of only two I-16s and an I-15, together with two I-16s and an I-15 damaged.

At around midday on the 12th XXIII *Gruppo* engaged a formation of I-15s and I-16s over Fuentes de Ebro. Zotti was credited with downing an I-15 and fellow ace Degli Incerti claimed an I-16.

As the Saragossa front offensive petered out the Nationalists conquered Gijón, in Asturia, on 21 October, thus completing the occupation of formerly Republican territories in northern Spain. With the seizure of this region, Nationalist troops, naval vessels and aircraft could now be transferred to other operational areas.

Shipments of CR.32s to Spain continued throughout this period, allowing 33^a *Squadriglia* to be formed on 1 November. Led by Capitano Vizzotto, it was assigned to VI *Gruppo* to bring the unit up to full strength. *Grupo 3-G-3* was established the following month, with Comandante José Ibarra Montis as its CO. The unit was comprised of *Escuadrillas* 3-E-3 and 4-E-3, led by Capitanes Javier Murcia Rubio and Manrique Montero Mera, respectively.

On 8 December a foreign pilot who had fought in Spain on the Nationalist side for more than a year joined *Grupo 2-G-3*. Rodolphe Charles Geofrey de Hemricourt de Grunne Montalembert was born on 18 November 1911 in Brussels. The fourth son of a Belgian count and

a French countess, his childhood was spent with his parents both in England and France during World War 1 following the German invasion of Belgium. Returning to his homeland in 1918, de Hemricourt was then enrolled in a Belgian religious college. Finishing his tertiary studies in Casablanca, French Morocco, he graduated as an agricultural engineer.

In 1933 de Hemricourt returned to Belgium for his military service,



and disappointed at not having been selected for flying training due to a slight imperfection in his sight in one eye, he served in the cavalry as an auxiliary officer until late September 1934. That same year de Hemricourt enrolled in a flying course at the Royal Belgian Aero Club, and in 1935 he obtained his civil flying licence.



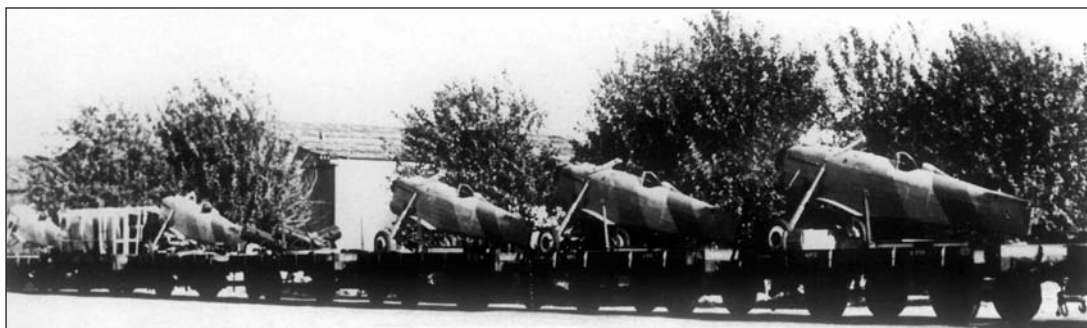
Bored with his aristocratic lifestyle, he unexpectedly left the comfort of the family castle at Aeltre following the start of the Spanish Civil War and travelled through France to reach Nationalist-controlled northern Spain. Crossing the Pyrenees on 1 October 1936 with the aide of Spanish monarchists of his acquaintance, de Hemricourt volunteered to fight communism. He duly joined the *Falange* militia and fought on the Santander front as an infantryman until he was wounded in the right leg on 19 November. Whilst recovering in Burgos hospital, he met a wounded Spanish pilot who advised him to join the Nationalist air force.

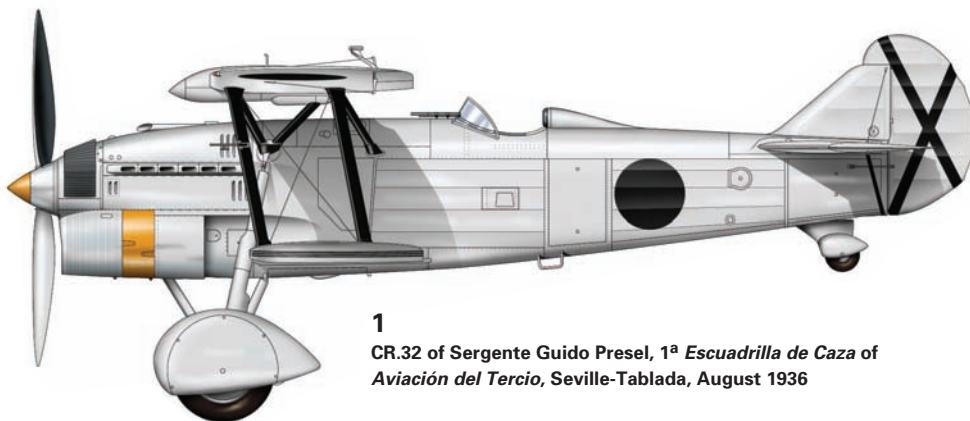
On leaving the hospital de Hemricourt presented himself as civilian pilot to Gen Kindelán at the General Staff in Salamanca, requesting to be transferred to the air service. On 1 December he was enrolled in the *Tercio Extranjero* and sent to the flying school at Seville-Tablada. After two months of service flying He 46 light bombers, de Hemricourt was transferred to a unit equipped with He 51 fighters on 1 March 1937. He flew these aircraft in the ground attack role for the next eight months, before being briefly assigned to a Ro.37 light bomber *escuadrilla* and then finally to CR.32-equipped *Grupo* 2-G-3.

The damaged CR.32bis NC 623 which was flown back to Saragossa-Sanjurjo airfield by badly wounded 32^a *Squadriglia* leader Capitano Ernesto Botto on 12 October 1937. Despite being struck in his right leg by a bullet from an I-16 that broke his femur and caused heavy blood loss, Botto was able to fly back to base. The fighter's upper wingtip was damaged in the heavy landing (A Emiliani archive)

Capitano Ernesto Botto at Saragossa-Sanjurjo airfield, shortly before returning to Italy in May 1938. Botto featured in the Italian propaganda film *Los Novios de la Muerte* (*The Fiances to the Death*) about the *Aviazione Legionaria* without giving his real name, or his alias. Instead, he used the by now well-known nickname *Gamba di ferro* or 'Iron leg', which was adopted by VI *Gruppo Caccia* in Spain and IX *Gruppo* during World War 2, which Maggiore Botto led (A Emiliani archive via E Santandrea)

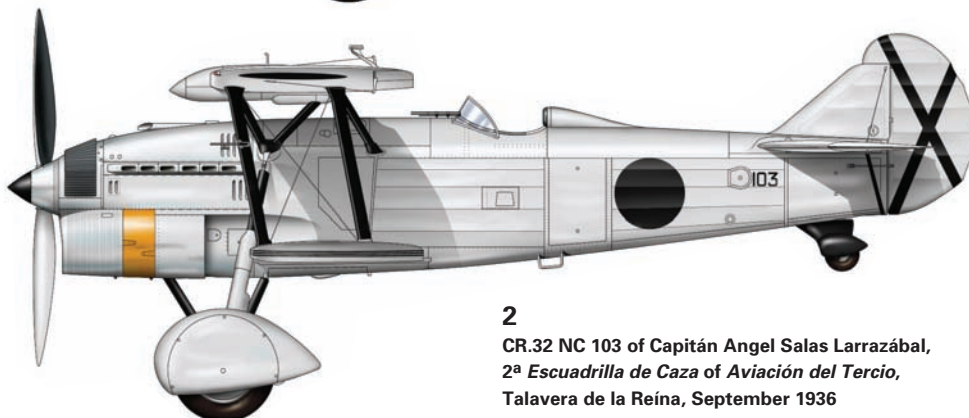
In late November 1937, 30 newly built CR.32ter were shipped from La Spezia to Seville aboard the steamer *Aniene*. They were delivered to the *Aviación Nacional*, who in turn passed 25 examples on to the newly formed *Grupo de Caza* 3-G-3's *Escuadrillas* 3-E-3 and 4-E-3 in December. The remaining five fighters were given to 3^o *Stormo Caccia* of the *Aviazione Legionaria*. Some of the aircraft are seen here being transported by train from Seville's fluvial harbour to Tablada airfield for assembling. They are painted in the standard camouflage scheme then in use by the *Regia Aeronautica*, but rarely retained in Spain (A Emiliani archive)





1

CR.32 of Sergente Guido Presel, 1ª Escuadrilla de Caza of Aviación del Tercio, Seville-Tablada, August 1936



2

CR.32 NC 103 of Capitán Angel Salas Larrazábal, 2ª Escuadrilla de Caza of Aviación del Tercio, Talavera de la Reina, September 1936



3

CR.32 of Sottotenente Adriano Mantelli, 2ª Escuadrilla de Caza of Aviación del Tercio, Cáceres, September 1936



4

CR.32 of Sottotenente Giuseppe Cenni, 1ª Escuadrilla de Caza of Aviación del Tercio, Talavera de la Reina, September-October 1936



5

CR.32 NC 105 of Sergente Maggiore Guido Presel,
3ª Escuadrilla de Caza of Aviación de el Tercio,
Torrijos-Barcience, November 1936



6

CR.32 NC 183 of Sergente Maggiore Bruno Montegnacco,
3ª Squadriglia, I Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria
Seville-Tablada, December 1936-January 1937



7

CR.32bis quadriarmi of Capitano Armando François, leader
of 5ª Squadriglia, II Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria,
Granada-Armilla, February 1937



8

CR.32bis NC 508 of Teniente Julio Salvador Díaz Benjumea,
Patrulla Azul of Aviación Nacional, Seville-Tablada, February
1937



9
CR.32 NC 208 of Sergente
Maggiore Guido Presel,
26ª Squadriglia, XVI Gruppo
Caccia of *Aviazione Legionaria*,
Vitoria, May-June 1937



10
CR.32bis NC 597 of Capitán Miguel Guerrero García,
Escuadrilla 1-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional,
Saragossa, June 1937



11
CR.32bis NC 596 of Teniente Miguel García Pardo,
Escuadrilla 2-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional,
Seville to Avila, July 1937



12
CR.32bis NC 601 of Comandante Joaquín García Morato,
leader of *Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional*, Seville to Avila,
July 1937



13
CR.32bis NC 594 of Capitán Julio Salvador Díaz Benjumea,
Escuadrilla 1-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Avila,
July 1937



14
CR.32 of Sergente Maggiore Gianlino Baschiroto, 24ª
Squadriglia, XVI Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria,
Saragossa, August 1937



15
CR.32 of Maggiore Andrea Zotti, leader of XXIII Gruppo
Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria, Saragossa, August 1937



16
CR.32 NC 111 of Capitán Angel Salas Larrazábal, leader of
Escuadrilla 2-E-3 and Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional,
Saragossa and León, August-October 1937



17

CR.32bis NC 331 of Comandante Ángel Salas Larrazábal, leader of *Escuadrilla 2-E-3* and *Grupo 2-G-3* of *Aviación Nacional*, Saragossa, September 1937



18

CR.32 NC 262 of Comandante Joaquín García Morato, leader of *Grupo 2-G-3* of *Aviación Nacional*, Saragossa, September 1937



19

CR.32 NC 29 of Capitano Guido Nobili, leader of 18^a *Squadriglia*, XXIII *Gruppo Caccia* of *Aviazione Legionaria*, Almaluez, September-October 1937



20

CR.32 of Capitano Enrico Degli Inceri, leader of 19^a *Squadriglia*, XXIII *Gruppo Caccia* of *Aviazione Legionaria*, Almaluez, October 1937



21

CR.32bis NC 623 of Capitano Ernesto Botto, leader of 32ª Squadriglia, VI Gruppo Caccia of *Aviazione Legionaria*, Alfamén to Saragossa, October 1937



22

CR.32 NC 262 of Comandante Joaquín García Morato, *Estado Mayor Primera Brigada Aérea* of *Aviación Nacional*, Saragossa-Sanjurjo, December 1937



23

CR.32ter NC 756 of Teniente Carlos Bayo Alessandri, *Escuadrilla 2-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3*, of *Aviación Nacional*, Alfamén, December 1937-January 1938



24

CR.32ter NC 781 of Capitán Miguel Guerrero García, leader of *Escuadrilla 5-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3* of *Aviación Nacional*, Tauste, March 1938



25

CR.32bis NC 596 of Teniente Rodolphe de Hemricourt de Grunne, *Escuadrilla 2-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional*, Tauste, March 1938



26

CR.32 NC 117 of Maggiore Armando François, leader of *XVI Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria*, Saragossa-Valenzuela, March-April 1938



27

CR.32ter NC 788 of Teniente Emilio O'Connor Valdivielso, *Escuadrilla 4-E-3, Grupo 3-G-3 of Aviación Nacional*, Bello, May 1938



28

CR.32ter NC 854 of Tenente Colonnello Andrea Zotti, leader of *XXIII Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria*, Puig Moreno, June-July 1938



29

CR.32quater NC 971 of Teniente Carlos Bayo Alessandri, *Escuadrilla 2-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional*, Escatrón, August 1938



30

CR.32ter NC 757 of Teniente José Larios Fernández, *Escuadrilla 6-E-3, Grupo 3-G-3 of Aviación Nacional*, Mérida, September 1938



31

CR.32ter NC 753 of Capitán Julio Salvador Díaz Benjumea, leader of *Escuadrilla 1-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional*, Escatrón, September-October 1938



32

CR.32bis NC 613 of Capitano Giuseppe Majone, leader of *24ª Squadriglia, XVI Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria*, Caspe, December 1938



33

CR.32 of Alférez Joaquín Velasco Fernández Nespral, *Escuadrilla 7-E-3, Grupo 3-G-3 of Aviación Nacional*, Escatrón, December 1938



34

CR.32quater NC 1011 of Teniente Abundio Cesteros García, *Escuadrilla 8-E-3, Grupo Provisional 4-G-3 of Aviación Nacional*, Posadas, January 1939



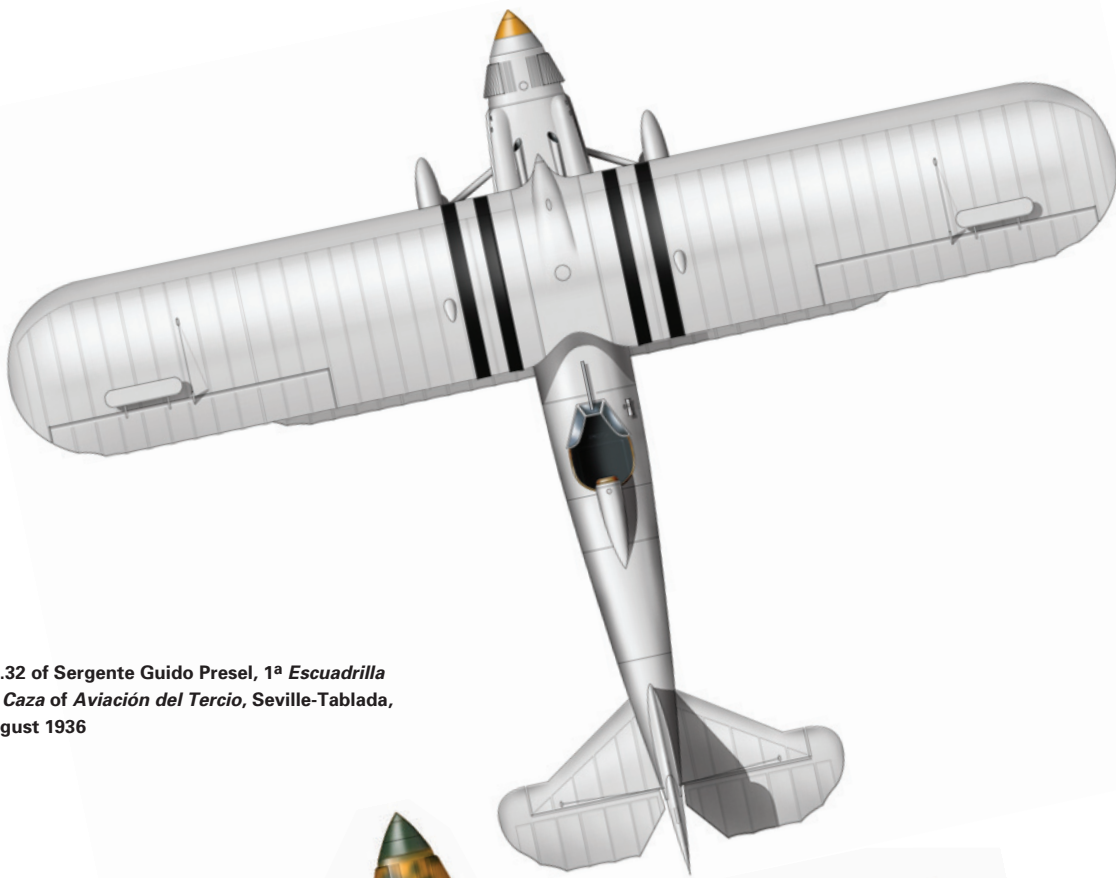
35

CR.32 NC 931 of Capitán Manuel Vázquez Sagastizábal, leader of *Escuadrilla 1-E-3* detached from *Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional*, Posadas, January 1939



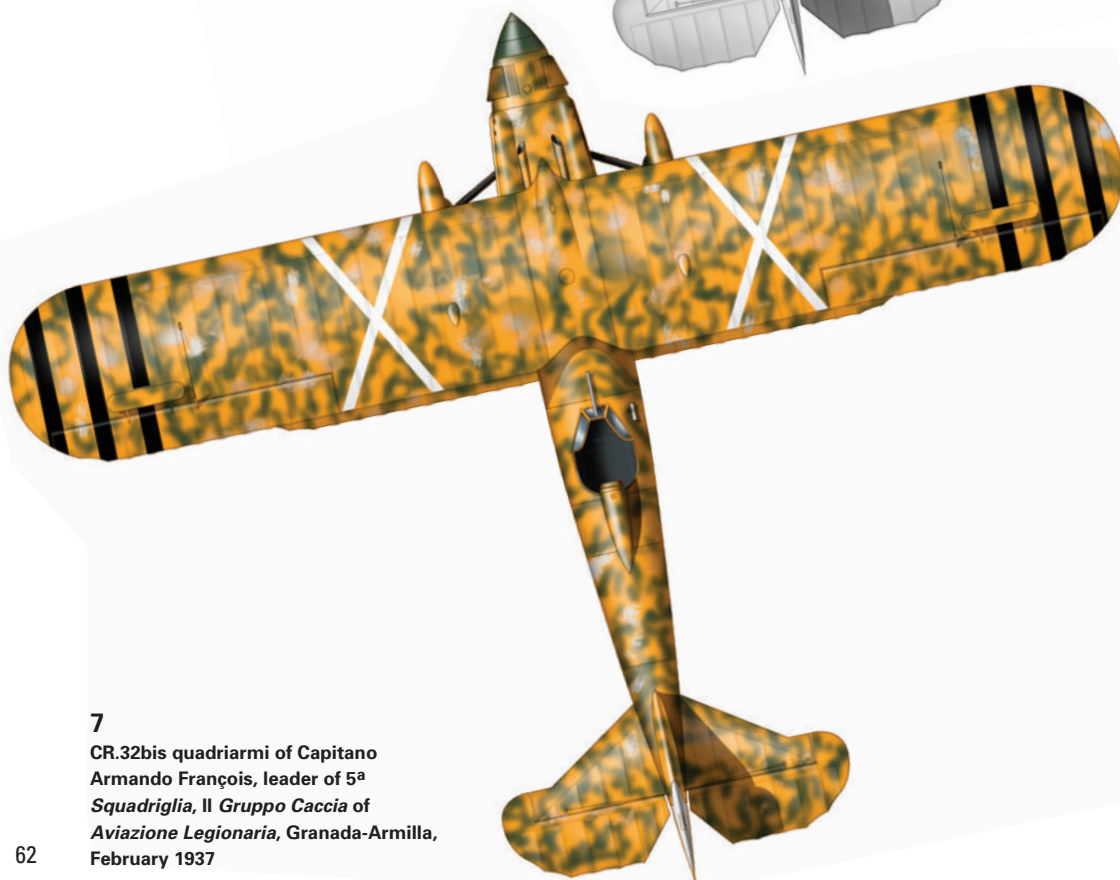
36

CR.32 NC 936 of Teniente Antonio Manrique Garrido, *Escuadrilla 1-E-3* detached from *Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional*, Posadas, January 1939



1

CR.32 of Sergente Guido Presel, 1ª Escuadrilla de Caza of Aviación del Tercio, Seville-Tablada, August 1936



7

CR.32bis quadriarm of Capitano Armando François, leader of 5ª Squadriglia, Il Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria, Granada-Armilla, February 1937



19

CR.32 NC 29 of Capitano Guido Nobili, leader of 18^a Squadriglia, XXIII Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria, Almaluez, September-October 1937



28

CR.32ter NC 854 of Tenente Colonnello Andrea Zotti, leader of XXIII Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria, Puig Moreno, June-July 1938

WAR CONTINUES EASTWARD

Keen to capitalise on their successes in northern Spain, the Nationalists began planning for a new offensive against Madrid in December 1937. This had to be put on hold, however, when the Republicans targeted the provincial town of Teruel in Nationalist-controlled Aragon on the 15th of that month. This offensive developed into a bloody battle that was fought in severe winter weather.

The first aerial action of note involving CR.32s occurred at noon on 28 December when 16 fighters from *Grupo 2-G-3* clashed with nine I-15s and 12 I-16s directly above Teruel itself. Nationalist pilots were credited with shooting down four 'Curtiss fighters' (two to Allende and one to Muntadas and Bayo) and a *Rata* (to Vázquez) for the loss of López Sert of *Escuadrilla 1-E-3*. The Republicans admitted the loss of Teniente Campoamor, who fell with his burning I-15 in the vicinity of La Muela, while two other aircraft returned to base damaged.

During the morning of 30 December, 15 CR.32s from *Grupo 2-G-3* and three from *Escuadrilla 3-E-3* (the latter undertaking its first combat mission) took off from Alfamén and intercepted 17 I-16s from *Escuadrillas 5ª* and *6ª* of *Grupo 21*. Two *Ratas* were credited to Murcia and García Lopez, the latter also subsequently claiming a 'Martin bomber' destroyed. Lt Sumarev of *6ª Escuadrilla* was indeed killed in action, and two of his comrades returned to base wounded. All seven surviving I-16s from *6ª Escuadrilla* had suffered combat damage.

XXIII *Grupo Caccia*, based at Bello, went into action over Teruel during the early afternoon of 4 January 1938 when 24 CR.32s of its three *squadriglie*, led by Zotti, intercepted a formation of nine R-Zs from *2ª Escuadrilla* of *Grupo*



Teniente Carlos Bayo Alessandri and his CR.32ter NC 756, coded 3-72. Both were assigned to *Escuadrilla 2-E-3* of *Grupo 2-G-3* during the winter of 1937-38. Initially serving as an observer-gunner in Breguet 19s, Bayo earned his 'wings' and flew He 51s as an assault pilot. He eventually transitioned to CR.32 fighters in the autumn of 1937 and was credited with his first individual victory on 28 December when he downed an I-15 near Villastar, on the Teruel front. In 1938 Bayo increased his score to 11 individual victories (five I-15s and six I-16s) and one probable (an I-16) (Author archive)



Teniente Aristides García Lopez (left) in March 1938, at which point his score stood at nine victories – eight in the CR.32 within *Escuadrilla 1-E-3*. Standing beside him is future CR.32 ace de Hemricourt, then serving with *Escuadrilla 2-E-3* (Author archive)



CR.32 NC 29, coded 3-2, of 18^a *Squadriglia* continued to serve as the personal aircraft of recently promoted Maggiore Guido Nobili through the winter of 1937-38, despite the ace's assignment to the staff of XXIII *Gruppo Caccia* at this time. Note that the triangular markings indicating *squadriglia* leadership have been removed, Nobili having been relieved by Capitano Marco Larcher (alias Lenzi) on 3 December 1937. The triangles have been replaced with two white discs within the black roundels (A *Emiliani* archive)

On 17 January 1938, in a ceremony held at Saragossa-Sanjurjo airfield, command of XVI *Gruppo Caccia* of the *Aviazione Legionaria* passed from Maggiore Giuseppe Casero (alias Casetti) to the former leader of its 25^a *Squadriglia*, newly promoted Maggiore Armando François (alias Martori). This photograph was taken on that occasion, Casero and François standing in the centre of the group among pilots and groundcrew of XVI *Gruppo*. Note the painting of the *gruppo's Cucaracha* emblem. At this time François had been an ace for six months, having claimed five individual and two shared victories between 14 March and 18 July 1937 on Guadalajara and Brunete fronts. Standing fourth from the left is fellow ace Sergente Maggiore Gianlino Baschiroto (alias Giri), who had served in Spain since late August 1936. By the time he returned to Italy in February 1938 his score stood at five individual and five shared victories and three probables (Author archive)

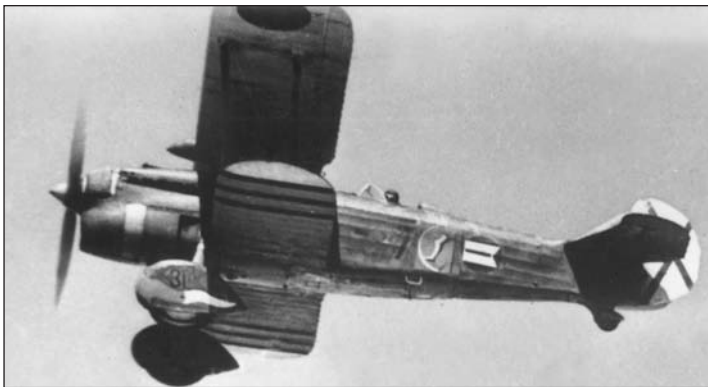
30, and their escort of 13 I-15s and 15 I-16s. The Italian pilots claimed four light bombers destroyed, two of the aircraft crashing in Republican territory and a third coming down in flames onto the beach at Malvarosa, close to Sagunto. Two more battle-damaged R-Zs landed back at their Liria base. The Italian pilots then turned their attention to the bombers' fighter escort when a second R-Z *escuadrilla* aborted its attack so as to escape the marauding CR.32s. During a frontal clash in broken cloud, Zotti shot down the I-15 flown by patrol leader Lt Kapustin of 1a *Escuadrilla*, *Grupo* 26. The latter managed to parachute into Republican territory. The Italian ace's aircraft had in turn been hit by seven rounds fired by Kapustin as he flew headlong at the CR.32.

Zotti was in action again the following afternoon when he led 16 CR.32s from XXIII *Gruppo* on a surveillance patrol over Teruel. The aircraft intercepted a formation of R-Zs and claimed five shot down. One was credited to the *gruppo's* second-in-command, Capitano Nobili.

Despite these victories, on 6 January the besieged Nationalist garrison at Teruel surrendered and the Republicans occupied the city. Fighting continued in the air over the Teruel front nevertheless. On 17 January, for example, VI *Gruppo* claimed 11 'Curtiss fighters' shot down. Eleven I-15s had indeed been hit, but only four crashed. Two more were badly damaged and five holed. In return, the Italians had Sergente Maggiore Boetti and Maresciallo Cesena killed and Sergente Benassi wounded.

XVI *Gruppo*, which had recently been placed under the command of newly promoted Maggiore François, went into action between Teruel and Aldehuela on 20 January. Italian pilots were credited with shooting down five 'Curtiss fighters' and two *Ratas*, although Sottotenente Andreani of 25^a *Squadriglia* lost his life and two CR.32s returned to base





CR.32ter NC 714, coded 3-7, flew with 31^a *Squadriglia Caccia* of the *Aviazione Legionaria* during the winter of 1937-38. It was assigned to Maggiore Eugenio Leotta (alias Leonello), who was CO of VI *Gruppo Caccia* from 28 April 1937 through to 16 March 1938. He claimed three individual and seven shared victories and one individual and five shared probables whilst leading the *gruppo*. Made CO of the *Regia Aeronautica's* 4^o *Stormo Caccia* in World War 2, Leotta was posted missing in action near Malta on 25 October 1941 (A Emiliani archive)

CR.32ter NC 781, coded 3-91, was flown by the leader of the newly formed *Escuadrilla* 5-E-3, Capitán Miguel Guerrero García, in March 1938 on the Aragon front. Note the circular 'three blue-birds' emblem on its fin, this marking passing from *Patrulla Azul* to *Grupo* 2-G-3 – it was applied to the port side of the fin only. The rhomboidal symbol on the wheel spats was unique to *Escuadrilla* 5-E-3 (A Emiliani archive)



with severe battle damage. *Grupo* 26 lost three I-15s during this clash, one from 3a *Escuadrilla* crashing near Torrente after its pilot, Puig Bastons, parachuted safely into Republican territory. A machine from 1^a *Escuadrilla* broke up in the air after being hit, its Soviet pilot, Lt Gorshkov, being forced to bail out. Debris from Gorshkov's I-15 in turn hit the Polikarpov of 2a *Escuadrilla* commander Teniente Morquillas, who also parachuted

into Republican territory. No I-16s were lost, however.

On 7 February the Nationalists launched a counter-offensive to retake Teruel, the battle being fought mainly along the River Alfambra, north of the city. Despite aerial support initially being limited by poor weather conditions, the Nationalists retook Teruel on the 22nd when Republican troops evacuated the city to avoid being encircled. Stability then returned to the Aragon front until early March.

In order to further exploit the successful counter-offensive at Teruel, and take full advantage of the large concentration of forces now in the region, Gen Franco ordered a massive offensive in Aragon. Commencing on 9 March with the support of the *Aviación Nacional*, *Aviazione Legionaria* and *Legion Condor*, this campaign, if successful, would allow the national army corps and the Italian *Corpo Truppe Volontarie* to occupy a vast swathe of territory stretching up to the Mediterranean coast. This would split the remaining Republican-held territory in two – a largely agricultural south-central zone and the predominantly industrial zone that encompassed Barcelona and the eastern border with France.

The breaking of Republican resistance in various sectors along the Aragon front on 10 March was well supported from the air. As troops advanced eastward, the Nationalists occupied airfields previously used by Republican fighter units that had been forced to make a hasty retreat.

The first major aerial battle of the new offensive took place during the afternoon of 12 March near Híjar when 18 CR.32s from *Grupo* 2-G-3,

led by García Morato and Salas, attacked 19 I-15s that were escorting 11 SBs. The Nationalist pilots were credited with downing one Tupolev 'Katiushka' (claimed by Vázquez, who attacked three SBs) that crashed while attempting to land near Escatrón, and six 'Curtiss fighters'. Two I-15s fell to García Morato, taking his tally to 30, while García Pardo, Guerrero, Bayo and de Hemricourt got one apiece. No losses were suffered in return.

Two days hours later, Maggiore Aiello (the new commander of XVI

Gruppo) led 25 CR.32s on a morning patrol as air cover for advancing columns of the *Corpo Truppe Volontarie*. As the aircraft approached Alcañiz they ran into 20 I-15s and 28 I-16s. Overwhelmed by the sheer size of the Republican formation, four CR.32s were quickly shot down. Sottotenenti Montefusco and Brondi were both captured, but their squadronmate Armanino managed to escape.

Maggiore Aiello's aircraft was also forced down, the fighter flipping onto its back as its pilot attempted a forced landing. Aiello was also taken prisoner, but he somehow convinced his captors to defect and they accompanied him to Nationalist territory! Four weeks later Maggiore François, who had been recalled to command XVI *Gruppo* just as he was about to return to Italy, ordered the recovery of Aiello's fighter from occupied territory. Once back in Nationalist hands, it was despatched to the Hispano-Suiza workshops at Seville-Tablada and rebuilt.

The six *escuadrillas* of the two Spanish CR.32 *grupos* were back in action around midday on 24 March when 30 I-15s and 11 I-16s were attacked between Farlete and Quinto. *Legion Condor* Bf 109s also joined the fray, while He 51s flown by Spanish pilots performed ground attack missions below the swirling dogfight. CR.32 pilots claimed to have downed four 'Curtiss fighters' (two each to Salas and García Lopez) and five probables, while the German pilots were credited with three I-15s shot down. Seven Polikarpov fighters were in fact destroyed, with two colliding in mid air and five being hit by fire from CR.32s or Bf 109s. Salas chased an I-15 at low level in the hope that he could force the fighter to land intact behind Nationalist lines. However, *Staffel* 1.J/88 CO Wolfgang Schellmann shot the I-15 down, prompting Salas to lodge a formal complaint with the *Legion Condor*.

Teniente Jurado of *Escuadrilla* 3-E-3 was killed during this action when Republican fighters shot him down between Caspe and Quinto. The Nationalists also had an He 51 destroyed, although its pilot survived.

On 15 April the vanguard of the Nationalist and Italian forces reached the Mediterranean coast south of the River Ebro, thus attaining the objective of the Aragon offensive – the severing of land communications between the two principal Republican rear guard metropolises of Valencia and Barcelona. During the offensive in Aragon Nationalist air elements had lost 30 aircraft due to enemy action and an equal number in accidents. Republican losses stood at 60 aircraft through enemy action – mainly I-15s and I-16s, half of which were destroyed on the ground or abandoned during the retreat. Several others were lost through accidents.

During that same period aircraft reinforcements to the Republicans from the Soviet Union had dwindled, while Italy and Germany continued to supply aircraft and crews for the Nationalist cause in substantial numbers.

NEW OFFENSIVE

On reaching the Mediterranean coast, Nationalist forces launched a new offensive in a southerly direction towards Valencia. The CR.32 units assigned to support this action were stationed in Aragon, predominantly on airfields captured from the Republicans during the previous advance. VI *Gruppo* moved to Escatrón on 3 April, where it was joined by the *Squadriglia Autonoma Caccia Mitragliamento* (Autonomous Strafing



Maggiore Armando François led XVI *Gruppo Caccia* of the *Aviazione Legionaria* from 17 January to 6 March 1938 and then again from 16 March to 10 August 1938, having been called back to the group just as he was about to return to Italy. His original replacement, Maggiore Ciro Aiello, had been shot down in aerial combat on 14 March and captured. He was only a prisoner for a few hours, however, as he persuaded his captors to defect to the Nationalists! (Author archive)

On 18 March 1938, in a ceremony held at Castejón airfield, in Navarra, top nationalist fighter ace Joaquín García Morato was presented with the *Cruz Laureada de San Fernando* – Spain's highest decoration for military valour – by Gen Alfredo Kindelán Duany, commander of the *Aviación Nacional*. García Morato's exploits in air combat over the Jarama front in February 1937 drew particular praise from Gen Kindelán (C Carlesi archive)





Fighter Unit) the following day. XXIII *Gruppo* moved to Puig Moreno on 4 April, while *Gruppo* XVI transferred to Mas de las Matas 19 days later. Finally, the Spanish *grupos* 2-G-3 and 3-G-3 had replaced XXIII *Gruppo Caccia* at Bello by month-end.

On the morning of 31 May, after escorting bomber formations into action over the Teruel front close to La Puebla de Valverde, 14 CR.32s of the Spanish *grupos* prevailed during a 90-minute clash with 22 I-15s and 22 I-16s. Bf 109s escorting *Legion Condor* bombers also engaged some of the I-16s. Although heavily outnumbered, the Nationalist pilots more than held their own thanks to the combat experience of their five veteran *grupo* and *escuadrilla* commanders – four of whom were aces (Salas, Salvador, García Pardo, Vázquez and Guerrero). All of them claimed victories, while Murcia was credited with his third and fourth victories. Overall, Nationalist pilots claimed to have shot down eight ‘Curtiss Vázquez fighters’ and two *Ratas*.

Three of the I-15s and an I-16 were credited to Salvador – the best return for him in a single action, and also one of the highest mission tallies of the civil war. The first I-15 that he hit was seen falling close to La Puebla, the pilot of the second escaped by parachute into Republican territory and the third, flown by Teniente Juan Sayós Estivill of 1a *Escuadrilla*, made an emergency landing at the Republican airfield of Sarrión with a damaged engine. Estivill quickly abandoned his fighter, which was strafed by Salvador until it caught fire and burnt out. A few minutes later the Spanish ace destroyed an I-16, thus taking his overall tally to 20 individual victories.

Teniente de Hemricourt shot down another I-15 near La Puebla, the Belgian watching his opponent take to his parachute and land in the Republican zone. Fellow future aces Capitáne Murcia and Simón also

These pilots from *Grupo* 2-G-3 were photographed at Castejón airfield on 18 March 1938 just after their CO had received his decoration. They are, standing, from left to right, Murcia Rubio, Rubio Paz, García Morato, Salas Larrazábal, Guerrero García, Vázquez Sagastizábal, Senra Álvarez and Mendoza Catrain. Kneeling, again from left to right, are García López, Comas Altadill and Ibarreche Arriaga. Eight of these men were credited with five or more individual victories during the Spanish Civil War (Author archive)

A formation of nine CR.32s from 26^a *Squadriglia* of XVI *Gruppo Caccia* fly over Aragon in the spring of 1938. The leading aircraft, CR.32bis NC 673, was assigned to Capitano Alfiero Mezzetti (alias Ottavio Mariani), leader of 26^a *Squadriglia* from 3 August 1937 to 10 May 1938. He was credited with one individual and seven shared victories, as well as four probables. His aircraft lacks the standard white triangular *squadriglia* leadership marking, the fuselage code 3-1 being applied in white instead as his CO identifier (A Emiliani archive)





enjoyed success, claiming two and one 'Curtiss fighters' each, while Muerza got a *Rata*. The Republican bulletin issued the following day acknowledged the loss of five aeroplanes that crashed within its own lines, with four wounded pilots and one uninjured. The Polikarpov units had claimed the destruction of 12 Italian and German aircraft in return, although not a single Nationalist aircraft had actually been lost in combat.

The eastern offensive made progress south along the Mediterranean coast during the first half of June, troops being supported on the Castellón de la Plana front by bombers and CR.32s of the *Aviazione Legionaria*. Nationalist forces captured the town of Castellón on 13 June, together with the port of El Grao, but further movement towards Valencia then slowed in the face of bitter Republican opposition. The latter came both on the ground and in the air.

For example, late in the afternoon of 19 June ten CR.32s of *Grupo 2-G-3*, led by Salas, were escorting Ju 52/3m bombers over La Puebla de Valverde, on the Teruel front, when they clashed with 18 I-15s. The Polikarpovs were chased by the Spaniards all the way to Alcablas, where they were joined by nine I-16s. Despite once again being outnumbered, the Nationalist pilots emerged from the encounter with claims for four 'Curtiss fighters' and two *Ratas* destroyed – no CR.32s were lost. Two of the I-15s, from 3a *Escuadrilla*, were bounced from above by Salvador, who shot them down near La Puebla. The first aircraft exploded in mid-air and the second was despatched in flames. The pilots from both machines survived with wounds. De Hemricourt was credited with shooting down a 'Curtiss fighter' and a *Rata* near the Republican airfields of Alcablas and Villar del Arzobispo, respectively, while García Pardo claimed a *Rata*. Finally, future ace Teniente Esteban Ibarreche claimed a 'Curtiss fighter' that was seen to crash near Hiruerela.

Spanish 'ace of aces' García Morato also added further kills to his tally during late June, having seen little action over the previous six months following his assignment to the General Staff of the *Primera Brigada Aérea*. Despite no longer serving with a frontline unit, he continued to perform operational flights on the Teruel front. During one such sortie on 25 June he surprised a formation of nine R-Zs from 3a *Escuadrilla* of *Grupo 30* near La Puebla de Valverde. Although the light bombers were

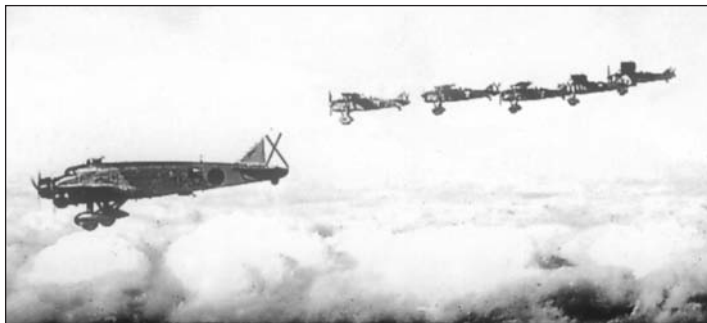
CR.32 NC 117, coded 3-1, was flown in Aragon by Maggiore Armando François in the spring of 1938, during which time he led XVI *Gruppo Caccia* (consisting of 24^a, 25^a and 26^a *Squadriglie*. The *Cucaracha* group emblem and white rectangular badge on the black roundel indicate that this aircraft was assigned to the group commander, these markings appearing on both sides of the fuselage. This machine had also been flown by François in 1937 when he was CO of 25^a *Squadriglia* – note the white triangular symbol adorned with the number 25 on its wheel spats. François used the aircraft for aerial filming, an Avia camera being installed in the forward fairing of the auxiliary fuel tank fitted to the upper wing. NC 117 also appeared in the 1938 Italian propaganda film *Los Novios de la Muerte* (A *Emiliani* archive)

Capitán Miguel Guerrero García (left) is seen with fellow Spanish CR.32 ace, and leader of *Escuadrilla 1-E-3* within *Grupo 2-G-3*, Capitán Manuel Vázquez Sagastizábal. The latter was credited with 21 individual and two shared victories, with seven probables. This was the third highest score among Nationalist aces of all nationalities. Vázquez was killed in air combat on 23 January 1939 (A *Emiliani* archive)



CR.32s from 26^a *Squadriglia Caccia* closely escort an S.81 bomber from 213^a *Squadriglia*, XXV *Gruppo Bombardamento Pesante* over Aragon in the spring of 1938. Not a single bomber of the *Aviazione Legionaria* was shot down by enemy fighters whilst being escorted by Italian CR.32 pilots during the Spanish Civil War (Author archive via US SM Aeronautica Militare)

Spanish Nationalist pilots and aces of *Grupo* 3-G-3 at Bello airfield in northwest Teruel in July 1938. They are, from left to right, *Alfárez* Alfonso García Rodríguez Carracido, *Alfárez* Osvaldo Alonso Fariñas, *Teniente* Andrés Robles Cebrian, 5-E-3 leader *Capitán* Javier Murcia Rubio, group commander *Joaquín* García Morato, 6-E-3 leader *Capitán* José Barranco del Egidio, 7-E-3 leader *Capitán* Heraclio Gautier Larrainzar (who was killed in action over the Ebro front on 28 July 1938), *Teniente* Carlos Bayo Alessandri and *Teniente* José Larios Fernández. Standing above them on the aircraft are *Teniente* Emilio O'Connor Valdivielso and *Teniente* Rogelio García de Juan. Five of these pilots were, or would become, CR.32 aces – Morato, Bayo, Larios, O'Connor and Murcia (Author archive)



being escorted by three higher-flying I-15s, both the Republican fighter pilots and the R-Z crews were distracted long enough by an increasing flak barrage for the lone CR.32 to sneak in undetected beneath them.

Ignoring the 'friendly' Nationalist ground fire, García Morato quickly sent two R-Zs down in flames – the first in Nationalist territory as the formation began banking around towards home. The second fell a few moments later near the frontline, its crew taking to their parachutes and landing in the Republican zone. García Morato subsequently recalled;

'This was one of the actions that I will remember most enthusiastically for the rest of my life. I was flying my faithful "3-51" alone on a reconnaissance sortie over the front when suddenly I saw enemy aircraft heading in my direction towards our lines. Although it was clearly an unequal fight in the enemy's favour, I didn't want to quit and let them attack our forces without trying to stop them. In fact I should have abandoned my attack as I was flying at a lower altitude than the Republican formation. Nevertheless, I managed to take the bombers by surprise, as their escorts were some way above them. Within a short time two bombers fell shrouded in flames, while the others beat a hasty retreat.

'I left the scene without the fighters having noticed either their invisible enemy's arrival nor his withdrawal.'

García Morato and the 4th Anti-aircraft Battery, operating from La Puebla, were both credited with shooting down two aeroplanes. In actual fact their victims were the same pair of R-Zs lost on this occasion. The bombers had probably been hit in rapid succession by both anti-aircraft fire and gunfire from the Spanish ace's CR.32.

The first significant action in July took place during the afternoon of the 18th when two 12-aircraft formations of CR.32s from XXIII *Gruppo*



were taking it in turns to patrol over the Viver front south of Barracas. The formations, led by aces Zotti and Nobili, were flying at altitudes of 11,500 ft and 13,000 ft, respectively, when they spotted 24 I-15s from *Escuadrillas* 2a and 3a of *Grupo* 26 on a strafing mission. The biplane fighters were escorted by 24 I-16s from *Escuadrillas* 2a, 3a, 4a and 5a of *Grupo* 21, which were flying above them. The CR.32 pilots engaged the monoplane

This patrol of *Grupo 3-G-3 CR.32s* was photographed in the summer of 1938. Closest to the camera is NC 262, coded 3-51, flown by Group Commander García Morato, then CR.32ter NC 757, coded 3-76, of *Escuadrilla 6-E-3* (also flown by ace Larios Fernández) and CR.32bis NC 594, coded 3-58, of *Escuadrilla 7-E-3*. This aircraft was subsequently issued with Hispano-Suiza reconstruction number A-46. Between the spring of 1937 and the spring of 1938 it had been assigned to aces Salvador Díaz and Salas Larrazábal (A *Emiliani archive*)



fighters, and Zotti described the well-trying tactics adopted by the enemy in his after action report;

‘The *Ratas* tried to fragment our compactness into a widespread battle, reduce our operational height and bring the broken formation down into the “Curtiss fighters” engagement zone – a restricted combat zone that would have put us in a disadvantageous position.’

Despite the Republican tactic, most Italian pilots stayed in formation and manoeuvred without losing height. The I-16s were tackled first in an engagement that lasted ten minutes, with Republican documents showing that three Polikarpovs were lost and two pilots killed. However, it appears that these aircraft were shot down by *Legion Condor* Bf 109s that had independently joined the battle at a higher altitude – German pilots claimed to have shot down three *Ratas* in the vicinity of Segorbe. Three more I-16s were hit by CR.32s or Bf 109s and had to make emergency landings. Two of the fighters collided whilst landing back at their base and one was destroyed, although both pilots survived.

One of the I-16s that force landed at Utiel airfield was flown by future ace, and flight commander, 1Lt Sergey Gritsevs of 5a *Escuadrilla*. His fighter on this occasion was one of the new four-gun I-16 Type 10s recently delivered to Spain. Gritsevs’ aircraft had suffered 25 hits from the guns of CR.32s, although he had also enjoyed success during the dogfight. Indeed, he was credited with two Fiat fighters destroyed, one of which was the aircraft flown by Capitano Giorgio Frattini, second-in-command of 18ª *Squadriglia*, which fell near Altura. Capitano Antonio Raffi, who had led 18ª *Squadriglia* since 6 June, was also hit when an I-16 Type 10 flown by patrol leader, and future ace, Nikolay Zherdev intentionally collided with the tail of his CR.32 after the pilot had exhausted his supply of ammunition. Zherdev managed to return to Utiel, thus saving his aircraft, but Raffi was forced to bail out over enemy territory in the vicinity of Teresa, where he was taken prisoner.

Zotti’s report concluded;

‘Having seen off the *Ratas*, which suddenly vanished, our CR.32s turned their attention to the “Curtiss fighters” that had dived down low in order to engage us in close combat. This tactic left us with no room for a diving attack, which is so favourable for the CR.32. In the second action, which lasted a good 20 minutes, we resisted the temptation to make individual attacks. Instead, we remained in formation, thus forcing the Republicans to fight us as a unified mass that dominated the battle from a higher altitude. During this second combat five “Curtiss fighters” were shot down.’



Maggiore Andrea Zotti and Capitano Guido Nobili (centre, reading map) were both leaders, and aces, within XXIII *Gruppo Caccia*. Here they are preparing for their next mission in Aragon in the spring of 1938 (Author archive)

The emblems of VI *Gruppo Caccia Gamba di Ferro* and XXIII *Gruppo Caccia Asso di Bastoni* were applied to this CR.32 flown by an unnamed Italian pilot who had served with both fighter groups in 1938 (A *Emiliani archive*)





Three I-15s had actually been downed by the CR.32s, one from 2a *Escuadrilla* crashing near Chelva and a machine from 3a *Escuadrilla* falling in Nationalist territory. According to Tenente Calvo Diago of 2a *Escuadrilla*, all the unit's fighters had been hit in the action. The third I-15 lost fell in flames after it was attacked by Zotti, but not before its had shot down Sergente Vestrini's CR.32. His fighter also ablaze, the badly wounded Italian pilot parachuted into enemy territory between Alcublas and Altura, where he was captured. Concluding his report, Zotti wrote;

'Personally, I had fired 745 rounds during the 30-minute combat. Initially, I had attacked three *Ratas* without success, before going after six or seven "Curtiss fighters", two of which I abandoned (one was the I-15 chasing Vestrini's CR.32) after I saw that they were trailing dark smoke. I landed at Teruel airfield at 1355 hrs when I ran low on fuel.

'Nationalist intelligence deciphered a "Red" air force signal during the evening of the 18th saying that following the day's fighting about 15 of their aircraft were missing and no news had been heard of them. From the accounts of pilots that had taken part in the battle it emerged that eight *Ratas* and five "Curtiss fighters" had certainly been shot down, with the probable destruction of a further two *Ratas*.'

Recently promoted Tenente Colonello Zotti handed over command of XXIII *Gruppo* to Maggiore Aldo Remondino on the evening of 23 July at Teruel-Caudé. On that date the *gruppo* could muster 24 CR.32s. During Zotti's time in command between 23 April 1937 and 23 July 1938 the unit had received 33 CR.32s. A total of 27 had been lost to enemy action and 15 in accidents during this period. Whilst Zotti was CO the *gruppo* had flown 13,790 hours, of which 13,222 hours were in combat during the course of 337 engagements. Of the latter, 31 had involved aerial combat, resulting in claims for 143 enemy aircraft shot down and 19 probably destroyed. Seven pilots had lost their lives in combat or in flying accidents, five had been captured and five wounded.

Two days after Zotti left XXIII *Gruppo* the Nationalists halted their advance on Valencia following a Republican counteroffensive.

EBRO OFFENSIVE

The Republican army launched its Ebro offensive at midnight of 25 July 1938 when it crossed the river between the cities of Fayón and

Emblems of all three *Gruppi Caccia* of the continental *Aviazione Legionaria*, namely XVI *La Cucaracha*, XXIII *Asso di Bastoni* and VI *Gamba di Ferro*, were painted onto the fuselage of the CR.32 assigned to the commander of 3° *Stormo Caccia* in Spain, Colonnello Guglielmo Cassinelli (alias Castello). He filled this position between 1 October 1937 and 23 May 1938, when he was replaced by Colonnello Venceslao D'Aurelio (alias Dauria). The *La Cucaracha* emblem was larger and applied in the central position because XVI *Gruppo* was descended directly from the first Italian fighter group in Spain, the *Aviación del Tercio*. It also remained the largest group in-theatre, providing replacement pilots and aircraft for the other continental *gruppi*. Indeed, XVI *Gruppo* was normally equipped with between 33 and 36 CR.32s for its three *squadriglie*. XXIII *Gruppo* was formed on 22 April 1937 (with 18^a, 19^a and 20^a *Squadriglie*), followed six days later by VI *Gruppo* (with 31^a and 32^a *Squadriglie*). Its third *squadriglia* (33^a) was formed on 1 October 1937. The aircraft's tactical rectangular badge indicated that this aircraft was assigned to a *stormo* commander. Later, the emblem of the *Squadriglia Autonoma Caccia Mitragliamento Frece Bianche* (White Arrows), also called the *Squadriglia Autonoma Attacco al Suolo*, was added to the aircraft flown by the 3° *Stormo* commander. The last of these in Spain was Colonnello Enrico Guglielmotti, who replaced D'Aurelio on 11 February 1939. Their aircraft was CR.32quater NC 939, which was completed at Turin in March 1938 and shipped to Spain at the end of the following month (A Emiliani archive)

Spanish Comandante Joaquín García Morato and Maggiore Andrea Zotti, commander of XXIII Gruppo *Caccia*, chat at Puig Moreno airfield, in east Aragon, in June 1938. Behind them is the last CR.32 flown by Zotti in Spain, coded 3-4 and marked with the group commander's rectangular pennant painted onto the black roundel on both sides of the fuselage – as was the *Asso di Bastoni* group emblem. The aircraft is camouflaged in the summer scheme of olive-green and reddish-brown patches on sand-yellow uppersurfaces and fuselage sides (Author archive)



Grupo 3-G-3 adopted the *El Clavileño* emblem from its formation in January 1938, this artwork being inspired by Cervantes' *Don Quixote* character. It was painted onto the fin's port side only. It shows *Don Quixote* and *Sancho Panza* on the magical wooden horse which had to carry the old knight on the moon. The motto *SUBA SOBRE ESTA MAQUINA EL CABALLERO QUE TUVIERE ANIMO PARA ELLO* ('Let mount this machine the gentleman who has the courage to do so') was sometimes written within the circular marking too. Its background was white or pale blue, with the artwork and outline done in black or blue. After command of *Grupo 3-G-3* passed to García Morato in July 1938, *El Clavileño* was replaced by the older *Patrulla Azul* circular emblem as worn by the CR.32s of *Grupo 2-G-3* (Author archive)



Benifallet. This marked the beginning of the last major land battle of the war, and it would drag on from the end of July to mid November. Having made initial gains, the Republican advance stalled when faced by stiff local resistance that was quickly bolstered with the arrival of Nationalist reinforcements.

There was intense aerial action throughout the Ebro campaign, with the three Nationalist air components – Spanish, Italian and German – quickly showing their combined numerical supremacy over their Republican counterparts.

In early August there were ten Italian CR.32 *Squadriglie* present on the Ebro front, namely 24^a, 25^a and 26^a *Squadriglie* of XVI Gruppo (commanded by Maggiore François, with Tenente Colonello Tessari taking over on the 10th) at Caspe; 18^a, 19^a and 20^a *Squadriglie* of XXIII Gruppo (led by Maggiore Remondino) at Sariñena; 31^a, 32^a and 33^a *Squadriglie* of VI Gruppo (commanded by Maggiore Rossi) at Puig Moreno; and the *Squadriglia Autonoma Caccia Mitragliamento* (of Tenente Vosilla, who was replaced on the 15th by Tenente Zannetti) at Caspe. The six Spanish *Escuadrillas* consisted of *Grupos* 2-G-3 (led by Salas) and 3-G-3 (led by García Morato). Three *staffeln* of Bf 109s represented the German contingent.

The Nationalists could field 180 fighters in total. In comparison, the Republicans in Catalonia had around 120 Polikarpov fighters split between two *Esquadrillas* of I-15s and seven of I-16s.

The first aerial clash came on 1 August near Fayón when a group of Spanish pilots led by García Morato engaged a formation of I-15s. Although CR.32 pilot Munaiz de Brea lost his life during the action, the Spaniards claimed seven 'Curtiss fighters' destroyed. Two of these aircraft were the first successes for future ace Antonio Manrique Garrido – one I-15 was seen to fall in flames near Mequinenza, while the pilot of the second machine escaped by parachute. The other kills were individually credited to García Morato, Salvador, Vázquez, Velasco and O'Connor.

XVI Gruppo was led into action by its CO, and ace, Maggiore François on the morning of 5 August when its three *squadriglie*, comprising some 30 CR.32s, intercepted six SBs, escorted by 21 I-16s, approaching



Nationalist positions from the northeast. During the battle that ensued François and a section of Italian pilots shared in the destruction of an SB, whose crew escaped by parachute and landed in the Republican zone. Capitano Fassi also shot up the I-16 flown by Lt Konovalov, who had to force-land at the Republican airfield of Reus. No CR.32s were lost.

By the end of the first week of August the Republican advance west of the River Ebro had been brought to a halt by the Nationalist defensive line that surrounded the town of Gandesa.

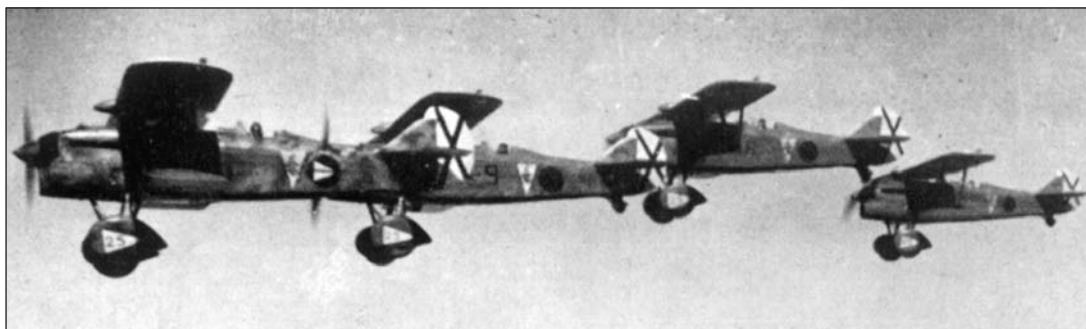
On the morning of the 14th 18 CR.32s, led by García Morato, engaged 80 Republican fighters – 52 I-16s and 28 I-15s. This massive formation of Polikarpovs was also targeted by ten Bf 109s. Aces García Morato, García Pardo, Bayo, de Hemricourt and O'Connor each claimed a *Rata* destroyed for the loss of two fighters from *Escuadrilla* 2-E-3. One I-16 was flown by Mesía Lesseps, who was wounded and taken prisoner after bailing out, and the other was crash-landed by ace Teniente Carlo Bayo Alessandri near the Nationalist town of Horta de San Juan.



The *La Cucaracha* emblem of XVI *Gruppo Caccia* was applied to the fuselages of the unit's CR.32s with some variation in both shape and colour from the autumn of 1937. Here, Sottotenente Emilio Marchi (alias Emilio Marazzi) of 25^a *Squadriglia* poses with his CR.32 at Mas de las Matas airfield in May 1938. Marchi was credited with one individual victory and other shared or unconfirmed kills (*G Giorgi archive*)

Alferez Emilio O'Connor Valdivielso served with CR.32 *Escuadrilla* 4-E-3 of *Grupo* 3-G-3 from February 1938. He claimed six individual victories between 13 May 1938 and 3 January 1939, downing three I-15s and three I-16s (*A Emiliani archive*)

CR.32s of 25^a *Squadriglia*, XVI *Gruppo Caccia* are led on patrol by Capitano Roberto Fassi (alias Rodolfo Tassi), *squadriglia* leader from 17 January to 7 September 1938. He claimed three individual and six shared aerial victories, with three shared unconfirmed. His aircraft is marked with a triangular badge within the black fuselage roundel, thus denoting his position as *squadriglia* leader. Fassi's fighter was shipped to Spain in August 1936, and the following month it was adorned with the **MONICO ! PRESENTE** titling in honour of Tenente Monico (*Author archive*)



LAST BATTLES

During the summer of 1938, away from the Ebro and Valencia fronts, the Nationalist air force repeatedly detached sections of fighter *squadriglie* to Mérida in support operations on the Extremadura front. Here, Gen Franco had planned an offensive eastward that would distance the enemy from the safety of the Portuguese border.

On the morning of 1 September, seven CR.32s from *Grupo 2-G-3* attacked a flight of two-seat Grumman FF-1 biplane fighters (imported from Canada) from *Grupo 28* over the Cabeza del Buey front. Two *Delfines*, as these aircraft were known in Spain, were shot down, their destruction being credited to García Pardo and de Hemricourt. Only one FF-1 was actually destroyed, with its pilot wounded and observer killed.

The following morning a formation of nine R-Zs, escorted by a similar number of I-15s, were attacked by 18 Spanish-flown CR.32s near Monterrubio de la Serena as they returned from a bombing mission. Minutes later nine SBs from 4a *Escuadrilla* of *Grupo 24*, escorted at a distance by 11 I-16s Type 10, hove into view too. The CR.32s concentrated on the Tupolev bombers and their monoplane fighter escorts in what turned out to be an exceptionally successful encounter for *Grupo 2-G-3* commander Capitán Salas, who noted in his logbook;

‘After 50 minutes on patrol I spotted nine “Martin bombers” that were a little higher than us heading in the direction of our lines. I gained height as I flew towards them, cutting off their escape route. As they returned after bombing Monterrubio, I attacked the bomber on the left in the first section, setting his left engine on fire. I then hit the left engine of the leader’s aircraft, setting it on fire too, and the third bomber suffered the same fate. Then I fired straight up at the leader of the second flight, and his aircraft started trailing white smoke. It was then that I noticed some *Ratas*, so I attacked one. After a long fight it also started to trail smoke, and the pilot took to his parachute. He landed close to his aircraft, north of Belalcázar. During his descent I saluted him and he saluted me back.’

Salas had shot down four aircraft in five minutes. A number of the crewmen from the downed bombers took to their parachutes, only to be killed as they floated down, or immediately after landing, by groundfire from Moroccan troops fighting in this area. Ricote, commander of 4a *Escuadrilla* and flying the SB damaged by Salas, force-landed his bomber on Almodóvar airfield after having one of his engines shot out.

The I-16 Type 10 that fell victim to Salas was flown by the CO of 1a *Escuadrilla* of *Grupo 21*, Teniente José Redondo Martín – son of Madrid’s former Mayor, Cayetano Redondo. Also an ace, Redondo had previously been CO of I-15-equipped 3a *Escuadrilla*. Having landed in Republican territory, Redondo returned to lead his unit, while Salas learned upon landing back at Mérida that his brother Ignacio, who was an army officer serving on the Ebro front, had been killed that same morning during a Republican air raid on Bot, near Gandesa. Salas subsequently discovered that the raid had been carried out by SBs from 2a *Escuadrilla* of *Grupo 24*.

Belgian volunteer pilot Rodolphe Charles Geoffrey de Hemricourt de Grunne had been promoted to the rank of *teniente* within the Spanish *Aviación Nacional* by July 1937, and he was assigned to the CR.32 in December of that year. Flying the fighter with *Escuadrilla 2-E-3* of *Grupo 2-G-3*, de Hemricourt was credited with 14 individual victories between March 1938 and January 1939 – six I-15s, seven I-16s and a Grumman FF-1. During World War 2 he flew with the RAF, claiming three unconfirmed victories prior to being posted as missing in action after his Spitfire was shot down by a Bf 109 over the English Channel on 21 May 1941 (A *Emiliani* archive)



As operations in Extremadura ended, *Grupos* 2-G-3 and 3-G-3 returned to Aragon, taking up station at Escatrón on 18 September.

Earlier that month the Nationalists had successfully embarked upon a local counteroffensive along the Gandesa-Corbera-La Venta de los Camposines route, which was well supported from the air. Amongst the aircraft involved were fighters from the *Aviazione Legionaria*'s XVI *Gruppo*, based at Caspe, and XXIII *Gruppo* at Sariñena.

On the morning of 5 September CR.32s from both *gruppi*, as well as the *Comando di Stormo*, escorted S.81 bombers sent to attack Republican targets on the Gandesa front. XXIII *Gruppo*, in particular, stuck closely to the three flights of Italian tri-motors, thus deterring formations of I-15s and I-16s from attacking the S.81s. Some 50 Polikarpov fighters were then spotted below the CR.32s by pilots from XVI *Gruppo*, which was indirectly supporting the operation. A large scale engagement involving more than 100 fighters then broke out, this swirling mass of aircraft drifting east over Republican territory beyond Falset.

Pilots of XVI *Gruppo* were subsequently credited with shooting down four 'Curtiss fighters' and four *Ratas*, while six other fighters were classified as probably destroyed – individual victories were awarded to 24^a and 25^a *Squadriglie* commanders, Capitani Majone (a future ace) and Fassi. The Republicans lost five I-15s and four I-16s, including a Type 10 from 2a *Escuadrilla*. Three more Type 10s returned to base with varying degrees of battle damage, the Spanish pilot of a 3a *Escuadrilla* machine making a wheels-up landing at Pla de Cabra airfield when wounds to his arm prevented him from manually lowering the fighter's undercarriage. No losses were suffered by the CR.32s, although several pilots from XVI *Gruppo* returned with bullet holes in their aircraft.

The next actions of note involving CR.32s took place on the Ebro front on 21 and 23 September, with VI *Gruppo Caccia* very much in the thick of things. The *gruppo* was now being led from Puig Moreno airfield by Capitano Giuseppe Baylon, who had relieved Maggiore Mario Rossi earlier in the month. These engagements, fought near Flix and Falset, respectively, ultimately proved to be the last for VI *Gruppo* in Spain. Two *Ratas* from 3a *Escuadrilla* were shot down and five claimed as probables during the afternoon of the 21st, with three CR.32s being damaged in return. Two days later, a 'Martin bomber' and three I-16s were destroyed, with two more claimed as probables. These were collectively credited to all pilots that had participated in the actions. One of the CR.32s returned to base with minor battle damage. The VI *Gruppo* diary entry following this final clash with the enemy on 23 September read as follows;

'The *Ratas* fought bravely, although they displayed defensive rather than offensive tactics, notwithstanding their superior aircraft.'

Four days later VI *Gruppo Caccia* was ordered to disband, along with other units of the *Aviazione Legionaria*, in accordance with wider commitments made by the major powers that signed up to the Munich agreement. This document, which was meant to avert the growing crisis in Europe, called for the removal of all foreign soldiers from Spanish soil. VI *Gruppo*'s CR.32s were duly handed over to the Spanish Nationalist air force at the end of September.

With the return of *Grupos* 2-G-3 and 3-G-3 to Escatrón, in Aragon, from Mérida on 18 September, all the frontline fighter units fielded by



the Nationalists in continental Spain were gathered together close to the Ebro theatre of operations. These included 18 CR.32 *squadriglie* and *escuadrillas* and three Messerschmitt *staffeln*, with serviceable totals of about 180 CR.32s and 30 Bf 109s, respectively. In opposition, the Republicans had two or three *escuadrillas* of I-15s (1a, 3a and, temporarily, 4a *Escuadrillas*) totalling 30 to 40 biplane fighters, and five or six I-16 *escuadrillas* (3a, 4a, 5a, 6a, 7a and, temporarily, 1a *Escuadrillas*) with 60 or 70 monoplane fighters. These totals excluded those fighter units provisionally detached to other areas.

Although clearly outnumbered, the Republicans usually put up large fighter formations that often engaged smaller Spanish Nationalist, Italian and German formations, as the latter units generally operated independently of each other.

Spanish CR.32s returned to action on the Ebro front on 20 September when *Grupo 3-G-3* escorted bombers over the Manzanera front. Polikarpov fighters were encountered, and a probable kill was claimed by Teniente Larois from *Escuadrilla 6-E-3*. He later recalled;

‘A large formation of *Ratas* suddenly appeared above us, flying high in the blue sky as if they had just come out of the sun. Pilots from our *escuadrilla* above us waved to signal the alarm, after which we all flew directly at the enemy at full throttle in an attempt to prevent them from reaching our bombers. I desperately tried to position my section above the *Ratas* before attacking them but I did not succeed, as they fell on us like an avalanche and we had little choice other than to defend ourselves.

‘Four *Ratas* in formation dived like lightning straight towards me in a frontal attack. I rapidly raised the nose of my “Fiat” and pointed it directly at the leading *Rata*. I had just enough time to fire a couple of bursts before the “Red” aeroplane dived straight down towards the ground and the others passed by at high speed over our heads, before banking around tightly so as to attack us from the rear.

‘Things now took a turn for the worse, as they held all the advantages – a superior number of aircraft, height and greater speed with which to manoeuvre. I had no option but to turn as tightly as possible. The enemy seemed to be everywhere, and again I could hear the classic chatter of

CR.32s of 24^a *Squadriglia*, XVI *Gruppo Caccia* of the *Aviazione Legionaria* patrol over the Ebro front in late 1938. The lead aircraft boasts a white triangular marking bearing a black horizontal bar on its fuselage sides between the *La Cucaracha* emblem of XVI *Gruppo Caccia* and the white diagonal band. This machine was assigned to *squadriglia* leader Capitano Giuseppe Majone, who commanded the unit from 7 July 1938 through to 8 January 1939. During this time it fought over Levante, Ebro and Catalonia. The same machine, without the diagonal band, had previously been flown by the former leader of 24^a *Squadriglia*, Capitano Luigi Bianchi (A Emiliani archive)

gunfire behind my shoulders. Instinctively, I threw my aeroplane into a sharp spin towards the River Ebro, knowing this to be my sole chance of survival. It worked, as the *Ratas* immediately gave up chasing me, probably thinking that I was on my way to the other world. I recovered from the violent dive upon seeing that I wasn't being chased and started to climb once again with my engine flat out, attentively observing the sky in all directions. I was impatient to regain height and rejoin the battle.

'On reaching 13,000 ft I felt secure once more. I could see that fierce fighting was still going on. A lonely *Rata* crossed the brilliant sky some 700 ft above me. I was in his blind spot, and it flew on without attempting to take any evasive action. Seizing my opportunity, I was able to fire several bursts right into its belly – one of the *Rata*'s most vulnerable spots. The fighter trembled with the impact and appeared to swing for a second, before dropping on a wing, lowering its nose and entering a spin. I followed for a while, stuck to the *Rata*'s tail, still firing. Climbing back up again, I lost sight of the aircraft as if it had been swallowed up by the uneven ground. I never did find out whether the *Rata* had indeed hit the ground or not. It remained another combat uncertainty.

'I turned towards our lines low on fuel. On landing, Rossi and I examined the aeroplane and could count a good number of bullet holes in the fuselage – fortunately no vital parts had been hit. The Fiat was strong and could take great punishment. It would soon be parked, fully serviced and prepared to take off again as part of the next flight.'

During the autumn months the Nationalist offensive between Gandesa and the Ebro continued, backed by bombers that always sortied with Italian and Spanish CR.32s as escorts. The latter were particularly busy, with *Grupos* 2-G-3 and 3-G-3 participating in a total of 16 aerial engagements between 18 September and 15 November 1938. Pilots from these units claimed 58 'Curtiss fighters' and *Ratas* destroyed, with 15 more as probables, and one SB destroyed and a second as a probable – only ten of these victories could be historically verified, however. Three CR.32s were lost in return, with two pilots killed and one taken prisoner.

During the same period Italian *Gruppi* XVI and XXIII, the *Squadriglia Autonoma Caccia Mitragliamento* and the *Sezione Comando* of 3° *Stormo Caccia* experienced nine aerial combats, claiming the destruction of 57 'Curtiss fighters' and *Ratas* with 34 probables, and two 'Martin bombers' destroyed and one probable – 16 kills could be historically verified. They too lost three CR.32s, with two pilots killed and the third taken prisoner.

———— TOP CR.32 ACES SHOT DOWN ————

During the morning of 3 October, García Morato led 24 CR.32s from *Grupos* 2-G-3 and 3-G-3 on an escort mission for Ro.37s. They encountered 28 I-16s escorting 24 I-15s that had been undertaking strafing attacks, García Morato and 12 fighters from 3-G-3 attacking the biplane fighters at low level, two of which were claimed shot down by Tenientes Medizabal and O'Connor. Twelve other fighters from 2-G-3 tackled the I-16s at a higher altitude, but they soon found themselves badly outnumbered.

As the I-15 *escuadrillas* withdrew towards Republican lines, García Morato and his pilots broke off their attacks and gained height in order to

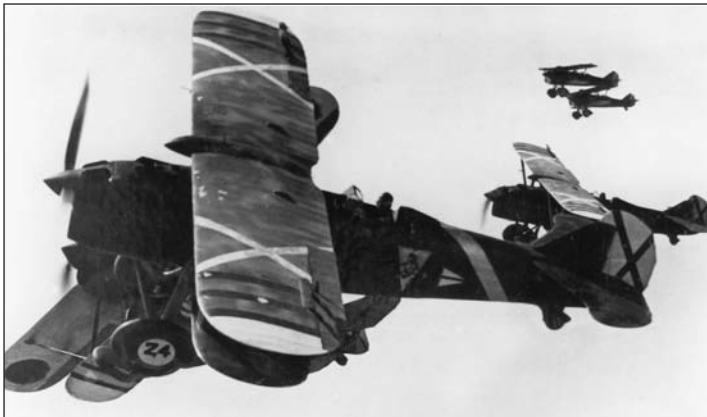
aid their compatriots in the struggle against the I-16s. García Morato attacked a *Rata* from the rear, quickly setting it on fire, but at the same time another CR.32 pilot targeted the same I-16 from an acute angle. A 12.7 mm bullet fired by the second Fiat hit the engine of García Morato's fighter, knocking it out. Still some 12 miles behind enemy lines, but at medium altitude, the ace used all his skills to glide the engineless CR.32 to within sight of the frontline, before he was forced to perform a dead-stick landing in a vineyard. His aircraft suffered no further damage when he landed. This was the only time that García Morato would be shot down in combat, albeit not through enemy action but accidentally by his wingman during the heat of battle.

The fighter shot down by García Morato was an I-16 Type 10 from 3a *Escuadrilla*, and it was seen to explode in mid air. Another I-16, this time from 7a *Escuadrilla* was destroyed by Teniente de Hemricourt, the ace seeing its pilot bail out over Republican territory. A third I-16 Type 10 was hit in the propeller and main-wheel doors by bullets from a CR.32 and its pilot crash-landed near Reus, from where it was recovered.

Republican pilots, in return, claimed nine CR.32s shot down, although in actual fact only one had been lost. However, the pilot downed was none other than the commander of *Escuadrilla* 1-E-3, 26-kill ace Capitán Salvador. According to Republican witnesses, his CR.32 had been hit near Fayón early on in the engagement with the I-16s. Salvador's opponent was the second-in-command of *Grupo* 21, fellow ace José María Bravo Fernández. The nationalist pilot was taken prisoner by soldiers of the 46th Division of the Popular Army, commanded by the famous communist leader Valentín González. Salvador was eventually set free in France along with other pilot detainees held by the Republicans after four months in prison.

The Nationalist counteroffensive on the Ebro front resumed on 30 October in the north-central sector between Ascó and Cherta, with this attack being well supported by an air component consisting of 100 tri-motor and twin-engined bombers of the National air force, *Aviazione Legionaria* and the *Legion Condor*. After three-and-a-half months of bitter fighting on the ground and in the air, the longest battle of the Spanish Civil War came to an end during the night of 15-16 November 1938 when the Republican army completed its withdrawal beyond the northern banks of the River Ebro.

For more than a month after the end of the battle, Gen Franco's command busied itself planning for a new offensive to be launched in Catalonia with the aim of occupying Barcelona. Virtually all the CR.32 units in Spain would be committed to this campaign, including 7a *Escuadra de Caza*, headed by García Morato and comprising *Grupos* 2-G-3 and 3-G-3, based at Escatrón. 3° *Stormo Caccia* of the *Aviazione Legionaria*, led by Colonello D'Aurelio, was transferred from Caspe to Sariñena at the beginning of the offensive. XVI *Gruppo*, led by Tessari, and including 24^a, 25^a and 26^a *Squadriglie* led by Capitani Majone, Meille and Travaglini, respectively, remained at Caspe, however. XXIII *Gruppo*, commanded by Remondino, and including 18^a, 19^a and 20^a *Squadriglie* led by Capitani Bonzano, Crosara and Favini, respectively, was also based at Sariñena. Finally, the *Squadriglia Autonoma Caccia Mitragliamento*, led by Capitano Iannicelli, flew from Caspe too.



Capitano Majone banks his CR.32 towards the camera while his wingman breaks away. Majone was credited with seven individual victories (three I-16s and four I-15s), four of which came on 24 and 30 December 1938 near Castellldans and Montblanch, respectively, during the Nationalist winter offensive in Catalonia. As well as these individual kills, Majone also claimed 24 shared confirmed and 11 probable victories while leading 24^a *Squadriglia Caccia* during the large-scale aerial combats that took place over the Ebro front and in Catalonia. No Italian pilot claimed more shared victories in Spain. Majone perished in a flying accident in Italy on 18 April 1939 when his CR.32 collided with a similar machine flown by Alfiero Mezzetti, who had also been a capitano in Spain, leading 26^a *Squadriglia Caccia*. He too died in the accident (A Emiliani archive)

Travaglini and Majone, leading 24^a and 26^a *Squadriglie*, dived headlong at the I-15s, which in turn fled towards the northern bank of the River Segre. The aerial battle continued between Serós and Castellldans following the intervention of eight CR.32s from Meille's 25^a *Squadriglia* just as three I-15s that were hit as the combat commenced abandoned the fight. The I-16s also fled at this time, leaving close to 40 biplane fighters locked in a series of bitter duels from a height of 3500 ft all the way down to the ground between Castellldans and Borjas Blancas.

The battle lasted more than 30 minutes, and upon returning to base the Italians claimed 14 'Curtiss fighters' destroyed and four more as probables – two victories were awarded to ace Capitano Majone. In reality, just five I-15s had actually been shot down by the CR.32s, including the fighter flown by the veteran commander of *Grupo* 26, ace Capitán Miguel Zambudio Martínez. Despite having suffered a serious bullet wound to his right leg, he managed to force land his aircraft in Republican territory. The remaining aircraft destroyed came from 1a and 4a *Escuadrillas*, and four more I-15s returned to base with battle damage.

In return, two CR.32s from 25^a *Squadriglia* were shot down by I-15s between Castellldans and Borjas Blancas. Sergente Giuseppe Marini was killed, while Sergente Giovanni Accorsi crash-landed in Nationalist territory and emerged from the wreckage of his CR.32 with only a slight wound following the explosion of his fighter's fuel tank.

Several hours later, 18 CR.32s from García Morato's Spanish units intercepted a formation of nine R-Z light bombers from 2a *Escuadrilla* of *Grupo* 30, escorted at a distance by 19 I-16s from the 6a and 7a *Escuadrillas* of *Grupo* 21, near Fontllonga. Initially diving head-on at the bombers, the CR.32s then made a second attacking pass from the rear before the escort fighters could intervene. The Spaniards claimed nine R-Zs destroyed, three of which (plus a probable) were attributed to García Morato, two to Velasco and one each to Larios, Lacour, Ruibal and Recasens. Six R-Zs were actually shot down, falling or force landing in Republican territory.

I-16s from 6a *Escuadrilla* intervened rather late in defence of the bombers, shooting down the CR.32 flown by the commander of 7-E-3, Capitán Rafael Mendizábal Amézaga. The latter took to his parachute and landed near Camarasa, where he was soon captured. Following six weeks in captivity, Amézaga was executed.

The offensive was launched on 23 December, with Spanish Nationalist aircraft supporting the Northern Army Corps, the *Aviazione Legionaria* operating closely with the *Corpo Truppe Volontarie* on the central front of Lérida and the *Legion Condor* supporting the army corps advance through the southern Ebro area.

During the morning of 24 December, 22 CR.32s from XVI *Gruppo* clashed over the Lérida front with 16 I-15s and eight I-16s.

On 19 January 1939 the Nationalist Army Corps in Catalonia and the Italian *Corpo Truppe Volontarie* resumed their advance on Barcelona after having been slowed down by inclement winter weather. There had also been little aerial activity by either side because of persistent cloud cover and generally poor flying conditions. However, at midday on the 19th six CR.32s of *Grupo 3-G-3*, led by García Morato, and six from 2-G-3, headed by Salas, flew a surveillance patrol near Igualada, on the Lérida-Barcelona road. The biplane fighters were accompanied by five He 112 monoplanes of *Grupo 5-G-5*, led by García Pardo.

During the course of their patrol the Nationalist fighters intercepted 16 I-15s and 13 I-16s, and García Morato shot down an I-15 from 4a *Escuadrilla*. This aircraft would prove to be the ace's 40th, and last, aerial victory. García Pardo also claimed a *Rata* destroyed for his 13th, and last, aerial success. It was also the only victory credited to the He 112 in Spain.

On 26 January Gen Franco's troops, together with the Italians of *Corpo Truppe Volontarie*, entered Barcelona. On 10 February Nationalist forces completed the occupation of Catalonia by reaching Spain's eastern border with France.

— LAST FIGHTERS IN THE SOUTH —

The last Republican offensive of the war began on 5 January 1939 close to the border between Andalusia and Extremadura, on the Pozoblanco front, this campaign being launched in a vain attempt to slow down the Nationalist advance in Catalonia. The only CR.32 unit in Andalusia at the time was *Escuadrilla 8-E-3* (led by Capitán García López) at Posadas, near Cordoba. One week later it was joined by 1-E-3 and 3-E-3 *Escuadrillas* (led by aces Vázquez and Guerrero, respectively), which were transferred in from Aragon.

On 23 January, Capitán Guerrero and Vázquez and Italian ace Maggiore Nobili (detached from the Nationalist *Escuela de Caza*) were leading seven CR.32s of *Grupo 2-G-3* on a bomber escort mission when enemy fighters were engaged. Vázquez, together with his wingmen Manrique and Viguera, chased after the aircraft while the remaining seven CR.32s stayed with the bombers. The three Fiat fighters then ran into a much larger formation of I-15s belonging to *Escuadrillas 2a* and *3a* of *Grupo 26* near Hinojosa del Duque. Ace Manrique was credited with shooting down a 'Curtiss fighter' and Viguera scored a probable before returning to base in his battle-damaged fighter.

Vázquez, however, was badly wounded in the stomach by an I-15 and forced to bail out of his stricken CR.32. He was quickly captured by Republican troops and taken to a hospital in Pozoblanco, where he passed away before he was able to identify himself to his captors. Vázquez was carrying a cigarette case given to him by García Morato, which was inscribed with his commander's initials. Moreover,



Teniente José Larios Fernández (right) and Italian mechanic Egisto Rossi, who served with Spanish unit 6-E-3 maintaining the CR.32 flown by Larios. Between 24 March and 24 December 1938, Larios was credited with six individual victories and seven more unconfirmed (A Emiliani archive)

Ranking ace García Morato is seen in the cockpit of an Italian Fiat G.50 in March 1939, 12 of these machines having been shipped to Spain for an experimental unit attached to XXIII *Gruppo Caccia*. They arrived too late to see combat with I-15s or I-16s, however. This was perhaps a fortunate thing as the G.50 was both underpowered and defective in design. Indeed, Italian airmen preferred to fly biplane fighters. Standing just below the cockpit is the leader of the experimental unit, Capitano Mario Bonzano, who formerly led the CR.32-equipped 18ª *Squadriglia*, XXIII *Gruppo Caccia Asso di Bastoni* from 30 July 1938 to 8 January 1939. He claimed one individual victory and 14 shared (confirmed and probables) (A Emiliani archive)





This impressive line-up of CR.32s from the Spanish *Aviación Nacional*'s 7^a *Escuadra de Caza* is seen at Griñon airfield, near Madrid, at war's end. Top ace and national fighter force commander García Morato killed himself in a flying accident here on 4 April 1939 (A *Emiliani* archive)

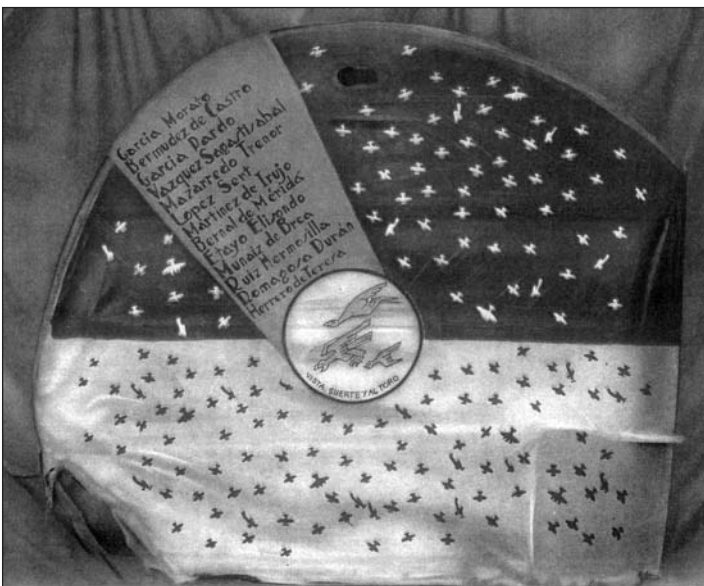
This upper section of a rudder taken from the wreckage of an I-15 downed in aerial combat was used by *Grupo 2-G-3* as a scoreboard. Each one of the aircraft silhouettes represented a confirmed claim. Note the addition of García Morato's name to the list of the 12 pilots killed flying with *Grupo 2-G-3* during the conflict. Amongst them are aces Vázquez Sagastizábal and García Pardo. It was the latter pilot who shot down the I-15 from which this rudder came, the aircraft crashing near Híjar, in Aragon, on the afternoon of 12 March 1938. The I-15, from 1^a *Escuadrilla* of *Grupo 26*, was flown by Soviet pilot 1Lt Bela Ignathevich Aradi, who bailed out wounded and landed in Republican lines. Only the upper two colours (yellow and red, respectively) of the Republican flag worn on the rudder were preserved, as these were also the colours of Spanish monarchist-nationalist flag. The purple band that completed the Republican colours was cut off. The circular *Patrulla Azul* emblem and motto *VISTA, SUERTE Y AL TORO* were painted in a central position, with the 'blue-birds' on a white disc that was outlined in black. A total of 178 silhouettes for official victories are represented as follows – seven SBs, 21 R-5 SSS or R-Zs and 150 I-15s or I-16s. 2-G-3 was the leading Nationalist fighter group, being credited with more victories than all the other *Aviación Nacional* groups combined (Author archive)

Vázquez bore a resemblance to García Morato, and the Republicans duly announced the death of the 'Separatist air force's "ace of aces"'.

During the civil war, Vázquez had flown a total of 1035 hours and completed more than 400 combat sorties – 324 sorties (totalling 657 hours) had been made in the CR.32. He had been involved in 40 air combats with the Fiat fighter, and all 21 of his individual victories, two of his seven shared kills and seven probables had been claimed with the Italian machine. Amongst his victories, Vázquez had claimed ten I-16s and two SBs destroyed, plus two Tupolev bombers shared destroyed. These totals made him the leading Nationalist ace against modern Soviet-built aircraft in Spain. The only pilot to come close to Vázquez's record was German *staffel* commander Werner Mölders, who was credited with 11 I-16s and one SB shot down. However, the latter pilot was flying the fastest fighter in Spain, namely the Bf 109.

By the end of January the Nationalist counteroffensive, using overwhelming land and aerial forces, had pushed the Republicans back to their previous defensive positions along the Pozoblanco front.

The last aerial combat for the CR.32 in Spain occurred on 9 February 1939 when five I-15s were shot down by Spanish pilots near Peñarroya, in Andalusia. Two were credited to García López, taking his overall tally to 17, and one each to Frutos, Manrique and Alcocer – the latter two pilots each 'made ace' with these successes.



NATIONALIST VICTORY

With the occupation of Catalonia, the Spanish Nationalist State received diplomatic recognition from Great Britain and France on 27 February 1939. The following month Gen Franco's forces launched its final offensive against Madrid and north-central Spain. In the latter region, a large section of the Republican military revolted against the government and the leaders of the Spanish Communist Party, thus hastening the Nationalist victory.

Madrid fell on 28 March, and that same day ace Capitán García Pardo lost his life in a flying accident at Almaluez airfield upon returning from a surveillance sortie on the Guadalajara front in a He 112. During the conflict he had flown more than 600 combat missions totalling 1100 hours, with the bulk of these being at the controls of a CR.32. García Pardo had been credited with 13 individual victories, 11 of them in the Italian fighter. He was posthumously decorated with the Individual Military Medal and promoted to the rank of commander as a result of his war record.

Valencia and the important naval base of Cartagena (from where the Republican navy sought refuge in Algeria) were occupied on 1 April, after which Gen Franco signed the final wartime bulletin that announced the cessation of hostilities.

Four days later Joaquín García Morato, foremost among the aces of the Spanish Civil War, also perished in a flying accident. From 1 August 1936 through to war's end, he had flown 1012 hours in action and taken part in 511 combat sorties – 444 sorties (totalling 790 hours) were made in the CR.32. García Morato had flown 16 different types of military aircraft and almost as many civilian types, survived 56 aerial combats that saw him engage 144 enemy aircraft, and undertaken 122 strafing missions. He had been credited with 40 individual and two shared victories, as well as 13 probables. García Morato had also possibly destroyed two aeroplanes on the ground and shared in the destruction of

Spanish Nationalist units equipped with CR.32s sit lined up in preparation for the *Parada Aérea de la Victoria* at Madrid-Barajas airfield in May 1939. In the foreground are fighters from *Escuadrilla 4-E-3* of *Grupo 3-G-3*, whilst behind them are aircraft from *Escuadrilla 2-E-3* of *Grupo 2-G-3*. Fighters from both units have black and white symbols painted on their wheel spats, a 'rose of four winds' for 4-E-3 and a number 2 on a white disc for 2-E-3. The circular *Patrulla Azul* emblem appears on the fins of all the CR.32s (A Emiliani archive)





Capitán Joaquín García Morato starts the engine of his CR.32 3-51 on the Aragon front in the late summer of 1937. His groundcrew on this occasion were Spanish Moroccans (A Emiliani archive via E Santandrea)

Capitán Julio Salvador Díaz Benjumea is seen here in 1940 whilst leading the Spanish air force's *Escuela de Caza* at Reus, in Catalonia. Promoted to comandante, in 1942 he fought in Russia with the Spanish volunteers of the *Aviación Expedicionaria* within the Luftwaffe's VIII *Fliegerkorps*. The latter was led by General Wolfram Von Richthofen, the last commander of the *Legion Condor* in Spain. Back in Spain, Salvador enjoyed a successful career that culminated with him becoming air minister in 1969, and flying until 1976 – by then he had totalled 7906 flying hours. He passed away in 1987 (A Emiliani archive)



12 others (plus two moored airships). No other Spanish Civil War pilot on either side had a comparable record.

García Morato's death in a crash at Griñón airfield on 4 April 1939 is still shrouded in mystery. According to official information released by the Nationalists, he died at the controls of his faithful CR.32 '3-51', in which he had claimed most of his victories. The fighter was reported as having been destroyed when it hit the ground near-horizontally while performing

a dangerous landing manoeuvre following an aerobatic display and mock combat with an I-16.

However, during the days immediately following García Morato's death, both the Spanish and foreign press claimed that the ace had lost his life while testing a *Rata*, which crashed inverted moments after take-off. Moreover, according to some of García Morato's closest friends and colleagues, the ace seemed to have a death wish as the conflict drew to an end. This was possibly brought on by the tension accumulated over 30 months of war, as García Morato had spent most of this time flying and fighting. He had seen numerous friends killed fighting fellow Spaniards, and this had a great effect on him.

The death of Spain's leading fighter pilot provoked widespread distress among his subordinates, who revered García Morato for his qualities as both a leader and an ace. A crowd some 20,000 strong attended his funeral in Madrid. Amongst the mourners were the new Head of State, General Franco, and the *Jefe del Aire*, Gen Alfredo Kindelán Duany, who placed the posthumous Individual Military Medal on his body, in addition to the *Cruz Laureada de San Fernando* that had already been awarded to him during the war. García Morato was also promoted to the rank of commander. Following the transfer of his coffin to Malaga, which was his adopted hometown, the local population of 100,000 attended the burial ceremony.

García Morato was also honoured by the Italians too, receiving the nation's highest honour for military valour, the *Medaglia d'Oro al valor Militaire*. The citation accompanying the award noted that the Spanish ace was a 'legendary courageous aviator, and a brother to all Italian pilots'.

The second ranking Nationalist fighter ace was Julio Salvador, who flew 1066 hours during the course of 567 combat sorties. Some 893 hours and 515 sorties were flown in the CR.32, and he fought 50 aerial combats. By the end of the conflict his tally stood at 26 individual and four shared victories (the latter including the destruction of an airship and a balloon) and four probables.

Between March and November 1942 Salvador fought on the Eastern Front alongside several other Spanish Nationalist pilots as he led the expeditionary unit 15.(*Span*)/JG 51. Flying Bf 109F-2s, he claimed two LaGG-3s destroyed. Upon his return to Spain Salvador remained in the

air force, being promoted to general in 1963. The Minister for Aviation from 1969 to 1974, he continued to fly until April 1976, by which point he had logged 7906 flying hours. Salvador finally retired from military service in 1980, after which he served as President of the Reserve of the *Ejército del Aire* until his death on 26 June 1987.

The remains of the third ranking Nationalist fighter ace, Manuel Vázquez, who fell in action over enemy territory on 23 January 1939, were recovered at the end of the war and buried in Seville on 2 April 1939 in a moving ceremony attended by García Morato and his *Escuadra de Caza* companions. Vázquez was posthumously awarded the Individual Military Medal during the service. Four weeks later, Gen Kindelán officially proposed that Vázquez should posthumously receive the *Cruz Laureada de San Fernando*, which was Spain's highest honour for military valour. However, thanks to bureaucratic delays, this award was not promulgated until 1947.

The fourth ranking Nationalist ace, Arístides García López, was the only one of the top five pilots to have started the war as a non-commissioned officer – a rank more usually seen in the Republican forces. In June 1941 he was awarded the *Medalla Militar* (Individual Military Medal) for the courage he had displayed during the Spanish Civil War. However, García López was posted missing in action prior to the presentation ceremony planned for 10 December that same year. On 27 November, while serving as a patrol leader with the Bf 109E-equipped 1ª *Escuadrilla de Caza Expedicionaria* (staffed by Spanish volunteer pilots sent to fight in the USSR), he failed to return from a patrol over the Moscow front.

Ranked fifth in the ace listing, Ángel Salas flew more combat sorties (618, totalling 1215 hours) than any other Nationalist fighter pilot during the Spanish Civil War. Three-quarters of these sorties/hours came in the CR.32. Salas fought 49 aerial combats, during which he was credited with 15 individual and five shared victories, four probables and one shared destroyed on the ground. All but three of his victories were claimed in a CR.32. Moreover, Salas was credited with the destruction of 48 enemy vehicles, as well as sharing in the sinking of ten small boats and the capture of a sailing ship! Salas was shot down four times, while aircraft that he returned to base in had been hit 117 times.

In July 1941 he left Spain as CO of 1ª *Escuadrilla de Caza Expedicionaria en Rusia* (1st Expeditionary Fighter Squadron in Russia), which supported the German advance towards Moscow – his unit was equipped with Bf 109Es and attached to JG 27. Salas was the most active among his pilots, performing 70 combat missions and being credited with six aerial victories and two aircraft destroyed on the ground. On 4 November he was forced down between German and Soviet lines,



Capitán Arístides García López Rengel poses for the camera in 1940, by which point he was commander of a newly formed CR.32 fighter group. In 1941 García López also fought in Russia with Spanish volunteers of the *Primera Escuadrilla Expedicionaria de Caza*. He was posted missing in action on the Moscow front on 27 November 1941, his body never being found (A Emilian archive)

Comandante Ángel Salas Larrazabal (right), wearing the uniform of a major in the Luftwaffe, converses with Werner Mölders, German Luftwaffe Fighter Force Inspector, on the Russian front in the autumn of 1941. Salas was commander of *Staffel 15/JG 27*, or the *Primera Escuadrilla Expedicionaria de Caza en Rusia*, which consisted of Spanish volunteers. Mölders was the *Legion Condor's* leading ace with 14 individual victories and one probable flying Bf 109s in Spain. He subsequently became the world's first fighter ace to be credited with 100 victories, and by July 1941 he had also become the first pilot to achieve 100 victories in World War 2 alone (Author archive)



Comandante Ángel Salas Larrazabal, securing his Luftwaffe issue flying helmet, is seen here in the autumn of 1941 whilst leading 1ª *Escuadrilla Expedicionaria de Caza en Rusia*. Behind him is a Bf 109E adorned with the second *Patrulla Azul* emblem, the first one having been worn by Nationalist fighter groups during the Spanish Civil War. The Roman numerals I and II indicate he first and second conflicts fought by Spain and Germany against communism. In October 1941 Salas was credited with six individual and five shared victories, plus 15 individual and four shared probables. After a long career as a military attaché serving abroad, Salas was promoted to *teniente general* in 1966 and he continued to fill senior positions within the Spanish air force until 1972 when, aged 66, he was transferred to the air reserve. Named a member of the Spanish Royal Council after the death of Gen Franco in 1975 and promoted to *capitán general* in 1991, Salas passed away in 1994 (Author archive)

and he was subsequently rescued by friendly troops the following day.

Upon returning to Spain, Salas fulfilled diplomatic assignments in Germany, Switzerland, Portugal and France both during and after World War 2. On promotion to general he was given command of the *Fuerza Aérea de Defensa* and became *Jefe del Mando de Aviación Táctica* in 1966, holding other senior positions through to the end of his active service in 1972. Following the death of Gen Franco in 1975, Salas became a member of the Regency Council. He passed away on 19 July 1994.

The highest-scoring Italian pilot of the Spanish Civil War placed sixth in the list of aces, Sottufficiale Bruno Montegnacco claimed 15 individual victories and one probable. He returned to Italy in the summer of 1937 following a year in Spain, being awarded the Silver Medal for Military Valour and promotion to *sottotenente*

as a result of his achievements in combat. Montegnacco rejoined 1° *Stormo Caccia* at Campoformido and took up aerobatic flying once again. He expressed a strong desire to return to Spain with the first Fiat G.50 monoplanes to reach frontline service, without knowing just how poor these fighters performed in combat.

During the spring of 1938 Montegnacco was part of a large aerobatic formation consisting of 28 CR.32s that had been created to perform a flying display to mark the visit of Adolf Hitler to Italy. On the morning of 13 April, near Gorizia, pilots began practising the most difficult and dangerous aerobatic manoeuvre in the programme – a loop by the entire formation. As the CR.32s climbed, section leader Capitano Brambilla (also a Spanish war veteran) collided with Montegnacco's aircraft just before reaching the apex of the manoeuvre. Brambilla managed to escape by parachute, but Montegnacco fell to his death trapped in his aircraft, which burst into flames upon hitting the ground. He was posthumously awarded the Gold Medal for Aeronautical Valour.

Belgian volunteer Rodolphe Charles Geoffrey de Hemricourt de Grunne Montalembert ranks eighth in the Spanish Civil War CR.32 list with 14 kills from 425 combat sorties (and 27 aerial engagements) totalling 749 hours. One place above him is the leading non-CR.32 Nationalist ace, Werner Mölders, who claimed 14 kills and one probable in the Bf 109. At war's end de Hemricourt returned home and joined the Belgian air force six months later. When the Germans launched their *blitzkrieg* in the west in May 1940, his unit's Hurricanes were destroyed on the ground by Luftwaffe Bf 109Es. De Hemricourt duly fled by car with other pilots to France, where he eventually embarked in a British destroyer in the Mediterranean and sailed to Liverpool, arriving on 7 July. Meanwhile, back in Belgium he was officially listed as a 'deserter'.

In England de Hemricourt joined the RAF, and he saw action flying Hurricanes with No 32 Sqn during the Battle of Britain against German pilots that had previously been his allies in Spain. In August 1940 he was credited with three probable kills prior to being shot down by Bf 109s –

he escaped by parachute. On 21 May 1941, while flying a Spitfire with No 609 Sqn, de Hemricourt became embroiled in a dogfight with Bf 109s over the Channel. His fighter burst into flames after being hit, and although the Belgian was seen to parachute into the sea, he was never recovered. Twenty-five days later in Spain, without knowledge of this incident, de Hemricourt was awarded the Individual Military Medal in recognition of his distinguished service during the civil war. In Belgium, he remained listed as a 'deserter' seven years after his death in action.

Miguel Guerrero flew 1050 hours during 575 operational sorties, of which 794 hours and 438 sorties were on CR.32s. He finished ninth in the Nationalists' overall list of aces and eighth in the CR.32 list, with 13 individual victories (nine flying the Fiat fighter). Decorated with the Individual Military Medal, he went on to command a fighter unit in Morocco during World War 2. On becoming a general, Guerrero was assigned important command and General Staff positions, as well as diplomatic assignments in the USA. In 1970 he was made commander of the 1st Aerial Region of Spain, and subsequently joined the Reserve in 1979. Guerrero passed away in Madrid in 1992.

Among the Italian aces in Spain, Adriano Mantelli claimed the highest number of individually credited aerial victories after Montegnacco and Presel (the latter was killed before the war had ended). Officially credited with ten victories, the Italian press had attributed as many as 27 kills to Mantelli. It was eventually proven that this total included both shared and unconfirmed victories, as well as two aircraft destroyed on the ground.

In the spring of 1937 Mantelli returned to Italy and eventually became a test pilot at the Guidonia Aircraft Experimental Centre near Rome. After Italy entered the war in 1940, he was promoted to capitano and transferred to the *Direzione Costruzioni Aeronautiche* (Aircraft Construction Directorate) in Naples. Mantelli flew his last combat mission on the morning of 8 September 1943 – the day of Italy's Armistice with the Allies – in a Macchi C.202 against a formation of USAAF B-17 bombers targeting Frascati. As a test pilot and flight instructor for the new Fiat G.55 fighter, he then served in the *Aeronautica della Repubblica Sociale Italiana* (Italian Social Republic Air Force). The latter continued to fight alongside Germany under the command of another veteran ace from Spain, Ernesto Botto. A post-war trial cleared Mantelli of 'collaboration' by serving with the *Aeronautica della Repubblica Sociale Italiana*.

He continued to design and construct light civil aircraft in Italy and Argentina prior to rejoining the Italian air force in 1951. Rising through the ranks, Mantelli became a general and eventually retired in Rome. Remaining active, he died from a sudden illness at the age of 82 whilst waiting for a train at Florence station on 6 May 1995. During his long flying career, Mantelli had flown more than 10,000 hours in 200+ aircraft types, setting several international light aircraft records in the process.

Claiming nine individual and 12 shared kills, and two probables, Guido Nobili was decorated with two Silver Medals for Military Valour in recognition of his service in Spain between 1936 and 1938. During the final months of the civil war he served with the *Aviación Nacional* as Chief Instructor of the *Escuela de Caza*, being successively based at Gallur,

Recently promoted Maggiore Guido Nobili is seen here in the winter of 1937-38 whilst serving as a group staff senior adjutant during operations on the Teruel front in Aragon. Note the *Asso di Bastoni* group emblem on his flying jacket opposite his rank badge. Standing behind him is one of Spain's most valiant pilots, Capitán Carlos Haya González, who was a volunteer attached to the *Aviazione Legionaria* within XXIII Gruppo Caccia. He was killed in action at Castralvo, near Teruel, on 21 February 1938 (Author archive)



Villanubla and Reus. Nobili enjoyed great respect among both Spanish commanders and trainees alike due to his combat record and fantastic flying skills. He demonstrated the latter by routinely flying a captured I-16 assigned to the school in realistic mock training with student pilots. Nobili continued to serve in Spain through to May 1940, at which point he returned home due to Italy's imminent entry into World War 2.

Initially Nobili commanded a fighter unit, but in 1942 he was made CO of 5° *Stormo Tuffatori* (Dive-Bombers), equipped with the Ju 87 Stuka – these were subsequently replaced by Reggiane Re.2002 fighter-bombers. Nobili perished leading his unit in action against the overwhelming Allied invasion force sent to occupy Sicily. In an unequal aerial combat fought during the afternoon of 10 July 1943 near Augusta, he was shot down by Spitfires. Nobili was posthumously awarded a third Silver Medal for Military Valour.

Fellow Italian ace Andrea Zotti flew 580 hours in combat in Spain and was credited with nine individual and six shared aerial victories, as well as two probables. During his service in Spain Zotti married Isabel Kindelán, daughter of Gen Alfredo Kindelán Duany, who commanded the Nationalist air force. Upon his return to Italy in the summer of 1938, having been decorated with three Silver Medals for Military Valour, Zotti was assigned to the General Staff of 3ª *Squadra Aerea*. He subsequently tested new aeroplanes prior to their delivery to the *Regia Aeronautica*, eventually logging a total of 2340 flying hours before being killed on 16 March 1940 when the tri-motor in which he was a passenger crashed into the southern Tyrrhenian Sea.

Fellow aces Enrico Degli Incerti and Giuseppe Majone also lost their lives in flying accidents (although both were flying CR.32s), on 22 July 1938 and 18 April 1939, respectively. All of the remaining six Italian aces of the Spanish conflict – Aurili, Daffara, François, Cenni, Baschiroto and Botto – saw additional combat in World War 2, and five of them survived the conflict. The only one to perish was Giuseppe Cenni, who had become a Ju 87 pilot shortly after Italy declared war in June 1940. Promoted to capitano and *squadriglia* commander, he flew with 5° *Stormo* over the Aegean Sea and in North Africa during 1941, sinking two ships and putting a third out of action. Cenni's unit was led by fellow civil war ace Guido Nobili from 1942, and that year his *squadriglia* fought in the Mediterranean theatre. Cenni was promoted to maggiore on 31 July as a reward for his combat service to date.

When Nobili fell in action at the start of the Sicilian campaign, Cenni replaced him in command of 5° *Stormo*, which fought on despite the tremendous numerical superiority enjoyed by the Allies. On 4 September 1943 he led an attack on the Allied beachhead in Calabria, and like Nobili, his Re.2002 was also shot down by Spitfires (on this occasion from No 111 Sqn RAF) over the Aspromonte. Cenni was killed. The Armistice, representing Italy's surrender, had been secretly signed the previous day. Cenni, who left behind a young wife and two children born during the war, was posthumously honoured with the Gold Medal for Military Valour. He had previously received six silver medals awarded to him in Spain and during the course of World War 2.

With the rebirth of the *Aeronautica Militare* of the Italian Republic post-war, 5° *Stormo Caccia* was named after Giuseppe Cenni.

APPENDICES

FIAT CR.32 ACES OF THE SPANISH CIVIL WAR

Rank	Name (and Italian alias)	Nation	Claims (+unconfirmed) individual and shared	Unit(s)	Notes
Com	Joaquín García Morato Castaño	Sp	40(+13) 4	c. 1ª, c. 2ª, 1-E-3, 2-G-3, 3-G-3, EdC	(1)
Cap	Julio Salvador Díaz Benjumea	Sp	26(+4) 4	3ª, 1-E-3, c. 1-E-3	(2)
Cap	Manuel Vázquez Sagastizábal	Sp	21(+7) 2	1-E-3, c. 1-E-3	(3)
Cap	Aristides García López Rengel	Sp	17	1-E-3, 5-E-3/3-E-3, 8-E-3, c. 8-E-3	(4)
Com	Ángel Salas Larrazábal	Sp	15(+4) 5	2ª, 3ª; c. 4ª, 2-E-3, 2-G-3	(5)
Ser M	Bruno Montegnacco (alias 'Romualdi')	It	15(+1)	1ª, 3ª, 26ª	(6)
Ten	Rodolphe de Hemricourt de Grunne	Be.	14	2-E-3	(7)
Cap	Miguel Guerrero García	Sp	13(+2)	1-E-3, 3-E-3, c. 5-E-3	(8)
Cap	Miguel García Pardo	Sp	13 2	3ª, 2-E-3, c. 2-E-3	(9)
Ten	Joaquín Velasco Fernández Nespral	Sp	13	7-E-3	
Ser M	Guido Presel (alias 'Sammartano')	It	12(+2) 10	1ª, 3ª, 26ª	(10)
Cap	Carlos Bayo Alessandri	Sp	11(+1)	2-E-3	
Ten	Adriano Mantelli (alias 'Arrighi')	It	10 12(+3)	1ª, 2ª, 4ª	(11)
Cap	Guido Nobili (alias 'Notabili')	It	9(+2) 12	c. 2ª, 18ª	(12)
T Col	Andrea Zotti (alias 'Biondi')	It	9(+2) 6	c. XXIII Gruppo	
Cap	Enrico Degli Incerti (alias 'Tocci')	It	8(+3) 5	c. 1ª, 19ª	(13)
Cap	Javier Allende Isasi	Sp	7(+2)	2-E-3, c. 7-E-3	(14)
Ten	Esteban Ibarreche Arriaga	Sp	7 2	5-E-3/3-E-3	
S ten	Giuseppe Aurili (alias 'Banchero')	It	7(+1) 1	4ª, 24ª	(15)
Cap	Giuseppe Majone (alias 'Magone')	It	7 24(+11)	c. 24ª	
Ten	José Larios Fernández Villavicencio	Sp	6(+5)	6-E-3	(16)
Mar	Vittorino Daffara (alias 'De Pretis')	It	6 4(+9)	2ª, 19ª	
Magg	Armando François (alias 'Martori')	It	6 3	c. 5ª, 25ª, XVI Gruppo	
S ten	Giuseppe Cenni (alias 'Stella')	It	6 3	1ª, 5ª	(17)
Ten	Emilio O'Connor Valdivielso	Sp	6	4-E-3	
Ser M	Gianlino Baschiroto (alias 'Giri')	It	5(+3) 5(+1)	1ª, 2ª, 4ª, 24ª	
Ten	Abundio Cesteros García	Sp	5(+1)	5-E-3/3-E-3, 8-E-3	
Cap	Rafael Simón García	Sp	5(+1)	2-E-3, 3-E-3, c. E.IIa Provisional	
Ten	Antonio Manrique Garrido	Sp	5(+1)	1-E-3	
Cap	Ernesto Botto (alias 'Cantini')	It	5 15(+7)	c. 32ª	
Cap	Javier Murcia Rubio	Sp	5	2-E-3, c. 3-E-3/5-E-3	
Ten	Luis Alcocer Moreno Abella	Sp	5	2-G-3, E.IIa Provisional	
Ten	Jorge Muntadas Claramunt	Sp	5	2-E-3, 8-E-3	(18)

Notes

- Individual claims including 1 confirmed +1 probable flying Ni-H.52 and 3 confirmed +1 probable flying He 51
Individual claims do not include 2 probably destroyed on the ground. Shared claims including 2 dirigibles
Individual unconfirmed claims are part of 133 aircraft directly engaged in air combat in addition to confirmed kills
Shared claims do not include 12 destroyed on the ground. Killed in flying accident 4 April 1939
- Individual claims including 3 confirmed flying He 51 and 1 initially recorded as unconfirmed flying CR.32
Shared claims including 1 captive balloon and 1 dirigible
- Killed in action 23 January 1939
- Individual claims including 1 confirmed flying He 51. Missing in action 27 November 1941 in Russia
- Individual claims including 1 confirmed flying Ni-H.52 and 2 confirmed flying He 51
Shared claims do not include 1 destroyed on the ground
- Individual claims do not include 1 destroyed on the ground. Killed in flying accident 13 April 1938 in Italy

- (7) Individual claims including 4 initially recorded as unconfirmed
- (8) Individual claims including 4 confirmed and 1 probable flying Ni-H.52
- (9) Individual claims including 2 confirmed flying Ni-H.52 and He 112. Killed in flying accident 28 March 1939
- (10) Individual claims do not include 2 destroyed on the ground. Killed in action 5 June 1937
- (11) Individual claims do not include 2 destroyed on the ground. Shared claims including 6 +3 unspecified
- (12) Unofficial Spanish account indicating 10 individual confirmed claims
- (13) Killed in flying accident 22 July 1938 in Italy
- (14) Individual claims including 1 confirmed flying He 51
- (15) Shared claim of a civil-type aircraft officially credited to *Comandante di Squadriglia* Capitano Brambilla
- (16) Unconfirmed claims include one reported as confirmed by Nationalist Official War Bulletin
- (17) Shared claims including 1 dirigible and do not include 2 destroyed on the ground
- (18) Individual claims including 1 confirmed flying He 51

Key

Rank – is the highest achieved during war service in Spain

Nation – refers to pilot's nationality, Spanish, Italian or Belgian

Claims – refer to total number of aerial victories whilst flying CR.32s or other aircraft types, as specified by 'Notes'

Units – only those equipped with CR.32s are detailed

c. – indicates 'commander' or leader of the unit specified

a – indicates *squadriglia* number of *Aviación del Tercio* or *Aviazione Legionaria*. EdC stands for *Escuadra de Caza*

COLOUR PLATES

1

CR.32 of Sergente Guido Presel, 1ª Escuadrilla de Caza of Aviación del Tercio, Seville-Tablada, August 1936

One of the first CR.32s shipped to Spain, this aircraft is finished in silver overall, with a copper-yellow radiator ring and black wing struts. It features Nationalist markings as ordered by Gen Franco on 8 August – black roundels on the fuselage sides and undersurfaces of the upper wing tips, with a black St Andrew's Cross on the rudder. No individual aircraft code numbers had yet been applied. The fighter also has two pairs of black stripes on the upperwing wing centre section.

2

CR.32 NC 103 of Capitán Angel Salas Larrazábal, 2ª Escuadrilla de Caza of Aviación del Tercio, Talavera de la Reina, September 1936

One of nine CR.32s unloaded at Vigo de Galicia on 27 August 1936, this aircraft features the same marking as the aircraft in profile 1, bar the black spinner tip. The Fiat factory number 103 is also marked on the port side of the rear fuselage.

3

CR.32 of Sottotenente Adriano Mantelli, 2ª Escuadrilla de Caza of Aviación del Tercio, Cáceres, September 1936

This aircraft is camouflaged in irregular reddish-brown patches on sand-yellow uppersurfaces, nose and wheel spats, while its undersurfaces and aft fuselage sides have been left in silver. Updated upper wing markings consisted of three black stripes near each wingtip. Titling *MONICO ! PRESENTE* was applied to the port side of the fuselage only.

4

CR.32 of Sottotenente Giuseppe Cenni, 1ª Escuadrilla de Caza of Aviación del Tercio, Talavera de la Reina, September-October 1936

By the end of September 1936, the reddish-brown on sand-yellow camouflage had been extended to the aft fuselage sides and closer around the *MONICO ! PRESENTE* titling. The rudder and undersurfaces remained in silver, however.

5

CR.32 NC 105 of Sergente Maggiore Guido Presel, 3ª Escuadrilla de Caza of Aviación del Tercio, Torrijos-Barcience, November 1936

This aircraft displays the two-colour scheme adopted for CR.32s in central continental Spain in late 1936, consisting of narrow reddish-brown patches on sand-yellow uppersurfaces, with the undersurfaces left in silver. Coded 3-22, this aircraft was one of the first to be identified by a series of fleet-wide individual numbers, rather than by unit – a system later maintained by Spanish CR.32 units only, starting with the serial 3-51. Italian units applied identification numbers by *squadriglia*, and they generally ranged from 3-1 to 3-12.

6

CR.32 NC 183 of Sergente Maggiore Bruno Montegnacco, 3ª Squadriglia, I Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria, Seville-Tablada, December 1936-January 1937

This aircraft has been camouflaged with mottled olive-green and reddish-brown patches over yellow-sand and reddish-brown paint or directly onto its silver fuselage sides. The rudder has been left in silver, while its wing struts and undersurfaces are pale bluish-grey. The second 3 in its code was its individual identification number within 3ª *Squadriglia Caccia*, this unit also marking the wheel spats of its CR.32s.

7

CR.32bis quadriarmi of Capitano Armando François, leader of 5ª Squadriglia, II Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria, Granada-Armilla, February 1937

Shipped to Spain in December 1936, this CR.32bis quadriarm has been camouflaged with large areas of sand-yellow over which narrow olive-green patches have been applied. The CR.32's undersurfaces and rudder remain silver, although its spinner is olive-green. It wears the code 3-1, with the number 1 often being reserved for aircraft assigned to *squadriglie* commanders, as was the case in Italy. The number 5 on its wheel spats indicated 5^a *Squadriglia*. Its upperwing markings included two white St Andrew's crosses in central positions, plus three black stripes near each wingtip.

8

CR.32bis NC 508 of Teniente Julio Salvador Díaz Benjumea, Patrulla Azul of Aviación Nacional, Seville-Tablada, February 1937

NC 508 is camouflaged with scattered olive-green shaded patches over sand-yellow uppersurfaces and pale bluish-grey undersides. The black St Andrew's Cross has been applied to a white rudder. The yoke and arrows symbol of the *Falange Española Tradicionalista* (FET) has been applied to the roundels to indicate that this was a Spanish unit. Note the *Patrulla Azul* emblem on the fin, which was worn on the port side only, with factory number 508 to starboard. Initially coded 3-13, this aircraft became 3-52 in the spring of 1937.

9

CR.32 NC 208 of Sergente Maggiore Guido Presel, 26^a Squadriglia, XVI Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria, Vitoria, May-June 1937

Camouflaged with olive-green and ochre-yellow patches over sand-yellow uppersurfaces and pale bluish-grey undersurfaces, this aircraft also had a white St Andrew's Cross applied over the three black stripes painted on each wingtip. The factory number 208 appeared on the starboard side of the fin only. Presel was shot down and killed in this aircraft over Vizcaya on 5 June 1937.

10

CR.32bis NC 597 of Capitán Miguel Guerrero García, Escuadrilla 1-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Saragossa, June 1937

Shipped to Spain in April 1937, NC 597 was initially coded 3-5 at Seville-Tablada following re-assembly. Shortly thereafter this changed to its definitive code, 3-54. Camouflaged with shaded olive-green and ochre-yellow patches over sand-yellow uppersurfaces and pale bluish-grey undersides, the aircraft had a *Patrulla Azul* emblem applied to its port fin only in May 1937 – factory number 597 was to starboard. This marking was extended to all *Grupo 2-G-3* aircraft. Note its spinner with a red tip, and 1-E-3 number 1 on its wheel spats.

11

CR.32bis NC 596 of Teniente Miguel García Pardo, Escuadrilla 2-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Seville to Avila, July 1937

Shipped to Spain in April 1937, this aircraft received the code 3-60. Camouflaged with olive-green and ochre-yellow patches over most of its uppersurfaces, it also had small areas of sand-yellow (including the spinner) and pale bluish-grey undersides. Note the red FET symbol on the fuselage roundel and black 2 on wheel spats, the latter indicating its

assignment to 2-E-3. This machine was flown by García Pardo during the battle of Brunete in July 1937.

12

CR.32bis NC 601 of Comandante Joaquín García Morato, leader of Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Seville to Avila, July 1937

Shipped to Spain in April 1937, this aircraft was coded 3-57. It was camouflaged with shaded olive-green and ochre-yellow patches on sand-yellow uppersurfaces, with pale bluish-grey undersurfaces and a rare sand-yellow rudder. No *Escuadrilla* number has been painted on the wheel spats, as the aircraft was operating as a *grupo* staff machine. It was flown by *grupo* leader García Morato during the battle of Brunete as his 3-51 was temporarily unserviceable.

13

CR.32bis NC 594 of Capitán Julio Salvador Díaz Benjumea, Escuadrilla 1-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Avila, July 1937

Shipped to Spain in April 1937, where it received the code 3-58, this fighter was camouflaged with shaded olive-green and ochre-yellow patches over sand-yellow uppersurfaces, with pale bluish-grey undersides. The *Patrulla Azul* emblem adopted by *Grupo 2-G-3* can be seen on the port side of the fin, with the factory number 594 to starboard. This CR.32 was flown by Salvador during the battle of Brunete.

14

CR.32 of Sergente Maggiore Gianlino Baschiroto, 24^a Squadriglia, XVI Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria, Saragossa, August 1937

Camouflaged with shaded olive-green on sand-yellow uppersurfaces, and with a sand-yellow rudder and pale bluish-grey undersurfaces, this aircraft also had black wing struts and a black tail wheel spat. Coded 3-5 within 24^a *Squadriglia*, the fighter bore the unit's white wheel spat disc identifier, adorned with the number 24. This had been the unit marking since April 1937. No group emblem had yet been applied. A small white AB monogram also adorned the radiator-ring.

15

CR.32 of Maggiore Andrea Zotti, leader of XXIII Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria, Saragossa, August 1937

One of 33 CR.32s that formed XXIII *Gruppo* on 22 April 1937 at Seville, this machine was coded 3-11 and assigned to the group CO of the three *squadriglie* that made up this unit – 18^a, 19^a and 20^a, each initially equipped with 11 fighters. It was camouflaged in a four-colour scheme consisting of yellow, ochre-yellow, olive-green and reddish-brown uppersurfaces, with pale bluish-grey undersides and black wing strut fairings. The group emblem, *Asso di Bastoni*, was painted on both sides of the fuselage. Note also the white rectangular command pennant on the black roundel.

16

CR.32 NC 111 of Capitán Angel Salas Larrazábal, leader of Escuadrilla 2-E-3 and Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Saragossa and León, August-October 1937

Shipped to Spain in 1936, this aircraft received the code 3-61 in the spring of 1937. It is camouflaged in sand-yellow, olive-

green and reddish-brown patches over aluminium, with silver undersides. The *Patrulla Azul* emblem has been applied to a white background on this occasion. The titling *BERMUDEZ PRESENTE* honoured the memory of Capitán Bermúdez de Castro, who was the first Spanish CR.32 pilot killed in combat on 12 July 1937. Salas initially flew 3-61 as the new leader of *Grupo 2-G-3* in September–October 1937, seeing action over León, on the Asturias front. He kept it until war's end.

17

CR.32bis NC 331 of Comandante Ángel Salas Larrazábal, leader of *Escuadrilla 2-E-3* and *Grupo 2-G-3* of *Aviación Nacional*, Saragossa, September 1937

Also shipped to Spain in 1936, this aircraft became 3-63 in the spring of 1937. Its two-colour camouflage scheme consisted of olive-green patches over sand-yellow uppersurfaces, with pale bluish-grey undersides and wing strut fairings. It too carried the titling *BERMUDEZ PRESENTE*. Salas flew 3-63 during the battle of Brunete in July 1937 and also between April and June 1938, when 3-61 was unserviceable.

18

CR.32 NC 262 of Comandante Joaquín García Morato, leader of *Grupo 2-G-3* of *Aviación Nacional*, Saragossa, September 1937

Shipped to Spain in 1936, this CR.32 was assigned to ranking ace García Morato. From early 1937 the *Patrulla Azul* emblem was worn on the port side of the aircraft's fin, with the factory number 262 to starboard. There was no *escuadrilla* number on its wheel spats. 3-51 is seen here with its newly applied three-colour camouflage scheme of olive-green, ochre-yellow and sand-yellow uppersurfaces and wing strut fairings.

19

CR.32 NC 29 of Capitano Guido Nobili, leader of 18^a *Squadriglia*, XXIII *Gruppo Caccia di Aviazione Legionaria*, Almaluez, September–October 1937

NC 29 is camouflaged in a two-colour scheme of olive-green patches over sand-yellow uppersurfaces, with wing strut fairings to match. 18^a *Squadriglia* marked its aircraft with a black 18 on striking yellow and red wheel spats. Note also the more detailed *Asso di Bastoni* emblem worn by this machine. The white triangular badge within the black roundel indicated that NC 29 was flown by a *squadriglia* leader – a similar marking was applied to the centre section of the upperwing.

20

CR.32 of Capitano Enrico Degli Inceri, leader of 19^a *Squadriglia*, XXIII *Gruppo Caccia di Aviazione Legionaria*, Almaluez, October 1937

This aircraft has a similar camouflage scheme to the CR.32 in the previous profile. The stylised red lightning bolt symbol with the number 19 on the wheel spats indicates 19^a *Squadriglia*. It also has an *Asso di Bastoni* emblem and a white triangular *squadriglia* leader's marking in the roundel.

21

CR.32bis NC 623 of Capitano Ernesto Botto, leader of 32^a *Squadriglia*, VI *Gruppo Caccia* of *Aviazione Legionaria*, Alfamén to Saragossa, October 1937

Camouflaged in olive-green and reddish-brown patches over

ochre-yellow uppersurfaces, with pale bluish-grey undersides, this aircraft's white triangular symbol with a black 32 over a partially obscured red-orange disc on the wheel spats denoted its assignment to 32^a *Squadriglia*. Its identification number 3 was painted in white as a leadership marking near the cockpit, without any *squadriglia* number. On 12 October 1937 Botto was seriously wounded whilst flying this aircraft.

22

CR.32 NC 262 of Comandante Joaquín García Morato, *Estado Mayor Primera Brigada Aérea* of *Aviación Nacional*, Saragossa–Sanjurjo, December 1937

García Morato flew 3-51 from late 1936 through to early 1939, during which time it received at least six different camouflage schemes. By the end of 1937 it was painted in olive-green and sand-yellow patches over ochre-yellow uppersurfaces, with pale bluish-grey undersides and wing-strut fairings. In December 1937 García Morato was appointed *Jefe* of 3^a *Sección Operaciones* within the *Estado Mayor* of the *Primera Brigada Aérea Hispana*, although he continued to see action. Rigid staff pennants were applied to both the port and starboard outer wing strut fairings. The ace had the telescopic gunsight removed, using a simple ring and bead sight instead.

23

CR.32ter NC 756 of Teniente Carlos Bayo Alessandri, *Escuadrilla 2-E-3*, *Grupo 2-G-3*, of *Aviación Nacional*, Alfamén, December 1937–January 1938

Shipped to Spain in October 1937, the fighter received the code 3-72. It was camouflaged in a three-colour scheme of olive-green and reddish-brown patches over sand-yellow upper surfaces, with pale bluish-grey undersides and wing strut fairings. The gunsight telescopic tube was retained.

24

CR.32ter NC 781 of Capitán Miguel Guerrero García, leader of *Escuadrilla 5-E-3*, *Grupo 2-G-3* of *Aviación Nacional*, Tauste, March 1938

Shipped to Spain in November 1937, where it received the code 3-91, this machine was camouflaged in olive-green patches over ochre-yellow, with wing strut fairings to match. The number 5 in a red and yellow rhomboidal symbol on the wheel spats indicated its assignment to 5-E-3, these colours later being changed to black and white so as to match other Nationalist fighter *escuadrilla* identification symbols.

25

CR.32bis NC 596 of Teniente Rodolphe de Hemricourt de Grunne, *Escuadrilla 2-E-3*, *Grupo 2-G-3* of *Aviación Nacional*, Tauste, March 1938

3-60 served with 2-E-3 from its formation in May 1937. Following an overhaul, it received a three-colour camouflage scheme of olive-green and reddish-brown over sand-yellow. It has the early style number 2 on a white disc on its wheel spats denoting 2-E-3, and a *Patrulla Azul* emblem with a blue background. The telescopic sight has also been replaced.

26

CR.32 NC 117 of Maggiore Armando François, leader of XVI *Gruppo Caccia* of *Aviazione Legionaria*, Saragossa–Valenzuela, March–April 1938

This aircraft was flown by Capitano François from 1937 when leader of 25^a *Squadriglia*, being camouflaged in olive-green, reddish-brown, ochre-yellow and sand-yellow. Promoted to maggiore, François commanded XVI *Gruppo* from 17 January 1938. He had the triangular *squadriglia* leader's markings replaced with a *gruppo* leader's pennant within the fuselage roundels, and also had the *Cucaracha* emblem modified as per the XVI *Gruppo* symbol (dark body and head turned forward). NC 117 retained its triangular 25^a *Squadriglia* markings on its wheel spats, however. Note the Avia camera fitted in the forward fairing of the upperwing fuel tank.

27

CR.32ter NC 788 of Teniente Emilio O'Connor Valdivielso, Escuadrilla 4-E-3, Grupo 3-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Bello, May 1938

Shipped to Spain in November 1937 coded 3-98, NC 788 has olive-green patches on ochre-yellow uppersurfaces. The port side of the fin has been decorated with 3-G-3's original emblem – the wooden horse *Clavileño* ridden by *Don Quixote* and *Sancho Panza*. The white 4 in a black/white triangle on the wheel spat denoted NC 788's assignment to 4-E-3.

28

CR.32ter NC 854 of Teniente Colonnello Andrea Zotti, leader of XXIII Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria, Puig Moreno, June-July 1938

Shipped to Spain in 1938 and assigned to Zotti towards the end of his time in Spain, this aircraft has olive-green and reddish-brown patches over sand-yellow uppersurfaces. It is also marked with the *Asso di Bastoni* emblem of XXIII *Gruppo* and the group commander's pennant – the latter was also applied to the centre section of the upper wing.

29

CR.32quater NC 971 of Teniente Carlos Bayo Alessandri, Escuadrilla 2-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Escatrón, August 1938

Shipped to Spain in July 1938 and coded 3-127, this aircraft is camouflaged in olive-green patches over ochre-yellow. The thin 2 on a white disc on the wheel spats indicated 2-E-3.

30

CR.32ter NC 757 of Teniente José Larios Fernández, Escuadrilla 6-E-3, Grupo 3-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Mérida, September 1938

Shipped to Spain in November 1937 and coded 3-76, this aircraft was camouflaged in large olive-green patches over sand-yellow uppersurfaces. In September 1938, 3-G-3 was led by Comandante García Morato, its *Clavileño* emblem having been replaced by the *Patrulla Azul*. The white 6 on the black/white disc on the wheel spat indicated 6-E-3.

31

CR.32ter NC 753 of Capitán Julio Salvador Díaz Benjumea, leader of Escuadrilla 1-E-3, Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Escatrón, September-October 1938

Shipped to Spain in October 1937 and coded 3-69, this aircraft was camouflaged in olive-green patches over sand-yellow uppersurfaces in the summer of 1938. Salvador was shot down in it on 3 October 1938 during the battle of Ebro.

32

CR.32bis NC 613 of Capitano Giuseppe Majone, leader of 24^a Squadriglia, XVI Gruppo Caccia of Aviazione Legionaria, Caspe, December 1938

This aircraft had served in Spain since 1937. Its white triangular badge (and flag-staff!) indicated the aircraft's assignment to a *squadriglia* leader. The white oblique band on the rear fuselage acted as an additional command marking. It also has the *Cucaracha* XVI *Gruppo* emblem.

33

CR.32 of Alférez Joaquín Velasco Fernández Nespral, Escuadrilla 7-E-3, Grupo 3-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Escatrón, December 1938

One of the CR.32s previously in service within VI *Gruppo Caccia*, this aircraft joined the *Aviación Nacional* in late September 1938 when the *gruppo* disbanded. New camouflage of olive-green patches on ochre-yellow uppersurfaces was applied. The white arrow and number 7 on the wheel spats was 7-E-3's symbol.

34

CR.32quater NC 1011 of Teniente Abundio Cesteros García, Escuadrilla 8-E-3, Grupo Provisional 4-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Posadas, January 1939

Shipped to Spain in July 1938 and given the code 3-143, this fighter bore the Santiago cross (in red or black on a white shield) emblem of 8-E-3. This marking was inspired by the Galician origins of the *escuadrilla*'s first leader, Capitán José Pazó Montes. This cross also became the emblem of *Grupo Provisional* 4-G-3 when an *escuadrilla provisional* joined 8-E-3 in Extremadura in late 1938. The 8-E-3 symbol on the wheel spats took the form of an alpha-numerical and phonetic rebus, painted in white. *NO 8 DO* in Spanish means no-m(eh)a(s)deja-do, or 'you haven't abandoned me' – a phrase used by King Alfonso X in homage to the town of Seville for its fidelity during wars in the XIII Century.

35

CR.32 NC 931 of Capitán Manuel Vázquez Sagastizábal, leader of Escuadrilla 1-E-3 detached from Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Posadas, January 1939

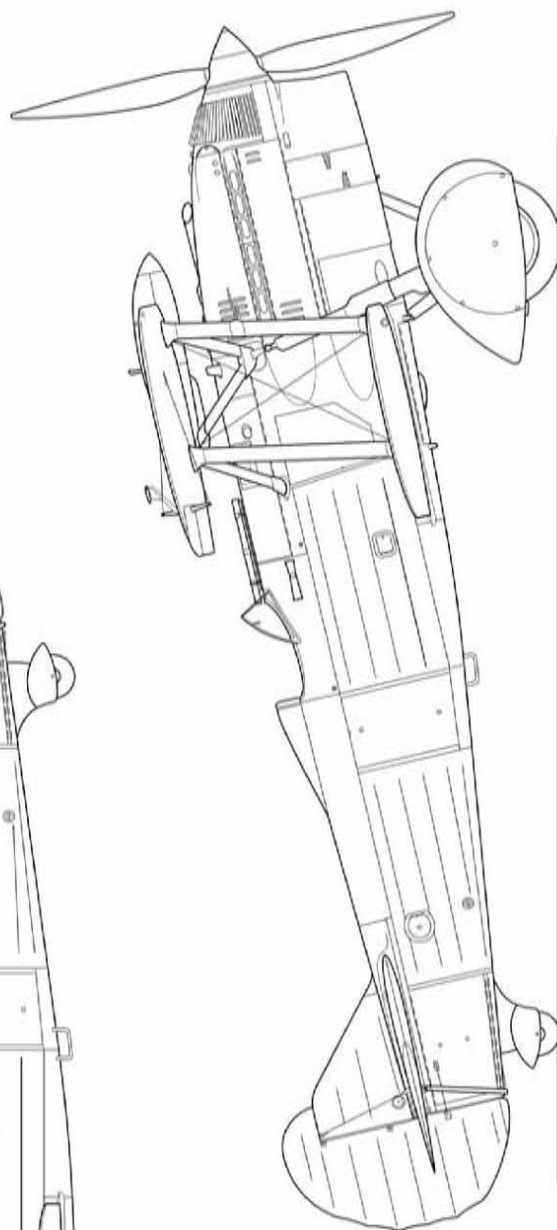
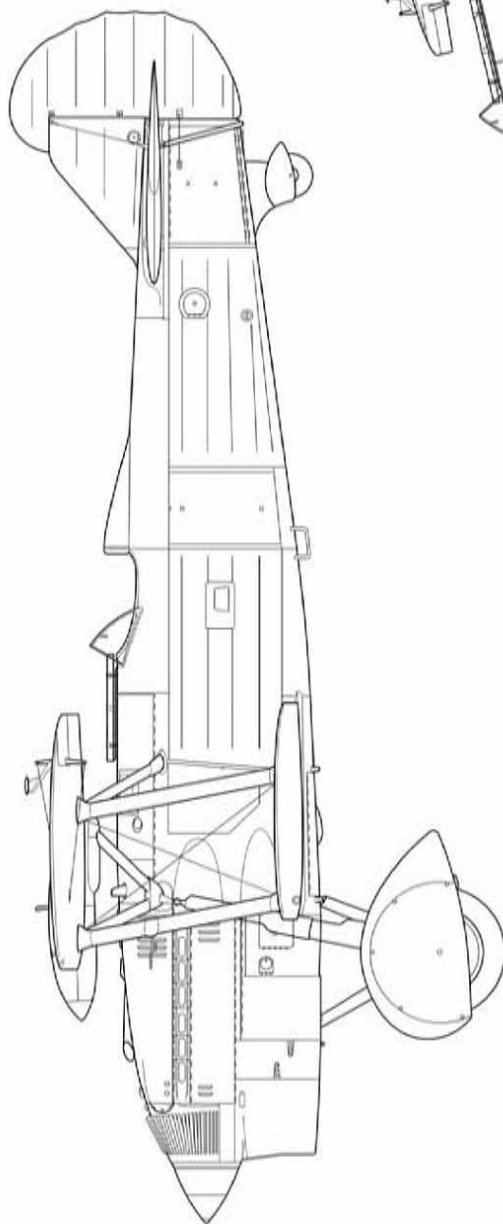
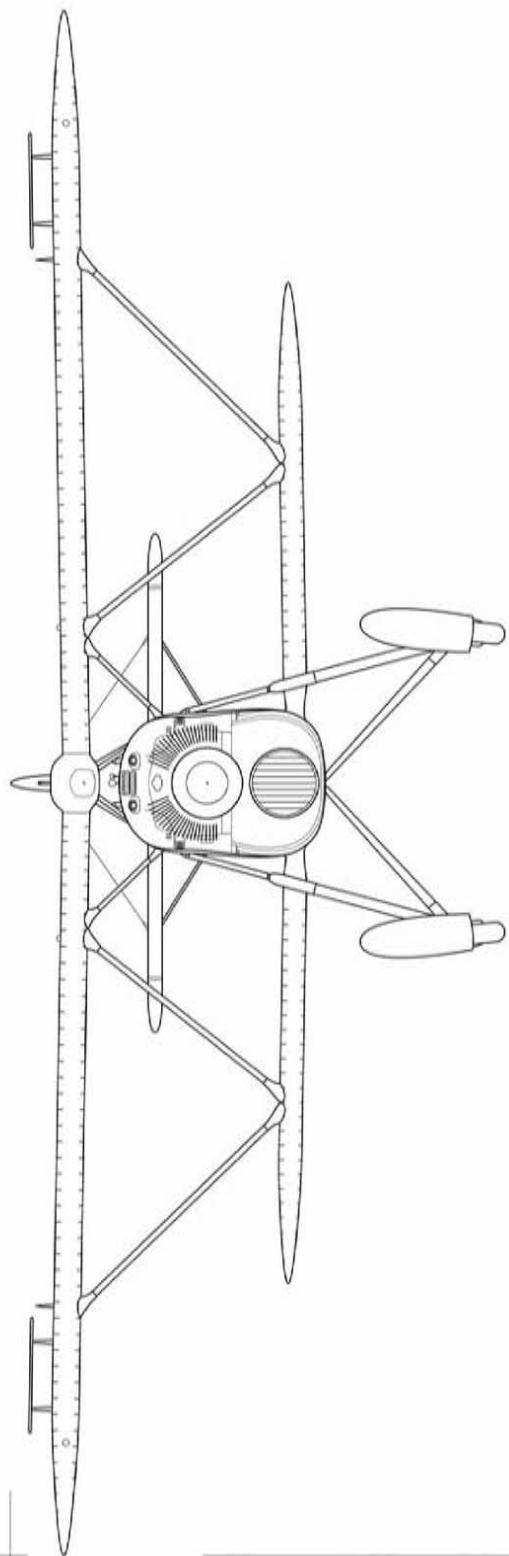
Shipped to Spain in April 1938 and given the code 3-118, NC 931 is camouflaged in shaded olive-green patches over ochre-yellow uppersurfaces. The number 1 on its wheel spats, indicating 1-E-3, has been replaced by a white linear profile of Giralda tower. The latter is a monument in Seville, where the *escuadrilla* was created. The word *Chica* to the left of the tower was the nickname of the *escuadrilla*'s 'godmother', Mercedes Delgado. Vázquez was shot down in this aircraft and killed over the Cordoba front on 23 January 1939.

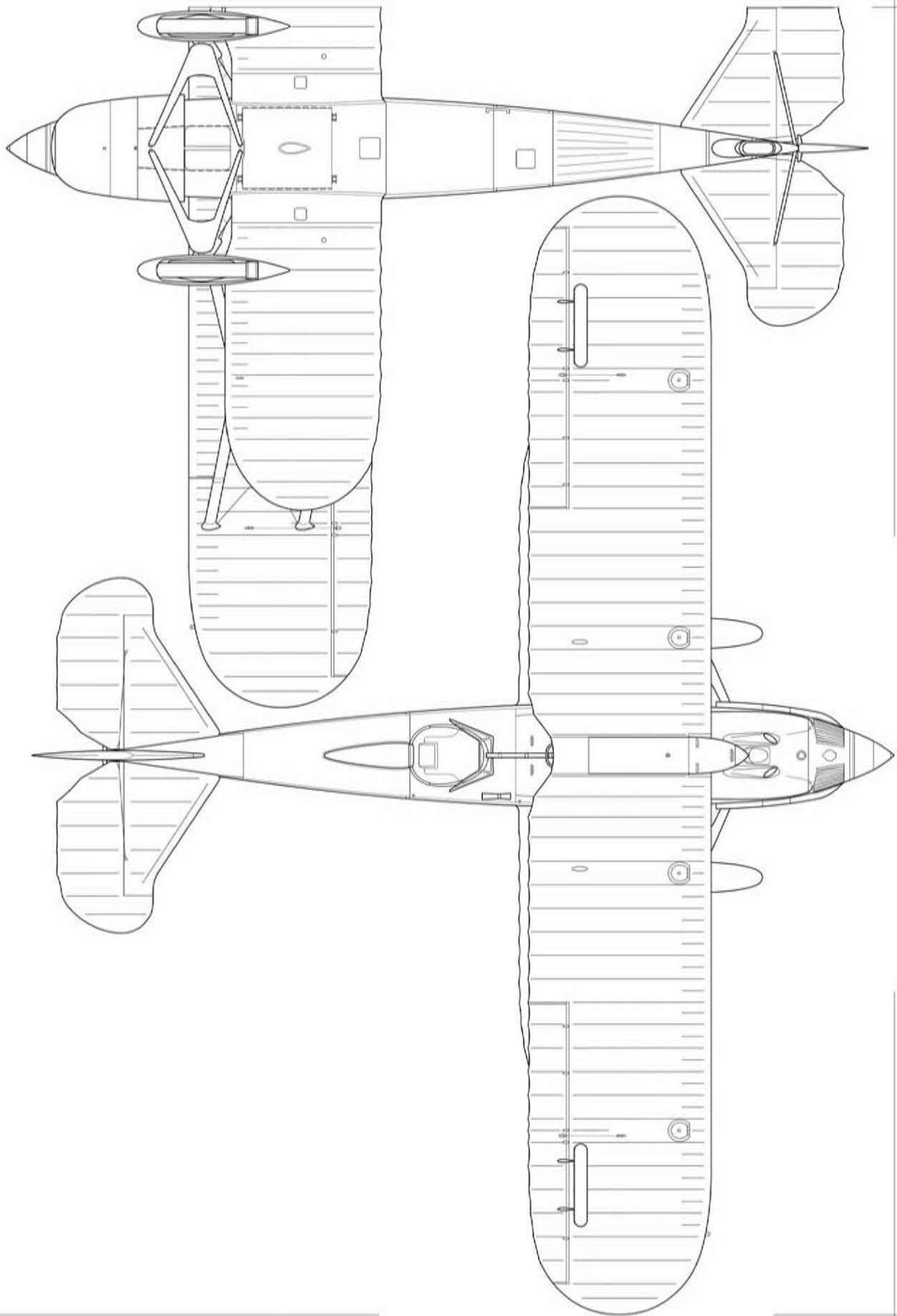
36

CR.32 NC 936 of Teniente Antonio Manrique Garrido, Escuadrilla 1-E-3 detached from Grupo 2-G-3 of Aviación Nacional, Posadas, January 1939

Shipped to Spain in April 1938, 3-123 flew over the Cordoba front. Manrique claimed his fourth victory in it on 23 January 1939 during the same action that resulted in the death of *Escuadrilla* leader Vázquez.

All drawings on this spread are
of a Fiat CR.32bis, and they are to
1/48th scale





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